

RAS Prelims 2026 · Handwritten Class Notes

Indian History

Chapter-by-chapter notes in coaching-lecture style — concept first, then the facts, with flow charts, mind maps, previous-year callouts and current-affairs links.

- IH01** Indus Valley Civilisation
- IH02** Vedic Age and the 6th Century BCE Religious Movements
- IH03** Mauryas and Post-Mauryan India
- IH04** Gupta, Post-Gupta and South Indian Dynasties
- IH05** Ancient Indian Art, Science and the Indian Knowledge & Value System
- IH06** Delhi Sultanate
- IH07** Mughal Empire and the Marathas
- IH08** Medieval Art, Architecture, Literature, Painting, Music; Bhakti & Sufi Movements
- IH09** British Expansion, Policies, 1857 and Socio-Religious Reform
- IH10** Freedom Struggle (1885-1947) and Nation Building to 2000

RPSC RAS & RTS Preliminary Examination · 6 December 2026 · 150 questions · 200 marks · 1/3 negative marking

IH01

Indus Valley Civilisation

About 2-3 questions a paper from Indian History's 10-12. Kalibangan alone has come up again and again - 2013 (river), 2021 (excavator), and inside statement sets. Learn the site table cold and you have banked the marks.

Our first city-dwellers. For the exam this chapter is almost pure matching - which site, which river, which district, which excavator, which one famous find. And because Kalibangan sits in Hanumangarh, RPSC treats this as half a Rajasthan chapter.

Indus / Harappan Civilisation

Big five sites

- Harappa - Ravi - Daya Ram Sahni 1921
- Mohenjodaro - Indus - R.D. Banerji 1922
- Kalibangan - Ghaggar - B.B. Lal & B.K. Thapar
- Lothal - Bhogavo - S.R. Rao
- Dholavira - Kutch - R.S. Bisht

Material life

- Copper, bronze, gold, silver, lead - NO iron
- Steatite seals, unicorn commonest
- Chert weights, binary below 16
- World's first cotton

Rajasthan angle

- Kalibangan, Hanumangarh district
- Ghaggar = Saraswati
- Earliest ploughed field
- Seven fire altars
- Camel bones, bangle factory

Belief & burial

- Mother goddess, Pashupati seal
- Pipal, humped bull, swastika
- Cemetery R-37 and H at Harappa
- No temple anywhere

Town planning

- Grid streets at right angles
- Citadel west, lower town east
- Bricks 4:2:1
- Covered drains, manholes, soak-pits

Decline theories

- Wheeler - Aryan invasion
- Marshall / Rao / Raikes - floods
- Gurdip Singh - aridity
- G.F. Dales - tectonic shift

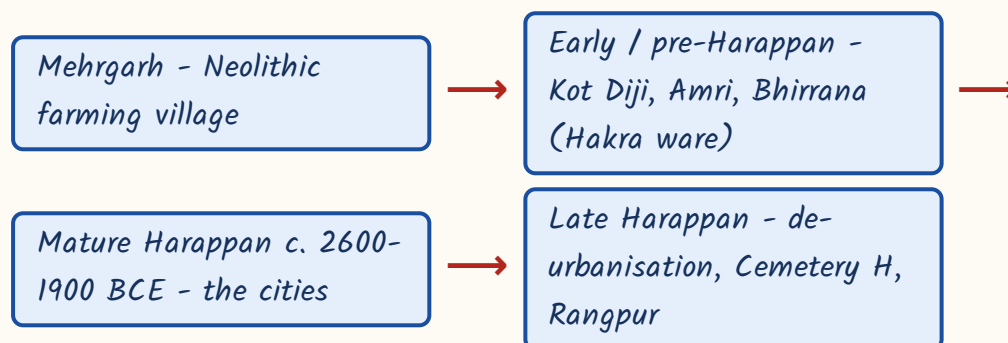
First fix the frame - who found it, when, and how big it was

Before 1921 Indian history textbooks began with the Vedas. Then two men digging in Punjab and Sindh pushed our past back by more than a thousand years. Daya Ram Sahni dug Harappa in 1921. R.D. Banerji reached Mohenjodaro in 1922. Both worked under John Marshall, then Director-General of the Archaeological Survey. The civilisation takes its name from Harappa because that is where the spade went in first.

Remember the naming logic - it is asked. It is called the Harappan civilisation after the first site excavated, and the Indus Valley civilisation after the river system. Neither name is wrong.

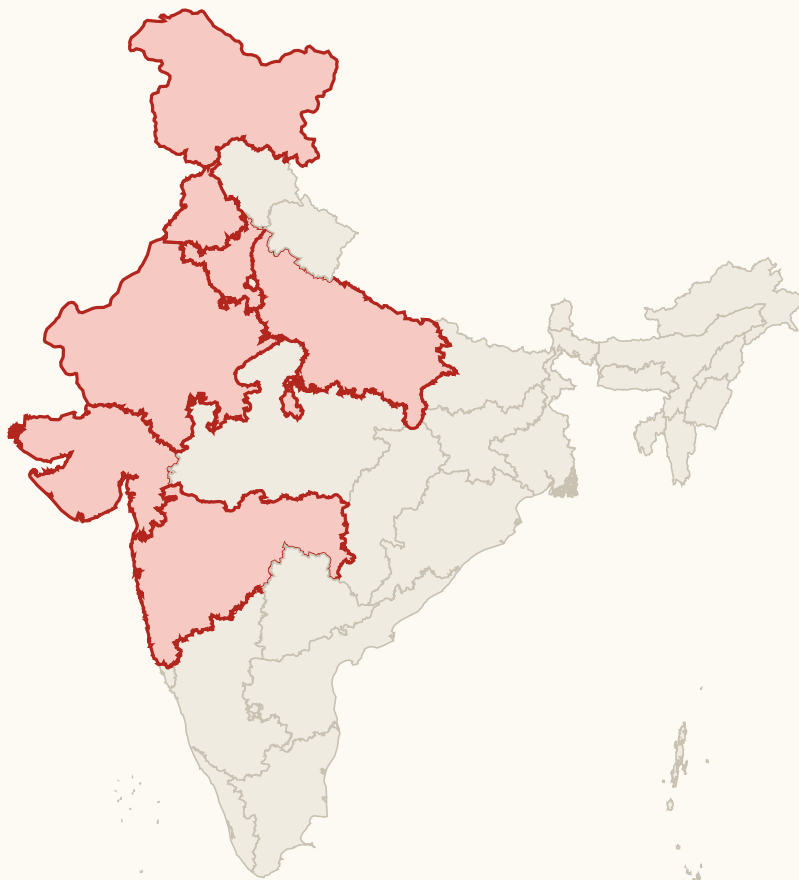
- Mature or urban phase: c. 2600-1900 BCE. The older ASI dating you will still see in books is 2500-1750 BCE.
- It is a Bronze Age civilisation - copper and bronze were known, iron was not.
- Roughly triangular in shape, and the largest in area of the four early river-valley civilisations.
- Mehrgarh near the Bolan pass in Balochistan is the Neolithic ancestor - earliest wheat and barley, and the earliest cotton in the subcontinent.
- Kot Diji (dug by Fazal Ahmed Khan) and Amri are early or pre-Harappan; Bhirrana in Fatehabad has the earliest Hakra-ware levels.

The cultural sequence - learn it as a ladder



YAAD RAKHO

Four boundary sites, four directions. Sutkagendor is West (Dasht river, Balochistan). Alamgirpur is East (Hindon, Meerut). Manda is North (Chenab, Jammu). Daimabad is South (Pravara, Maharashtra). Say it as W-E-N-S: Sutkagendor, Alamgirpur, Manda, Daimabad.

Indian states holding major Harappan sites

Manda north, Alamgirpur east, Daimabad south, the core cities are in Pakistan

The site table - this is where the marks actually are

Nothing in this chapter pays like the site table. RPSC's favourite format is List-I sites against List-II rivers, or against excavators, or against one famous find. So learn each site as a four-part packet: river, district and state, excavator, and the one thing it is famous for. Do not learn paragraphs. Learn packets.

Site - river - location - excavator (learn all four columns)

Site	River	District / State	Excavated by
Harappa	Ravi	Montgomery (Sahiwal), Pakistan	Daya Ram Sahni, 1921
Mohenjodaro	Indus	Larkana, Sindh	R.D. Banerji, 1922
Kalibangan	Ghaggar (Saraswati)	Hanumangarh, Rajasthan	B.B. Lal and B.K. Thapar, 1961-69
Lothal	Bhogavo	Ahmedabad, Gujarat	S.R. Rao, 1955-62
Dholavira	Khadir Bet island	Kutch, Gujarat	R.S. Bisht, 1989-2005
Chanhudaro	Indus	Sindh, Pakistan	N.G. Majumdar 1931; Ernest Mackay 1935-36
Banawali	Dried Saraswati bed	Fatehabad, Haryana	R.S. Bisht, 1973-74
Rakhigarhi	Drishadvati / Chautang bed	Hisar, Haryana	Amarendra Nath; later Vasant Shinde
Ropar (Rupnagar)	Sutlej	Rupnagar, Punjab	Y.D. Sharma, 1953
Surkotada	-	Kutch, Gujarat	J.P. Joshi
Sutkagendor	Dasht	Balochistan, Pakistan	Westernmost site
Alamgirpur	Hindon	Meerut, Uttar Pradesh	Easternmost site
Manda	Chenab	Jammu	Northernmost site
Daimabad	Pravara	Ahmednagar, Maharashtra	Southernmost site

Site - the one find it is famous for

Site	The famous find
Mohenjodaro	Great Bath, Great Granary, Pashupati seal, bronze Dancing Girl, steatite Priest-King, shell scale
Harappa	Cemetery R-37 and Cemetery H; two rows of six granaries with circular brick working-floors
Kalibangan	Earliest ploughed field in the subcontinent; seven fire altars; camel bones; bangle factory
Lothal	Dockyard; rice husk; Persian Gulf seal; double burial; bead factory; ivory scale
Dholavira	Three-part town; giant water reservoirs; the ten-sign 'signboard'
Chanhudaro	The only major city with no citadel; bead-makers' workshop; inkpot; lipstick
Banawali	Terracotta model of a plough; barley; radial street pattern
Rakhigarhi	Largest Harappan site found inside India
Ropar	First Harappan site excavated after independence; a dog buried with a human
Surkotada	The much-debated horse bones; pot burials
Daimabad	The bronze chariot group

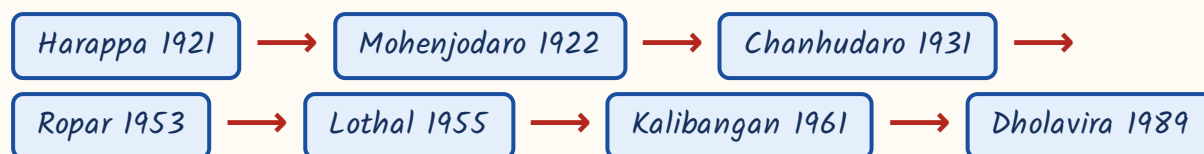
- Rakhigarhi is in HISAR district, not Fatehabad - Fatehabad holds Banawali and Bhirrana.
- Banawali is in Haryana, not Gujarat, even though it always appears in a list beside Lothal, Dholavira and Surkotada.
- Kalibangan is the only Harappan site of Rajasthan that RPSC asks about by name; Baror in Sri Ganganagar and Sothi in Bikaner are the supporting names.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2013 - the Harappan site of Kalibangan stands on the bank of which river? Answer: the Ghaggar. The same paper also ran a site-to-excavator matching set (Lothal - S.R. Rao, Harappa - Daya Ram Sahni, Dholavira - R.S. Bisht, Mohenjodaro - R.D. Banerji).

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023 - Surkotada in Kutch, the site of the much-debated horse bones, was excavated by J.P. Joshi. The same year the paper asked who excavated Dholavira - R.S. Bisht.

Order of first excavation - asked as an ordering question**Kalibangan - do this one site twice as carefully**

Kalibangan is your home site. It sits in Hanumangarh district on the left bank of the dried-up Ghaggar, which most scholars identify with the Vedic Saraswati. The name itself means black bangles, from the broken bangle pieces lying over the mounds. RPSC has asked its river, its district, its excavator and its finds, and it also slips Kalibangan into statement-based sets where all three statements are true.

- Excavated by B.B. Lal and B.K. Thapar between 1961 and 1969.
- Earliest evidence anywhere in the subcontinent of a ploughed agricultural field - furrows crossing at right angles, in the pre-Harappan level.
- A row of seven fire altars on a mud-brick platform in the citadel - evidence of ritual fire.
- Camel bones, and a bangle factory.
- Burials include an extended north-south burial, plus pot burials and symbolic burials.
- Kalibangan's lower town was also fortified, which is not true of most Harappan cities.
- The Kalibangan finds are displayed at the ASI's Archaeological Museum at Kalibangan itself.
- Fire altars are reported from three sites - Kalibangan, Lothal and Banawali - but the row of SEVEN on a platform, and the ploughed field, are Kalibangan alone.
- Do not hand Kalibangan the ten-sign signboard; that belongs to Dholavira.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2021 - Kalibangan was excavated under the direction of B.B. Lal and B.K. Thapar. RPSC has also run the three-statement version: ploughed field, seven fire altars, Ghaggar-Saraswati - all three correct.

YAAD RAKHO

Kalibangan = KAL. K for Krishi (the ploughed field), A for Agni (the fire altars), L for Left bank of the Ghaggar. And the district begins with H - Hanumangarh.

Kalibangan vs Lothal - the two sites examiners deliberately mix

Kalibangan	Lothal
Hanumangarh, Rajasthan	Ahmedabad, Gujarat
Ghaggar (Saraswati)	Bhogavo
B.B. Lal and B.K. Thapar	S.R. Rao
Ploughed field, seven fire altars	Dockyard, rice husk, bead factory
Camel bones, bangle factory	Persian Gulf seal, ivory scale
Extended north-south burial	Double burial (man and woman together)

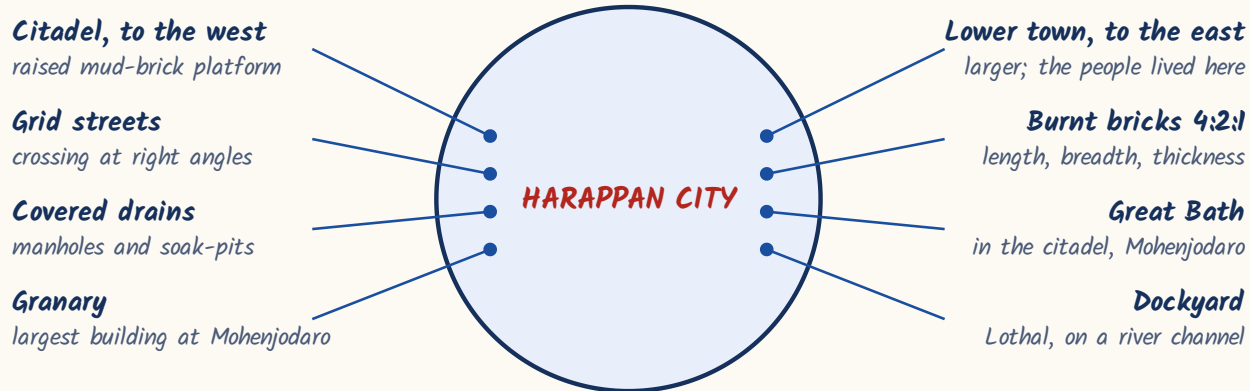
CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - Rakhigarhi has taken over as the headline Harappan dig. A PIB release of 22 June 2026 records that three complete skeletons and other skeletal fragments from Rakhigarhi were handed to the Anthropological Survey of India for ancient-DNA, isotopic and osteological study at its Kolkata laboratory; the 2025-26 season had opened eight burials on Mound 7. Rakhigarhi is described there as the largest known settlement of the Indus-Saraswati civilisation.

Town planning - the thing that made them a civilisation

What makes the Harappans remarkable is not any single building. It is the planning. Streets cut each other at right angles in a grid, the same grid at sites a thousand kilometres apart. The town splits in two - a raised citadel to the west for public buildings, and a lower town to the east where people lived. And the drains. Every Harappan city had covered brick drains running under the streets with manholes for cleaning and soak-pits at the end. No ancient civilisation matched that sanitation.

Plan of a Harappan city



- Grid layout - streets and lanes crossing at right angles, dividing the town into rectangular blocks.
- Citadel on a raised mud-brick platform to the west; lower town, larger and lower, to the east.
- Burnt bricks in the fixed ratio 4:2:1 - length to breadth to thickness - across the whole civilisation.
- House doors opened on to side lanes, not on to the main street. Windows were few and small.
- Every house had a bathroom connected to the street drain; wells were common.
- Chanhudaro is the exception with no citadel; Dholavira is the exception with three parts instead of two - citadel, middle town and lower town.
- Keep the rivers straight - Mohenjodaro is on the Indus, Harappa on the Ravi. Examiners swap those two routinely.

The famous structures and where they are

Structure	Site	Point to remember
Great Bath	Mohenjodaro	About 11.88 x 7.01 m, 2.43 m deep, made watertight with bitumen; inside the citadel
Great Granary	Mohenjodaro	The largest single structure at the site

Structure	Site	Point to remember
Granaries, two rows of six	Harappa	With circular brick working-floors near by
Dockyard	Lothal	Brick-built basin, connected to a river channel
Water reservoirs	Dholavira	The most elaborate water-harvesting system of any Harappan site

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - Dholavira was inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List in 2021 and remains the only Harappan site of India on that list. Expect it in any 'Indian sites on the World Heritage list' question.

Seals, script, weights - the small objects that get asked

Seals are the signature object of this civilisation - more than two thousand of them. Most are square, made of steatite, and carry a line of picture-signs on top with an animal engraved below. They were probably used to stamp bales of goods. Understand that, then memorise the small facts.

- Material: mostly steatite. Shape: usually square, with a boss at the back.
- The unicorn - a one-horned animal - is by far the commonest device. The cow is absent.
- The Pashupati or proto-Shiva seal, from Mohenjodaro, shows a three-faced figure seated cross-legged among animals.
- The Persian Gulf seal from Lothal is the direct evidence for overseas trade.
- The script is pictographic and still undeciphered. It runs boustrophedon - the first line right to left, the next left to right.
- The longest inscription is the ten-sign 'signboard' at Dholavira.
- Weights are of chert, cubical, without markings. Binary in the lower denominations - 1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64 - and decimal above that.
- Measuring scales: an ivory scale from Lothal, a shell scale from Mohenjodaro.

TRAP

The Indus script is NOT deciphered, and it is NOT an early form of Sanskrit. Any statement that says otherwise is your wrong option. Also - the script is pictographic, not alphabetic.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - in early February 2025 the Tamil Nadu government announced a prize of one million US dollars for anyone who deciphers the Indus script. It is still unclaimed. Useful as a current-affairs peg for the plain fact that the script remains undeciphered.

Economy - farming, crafts, metals and trade

They were farmers first and traders second. Wheat and barley were the staples; the ploughed field at Kalibangan and the terracotta plough model at Banawali show how the fields were worked. Rice husk turns up at Lothal. And one first belongs to them alone - cotton.

The Harappan economy



- The Harappans were the first people in the world to produce cotton. The Greeks later called Indian cotton Sindon, after the Sindhu.
- Metals used: copper, bronze (copper plus tin), gold, silver and lead. Iron was completely unknown.
- Copper came mainly from Khetri in Rajasthan; the Aravalli belt supplied the metal.
- Craft evidence: bead factories at Lothal and Chanhudaro, a bangle factory at Kalibangan, shell working, faience, and pottery that is mostly wheel-made red ware with black painting.
- The bronze Dancing Girl was cast by the lost-wax (cire perdue) process, at Mohenjodaro. The bronze chariot group is from Daimabad.
- The domesticated animals include the humped bull, buffalo, sheep, goat, pig, dog, cat and elephant. The horse is the disputed one - only the Surkotada report claims it.

Trade names - a straight matching set

Name in Mesopotamian records	Region it means
Meluha	The Indus region itself
Dilmun	Bahrain
Magan	The Makran / Oman coast
Shortughai (Afghanistan)	Source of lapis lazuli

YAAD RAKHO

Trade route from far to near: Meluha - Magan - Dilmun - Mesopotamia. India, then Oman, then Bahrain, then Iraq. Learn it as a west-bound chain and the matching question solves itself.

TRAP

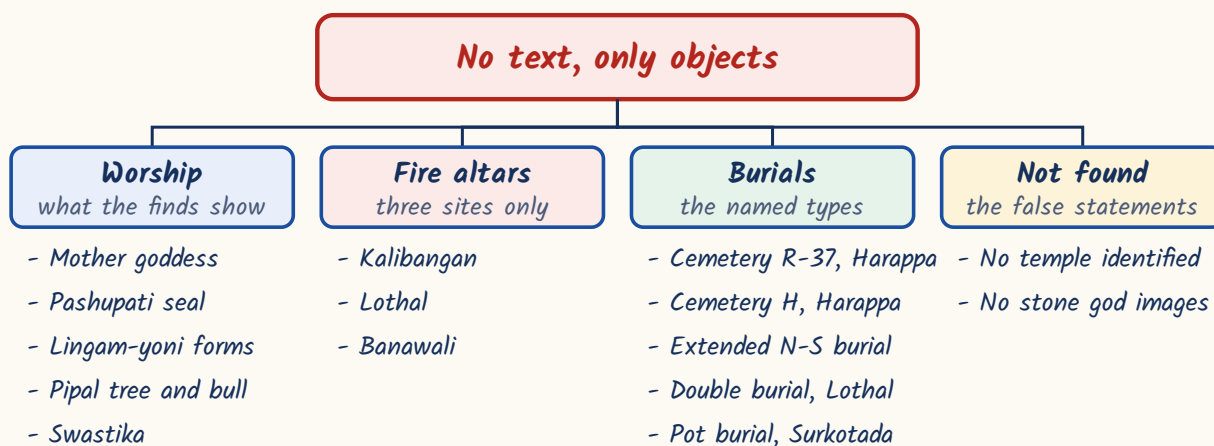
No iron. None. If any statement about Harappan metallurgy mentions iron tools from Mohenjodaro or Harappa, that statement is false - and RPSC has used exactly that statement inside a three-part set.

Religion and burial - and the temple question

We have no Harappan text, so religion is read off objects. Terracotta female figurines are taken as mother-goddess worship. The Pashupati seal is read as a proto-Shiva. Stone rings and cones are read as yoni and lingam worship. Trees, especially the pipal, and animals, especially the humped bull, appear again and again. And the swastika appears on seals.

- Objects of worship: mother goddess figurines, the proto-Shiva Pashupati seal, lingam-yoni forms, the pipal tree, the humped bull, the swastika.
- No structure at any Harappan site has been positively identified as a temple. No large stone images of gods either.
- Fire altars are reported from Kalibangan, Lothal and Banawali.
- Burial types: Cemetery R-37 and Cemetery H at Harappa; extended north-south burial at Kalibangan; double burial at Lothal; pot burial at Surkotada; a dog buried with a human at Ropar.
- Statement sets love this pair - 'stone images of gods were installed in Harappan temples' is false; 'no structure has been positively identified as a temple' is true.

Harappan religion - read off the objects



Decline - four theories, four names

The cities were abandoned by about 1900 BCE. Nobody knows why for certain, so the exam does not ask for the cause - it asks who proposed which theory. That is a pure matching question and you should never lose it.

Decline theory to scholar

Theory	Proposed by
Aryan invasion	Mortimer Wheeler
Recurrent floods	John Marshall, S.R. Rao, R.L. Raikes
Increasing aridity / climate change	Gurdip Singh
Tectonic disturbance	George F. Dales
Drying up of the Ghaggar-Saraswati	Widely held; explains the Rajasthan and Haryana abandonments

One more thing worth saying out loud. Decline did not mean disappearance.

Late Harappan cultures continue - Cemetery H at Harappa, Rangpur in Gujarat, and in Rajasthan the Ghaggar valley settlements thin out and shift. What ends is the city, not the people.

REVISION RECAP

1. Harappa 1921 Daya Ram Sahni on the Ravi; Mohenjodaro 1922 R.D. Banerji on the Indus; both under John Marshall.
2. Mature phase c. 2600-1900 BCE; Bronze Age; largest in area of the early civilisations.
3. Kalibangan - Ghaggar, Hanumangarh, B.B. Lal and B.K. Thapar, ploughed field, seven fire altars, camel bones, bangle factory.
4. Lothal - Bhogavo, Ahmedabad, S.R. Rao, dockyard, rice husk, Persian Gulf seal, double burial, ivory scale.
5. Dholavira - Kutch, R.S. Bisht, three-part town, reservoirs, ten-sign signboard, UNESCO 2021.
6. Chanhudaro - no citadel; beads, inkpot, lipstick. Banawali - Fatehabad, terracotta plough. Rakhigarhi - Hisar, largest in India.
7. Ropar - Sutlej, Y.D. Sharma 1953, first dig after independence, dog buried with a human.
8. Boundary sites W-E-N-S: Sutkagendor, Alamgirpur, Manda, Daimabad.
9. Mehrgarh - Neolithic, earliest wheat, barley and cotton. Kot Diji and Amri - pre-Harappan. Bhirrana - earliest Hakra ware.
10. Grid streets, citadel west on a platform, lower town east, covered drains with manholes; bricks 4:2:1; doors on side lanes.

11. Great Bath 11.88 x 7.01 m, 2.43 m deep, bitumen-sealed, inside the Mohenjodaro citadel; Great Granary the largest structure there.
12. Seals steatite and square, unicorn commonest; script pictographic, undeciphered, boustrophedon.
13. Weights of chert, binary up to 64 then decimal; ivory scale Lothal, shell scale Mohenjodaro.
14. Metals copper, bronze, gold, silver, lead - iron unknown. First cotton in the world; Greek name Sindon.
15. Meluha = Indus, Dilmun = Bahrain, Magan = Makran/Oman, lapis lazuli from Shortughai.
16. Religion - mother goddess, Pashupati, lingam-yoni, pipal, humped bull, swastika; no temple identified anywhere.
17. Fire altars at three sites: Kalibangan, Lothal, Banawali.
18. Decline - Wheeler (invasion), Marshall/Rao/Raikes (floods), Gurdip Singh (aridity), Dales (tectonics), plus the drying Ghaggar.
19. Excavation order for the ordering question: Harappa, Mohenjodaro, Chanhudaro, Ropar, Lothal, Kalibangan, Dholavira.

IH02

Vedic Age and the 6th Century BCE Religious

Movements

Two to three questions a paper, and the pool is small and repeats. Mahajanapadas from the Anguttara Nikaya and from Panini (2013, 2016), Ajivika niyati (2013 and again 2024), Jain Anekantavada and Syadvada (2021), Matsya capital Viratnagar (2016). Note the Rajasthan hooks - Matsya, Shivi and the Malavas.

Two blocks in one chapter. First the Vedic texts and the society they describe, then the sixth-century BCE churn that produced Jainism, Buddhism and the Ajivikas. RPSC's taste here is precise and textual - which mandala, which Brahmana belongs to which Veda, which Mahajanapada had which capital, which teacher taught niyati.

Vedic Age & the 6th Century BCE

The four Vedas

- Rigveda - 10 mandalas, 1028 hymns
- Samaveda - musical chants
- Yajurveda - sacrificial formulae, part prose
- Atharvaveda - charms, the Brahmvada

Later Vedic literature

- Brahmanas - ritual prose
- Aranyakas - forest texts
- Upanishads - philosophy
- Six Vedangas

Society & polity

- Sabha, Samiti, Vidatha, Gana
- Purohita, Senani, Gramani, Vrajapati
- Varna from the Purusha Sukta
- Early = cattle & gavishti; Later = iron, PGW, big sacrifices

Mahajanapadas

- 16 in the Anguttara Nikaya & Bhagavati Sutra
- Panini's Ashtadhyayi - Yaudheyas, Salvas
- Matsya - Viratnagar (Bairat)
- Shivi - Madhyamika (Nagari)

Rise of Magadha

- Haryanka - Bimbisara, Ajatashatru, Udayin
- Shishunaga
- Nanda - Mahapadma, Dhana Nanda
- Maurya

Heterodox sects

- Jainism - Mahavira, Triratna, Anekantavada
- Buddhism - four truths, eightfold path, 4 councils
- Ajivika - Makkhali Gosala, niyati
- Charvaka materialism; Sanjaya's Ajnana

The four Vedas - learn each by its one-line identity

Start with the simplest possible handle. Each Veda has one identity, and that identity is what gets matched. Rigveda is hymns of praise. Samaveda is music. Yajurveda is the formulae you mutter while performing the sacrifice. Atharvaveda is charms and spells - the folk religion. Fix those four and the matching question is done.

Veda - content - the fact that gets asked

Veda	Principal content	Remember
Rigveda	Hymns of praise	10 mandalas, 1028 hymns (1017 + 11 Valakhilya); oldest text

Veda	Principal content	Remember
Samaveda	Musical chants	The earliest source of Indian music
Yajurveda	Sacrificial formulae	The only Veda partly in prose; Shukla (Vajasaneyi) and Krishna (Taittiriya) branches
Atharvaveda	Charms, spells, popular belief	Also called the Brahmaveda; recensions Shaunaka and Paippalada

- Mandalas II to VII are the 'family books' and are the oldest; mandalas I and X are the latest additions.
- Mandala IX is devoted entirely to Soma.
- The Gayatri mantra is in Mandala III, addressed to the solar deity Savitri, and ascribed to Vishvamitra.
- The Purusha Sukta (Rigveda X.90) carries the earliest reference to the four varnas.
- The Nadistuti Sukta of Mandala X lists the rivers.
- Sindhu is the river named most often; Saraswati is called naditama, best of rivers. Ganga occurs once, Yamuna thrice.

YAAD RAKHO

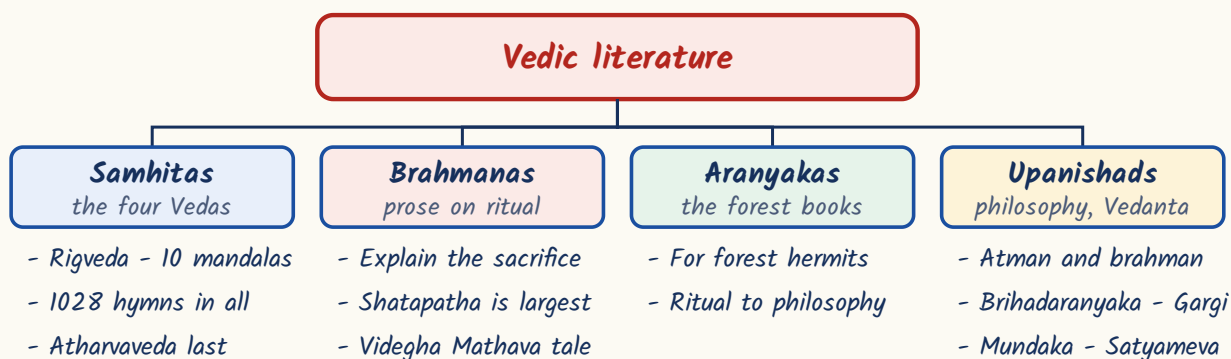
Number the special mandalas - 3 for Gayatri, 9 for Soma, 10 for both the Purusha Sukta and the Nadistuti. Three, nine, ten. And the oldest core is 2 to 7.

One event from the Rigveda is asked by name. The Battle of Ten Kings, the Dasharajna, was fought on the Parushni - the modern Ravi. Sudas of the Bharatas won it, with the priest Vasishtha on his side, against a confederacy backed by Vishvamitra.

Brahmanas, Aranyakas, Upanishads, Vedangas

After the Vedas came layers of commentary. Brahmanas explain the ritual in prose. Aranyakas are the 'forest books' for those who withdrew from village life. Upanishads are philosophy - atman, brahman, karma, rebirth. The Vedangas are the six technical limbs you need in order to use the Vedas correctly.

The layers of Vedic literature



Brahmana to Veda - a standing matching question

Brahmana	Attached to
Aitareya, Kaushitaki	Rigveda
Panchavimsha (Tandya), Jaiminiya	Samaveda
Shatapatha - the largest of them all	Shukla Yajurveda
Taittiriya	Krishna Yajurveda
Gopatha	Atharvaveda

- The Shatapatha Brahmana tells of Videgha Mathava's eastward migration to the Sadanira (Gandak) - our evidence for Vedic culture spreading into the middle Ganga plain.
- Brihadaranyaka and Chandogya are the oldest Upanishads.
- 'Satyameva Jayate' below the State Emblem of India comes from the Mundaka Upanishad.
- Yajnavalkya's dialogues with Gargi and with Maitreyi are in the Brihadaranyaka Upanishad.

The six Vedangas

Vedanga	Subject	Associated name
Shiksha	Phonetics	-
Kalpa	Ritual	-
Vyakarana	Grammar	Panini's Ashtadhyayi
Nirukta	Etymology	Yaska
Chhanda	Metrics	Pingala
Jyotisha	Astronomy	-

- The negative-framed question here is always a Vedanga mismatch - Chhanda is metrics, NOT etymology; Nirukta is etymology and it is Yaska's.
- Aranyakas sit between the Brahmanas and the Upanishads and are meant for forest-dwelling students, not for householders.

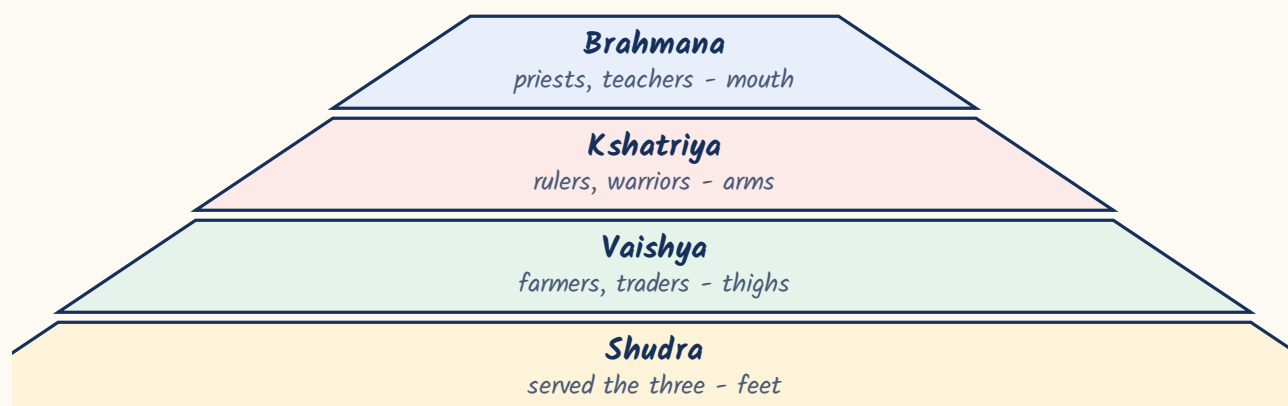
Early Vedic against Later Vedic - the comparison that answers half the questions

Almost every Vedic statement question is really asking, is this early or later. So build the contrast once and use it everywhere. Early Vedic is pastoral, tribal, Punjab-centred, no taxes, no rigid caste. Later Vedic is agricultural, territorial, Ganga-Yamuna doab-centred, with iron, big sacrifices and a hardening varna order.

Early Vedic (c. 1500–1000 BCE) vs Later Vedic (c. 1000–600 BCE)

Early Vedic	Later Vedic
Rigveda only	Later Vedas, Brahmanas, Aranyakas, Upanishads
Sapta-Sindhu, the Punjab region	Ganga-Yamuna doab and eastward
Pastoral - wealth counted in cattle	Agricultural - land becomes the wealth
Copper and bronze	Iron, called shyama ayas or krishna ayas
Ochre Coloured Pottery horizon	Painted Grey Ware (PGW)
Sabha, Samiti, Vidatha and Gana all active	Sabha and Samiti weaken; Vidatha disappears
No regular tax; bali a voluntary offering	Bali, bhaga and shulka become regular dues
Varna present but flexible	Varna hardens; the Shudra's position worsens
Simple household rituals	Rajasuya, ashvamedha, vajapeya - grand sacrifices

The varna order, as the Purusha Sukta puts it



- *Gavishti* - literally 'search for cows' - is the Rigvedic word for war. Cattle were the unit of wealth, and the king is called *gopati* or *gopa janasya*.
- Chief officials of the early period: *Purohita*, *Senani*, *Gramani* and *Vrajapati*.
- *Vidatha* is the OLDEST of the Vedic assemblies. *Sabha* and *Samiti* both appear in the *Rigveda*.
- The word *gotra* appears first in the *Atharvaveda*, not in the *Rigveda*.
- The four *ashramas* are listed in full only in later Vedic and post-Vedic texts.
- Early Vedic society had *varna* but NOT a rigid birth-based caste system with untouchability - that option is always false.
- Equally false for the early period: 'a regular system of taxation existed and *bali* was a compulsory levy'.

The sixteen Mahajanapadas - and the three Rajasthan entries

By the sixth century BCE north India had settled into sixteen large states. The list of sixteen comes from the Buddhist *Anguttara Nikaya* and from the Jain *Bhagavati Sutra* - so it is not a Buddhist list alone, and RPSC has tested exactly that point. *Panini's Ashtadhyayi*, a grammar, separately names a large number of *janapadas*, including the *Yaudheyas* and the *Salvas*, which are NOT among the sixteen.

Mahajanapada to capital - part I

Mahajanapada	Capital
Magadha	Girivraja / Rajagriha, later Pataliputra
Kosala	Shravasti
Kashi	Varanasi
Anga	Champa
Vatsa	Kaushambi
Avanti	Ujjain in the north, Mahishmati in the south

Mahajanapada	Capital
Vajji	Vaishali
Malla	Kushinara and Pava

Mahajanapada to capital - part 2

Mahajanapada	Capital
Matsya	Viratnagar - modern Bairat, Jaipur district
Surasena	Mathura
Gandhara	Taxila
Kamboja	Rajapura
Chedi	Shuktimati
Assaka	Potali
Kuru	Indraprastha
Panchala	Ahichhatra and Kampilya

The Rajasthan connection - RPSC will always take this exit

- Matsya Mahajanapada covered the Jaipur-Alwar-Bharatpur tract. Its capital Viratnagar is modern Bairat in Jaipur district - the same Bairat that later gave us Ashoka's edicts.
- The Shivi janapada had its capital at Madhyamika, modern Nagari near Chittorgarh.
- Malava coins have been found in very large numbers at Nagar in Tonk district.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2013 - the list of sixteen Mahajanapadas is given in the Anguttara Nikaya. RAS Pre 2016 - the capital of the Matsya Mahajanapada was Viratnagar.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2016 also ran the Panini set: Ashtadhyayi refers to many janapadas including the Yaudheyas and the Salvakas (true); the list of sixteen occurs only in Buddhist literature (false - the Jain Bhagavati Sutra has it too); Avanti had two capitals (true).

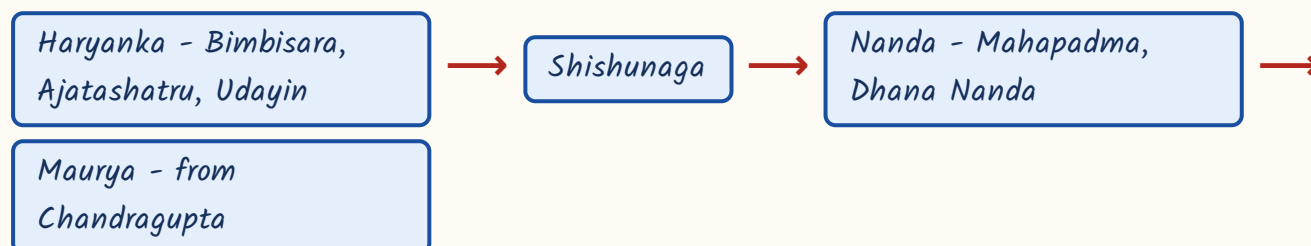
TRAP

Yaudheya is NOT one of the sixteen Mahajanapadas. It comes from Panini. RPSC has used it as the odd-one-out option, and it is tempting precisely because Rajasthan students know the name.

Rise of Magadha - the dynasty chain

Out of the sixteen, one state swallowed the rest. Magadha won because of geography and iron. It sat on the fertile middle Ganga plain, controlled the iron of south Bihar, had elephants from the forests, and its capitals - first Rajagriha ringed by hills, then Pataliputra at the meeting of the Ganga and the Son - were natural fortresses. Learn the reasons; they come as an assertion-reason or a statement set.

Magadhan dynasties in order - an ordering question every few years



- Bimbisara expanded by matrimonial alliances and annexed Anga.
- Ajatashatru fought the Vajjis using the rathamusala, a mace-fitted chariot, and the mahashilakantaka, a stone-throwing engine.
- Udayin founded Pataliputra at the Ganga-Son confluence.
- Mahapadma Nanda is called Ekarat and Sarvakshatrantaka - 'destroyer of all kshatriyas' - in the Puranas.
- Dhana Nanda was on the throne when Alexander invaded the north-west in 326 BCE; he was later overthrown by Chandragupta Maurya.

YAAD RAKHO

Ordering mnemonic for Magadha - Ha-Shi-Na-Mau. Haryanka, Shishunaga, Nanda, Maurya. The exam gives them jumbled; you just recite the four syllables.

Jainism - Mahavira, the vows, the doctrines, the councils

Jainism was not founded by Mahavira. He is the twenty-fourth Tirthankara; Parshvanatha was the twenty-third and lived about 250 years before him. Rishabhadeva, the first, is even mentioned in the Rigveda. Mahavira's work was to tighten and organise what already existed.

- Mahavira - born c. 540 BCE at Kundagrama near Vaishali. Father Siddhartha of the Jnatika clan, mother Trishala.
- He attained kaivalya, omniscience, at the age of 42 on the bank of the Rijupalika.
- He died at Pavapuri.
- Parshvanatha gave four vows - ahimsa, satya, asteya, aparigraha. Mahavira added the fifth, brahmacharya.
- Triratna, the three jewels: right faith, right knowledge, right conduct.
- Anekantavada - reality has many aspects. Syadvada - every judgement is only conditionally true, 'may be', expressed in a seven-fold predication.

Jain councils and the split

Council	Venue	Presided by	Outcome
First	Pataliputra	Sthulabhadra	The 12 Angas compiled
Second	Vallabhi	Devardhi Kshamashramana	The canon finally written down in Ardhamagadhi

- The sects: Digambara, the sky-clad, associated with Bhadrabahu; Shvetambara, the white-clad, associated with Sthulabhadra.
- Jain literature is in Prakrit, specifically Ardhamagadhi.
- Royal patrons include Chandragupta Maurya (Jain tradition), Kharavela of Kalinga, and the Chalukya and Ganga rulers of the south.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2021 - Anekantavada is the doctrine that reality has many aspects and Syadvada that every proposition is true only in a conditional sense; both are Jain, NOT Buddhist. That third statement was the trap.

TRAP

Bhadrabahu goes with the DIGAMBARA sect, Sthulabhadra with the Shvetambara. The wrong-pair question in this chapter is nearly always 'Bhadrabahu - Shvetambara'. Also note: the first Jain council at Pataliputra was under Sthulabhadra, not Bhadrabahu, because Bhadrabahu had gone south.

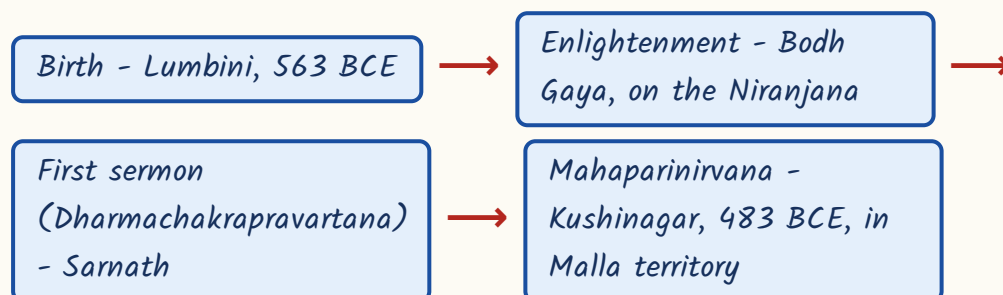
CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - on 3 October 2024 the Union Cabinet granted classical language status to Pali and Prakrit, along with Marathi, Bengali and Assamese. Pali is the language of the Buddhist Tripitaka and Ardhamagadhi Prakrit that of the Jain canon, so the decision is a ready-made hook for a question that pairs a language with a religious literature.

Buddhism - life, doctrine, councils, texts

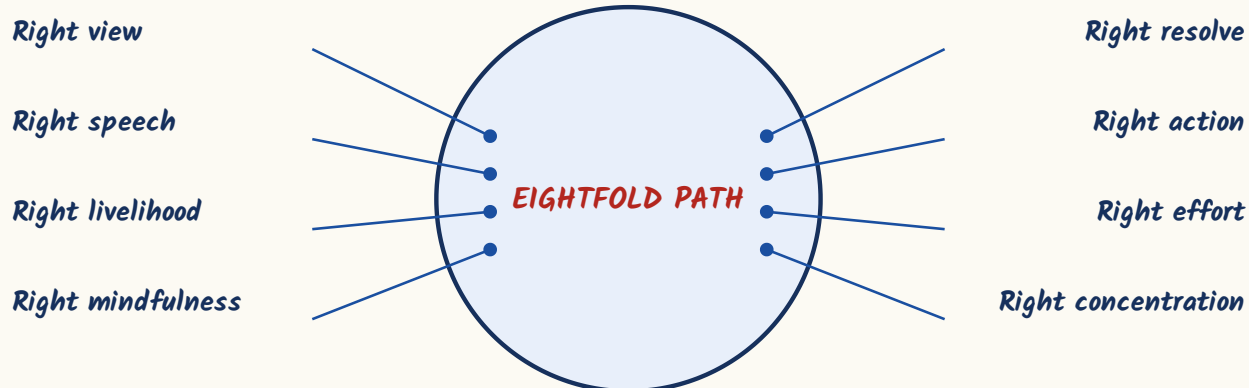
For the exam, Buddhism breaks into four blocks: the four places of the Buddha's life, the doctrine in its numbered form, the four councils, and the texts. Take them in that order and nothing overlaps.

The four great places of the Buddha's life

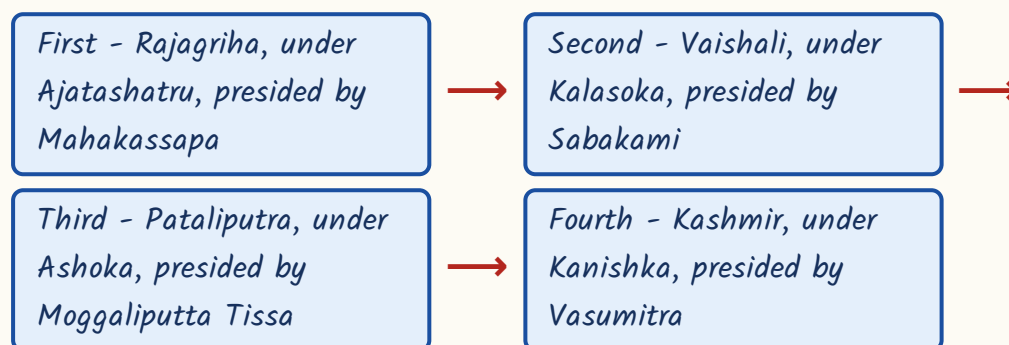


- Four Noble Truths: there is suffering; suffering has a cause; suffering can end; there is a path to ending it.
- The Eightfold Path (ashtangika marga): right view, right resolve, right speech, right action, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, right concentration.
- That path is the middle path - between sensual indulgence on one side and severe self-torture on the other.
- Buddhism denies the authority of the Vedas and the necessity of sacrifice, and it was preached in Pali, the people's language.
- The three jewels of Buddhism: Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha.

The Eightfold Path (ashtangika marga)



The four Buddhist councils - venue, patron, president



- The Third Council compiled the Abhidhamma Pitaka, the last of the three baskets.
- The Fourth Council in Kashmir produced the Mahavibhasha and marks the Hinayana-Mahayana split.
- Tripitaka - Vinaya Pitaka (monastic rules), Sutta Pitaka (sermons), Abhidhamma Pitaka (philosophy). All in Pali.
- The Jataka stories, tales of the Buddha's previous births, sit in the Khuddaka Nikaya of the Sutta Pitaka.
- The Milindapanho records the dialogue between the Indo-Greek king Menander (Milinda) and the monk Nagasena.
- Mahavamsa and Dipavamsa are the Buddhist chronicles of Sri Lanka, in Pali.
- Divyavadana is a SANSKRIT text and is not part of the Pali Tripitaka.

The Tripitaka - the three baskets



TRAP

The first council was at RAJAGRIHA under Ajatashatru, not at Vaishali. Vaishali is the second, under Kalasoka. RPSC has planted 'first council at Vaishali under Ajatashatru' inside a statement set - one clause right, one wrong.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - the Piprahwa gem relics, excavated in 1898 from a stupa near the Buddha's Shakya homeland, were put up for sale by Sotheby's Hong Kong in May 2025. India objected on legal and cultural grounds, the auction was halted, and the relics were handed back to India at the end of July 2025 - a repatriation after 127 years. A likely current-affairs hook that lands on this chapter's content.

Jainism against Buddhism - the classic comparison

Both were born in the same century, in the same region, out of the same discontent with Vedic ritual and brahmanical dominance. Both used the people's language, both rejected the Vedas, both admitted women and all varnas. What separates them is severity - Jainism goes to the extreme of ahimsa and austerity, Buddhism deliberately takes the middle path. Learn the differences, because the similarities are what makes the wrong options plausible.

Jainism vs Buddhism

Jainism	Buddhism
Mahavira, 24th Tirthankara; the faith is older	Gautama Buddha is the founder
Five vows, brahmacharya added by Mahavira	Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path
Extreme ahimsa and severe austerity; sallekhana	The middle path; austerity explicitly rejected
Accepts the soul (jiva) in everything, including matter	Denies a permanent soul (anatta)
Anekantavada and Syadvada	Pratityasamutpada - dependent origination
Language Ardhamagadhi Prakrit	Language Pali
Two councils - Pataliputra, Vallabhi	Four councils - Rajagriha, Vaishali, Pataliputra, Kashmir
Sects: Digambara and Shvetambara	Sects: Hinayana, Mahayana, later Vajrayana
Stayed within India; strong in Gujarat, Rajasthan, Karnataka	Spread across Asia; declined in India

One line to hold the whole contrast - Jainism says conquer the body, Buddhism says balance it. Every doctrinal difference in that table flows from it.

The other heterodox schools - small topic, disproportionate marks

Besides Mahavira and the Buddha there were four more famous teachers in the sixth century BCE. RPSC likes them because they are easy to confuse. The Ajivika question in particular is a documented repeat - it came in 2013 and came back in 2024.

Teacher to doctrine - learn this table as a unit

Teacher	School / doctrine	One-word handle
Makkhali Gosala	Ajivika - the doctrine of niyati, destiny	Fatalism
Purana Kassapa	Akriyavada - action has no moral consequence	Non-action

Teacher	School / doctrine	One-word handle
Ajita Kesakambalin	Materialism - man is made of the four elements	Materialism
Pakudha Kachchayana	Eternal indivisible categories	Atomism
Sanjaya Belatthiputta	Ajnana - knowledge of the ultimate is impossible	Scepticism
Brihaspati (traced to)	Charvaka / Lokayata materialism	Lokayata

Understand niyati before you memorise it. The Ajivikas held that everything is already fixed by destiny. Effort changes nothing; a soul simply runs its allotted course through births until release comes on its own. That is why Ajivika is labelled fatalism. The sect had real royal backing - Ashoka gave them cave dwellings in the Barabar hills and his grandson Dasharatha gave the Nagarjuni hill caves, which you will meet again in the Mauryan chapter.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2024, repeating 2013 - the doctrine of niyati or destiny was the central teaching of the Ajivika sect, founded by Makkhali Gosala. In 2013 the same fact came as a teacher-to-doctrine matching set with Ajita Kesakambalin (materialism), Pakudha Kachchayana (atomism) and Sanjaya Belatthiputta (scepticism).

REVISION RECAP

1. Rigveda - 10 mandalas, 1028 hymns; family books II-VII oldest; I and X latest; IX all Soma.
2. Gayatri in Mandala III to Savitri, by Vishvamitra; Purusha Sukta X.90 gives the four varnas; Nadistuti lists rivers.
3. Sindhu named most often; Saraswati is naditama; Ganga once, Yamuna thrice; Dasharajna on the Parushni, Sudas won.

4. Samaveda - music. Yajurveda - formulae, part prose, Shukla and Krishna. Atharvaveda - charms, the Brahmvveda.
5. Shatapatha is the largest Brahmana (Shukla Yajurveda) and carries the Videgha Mathava migration to the Sadanira.
6. Aitareya-Rigveda, Panchavimsha-Samaveda, Taittiriya-Krishna Yajurveda, Gopatha-Atharvaveda.
7. Satyameva Jayate from the Mundaka Upanishad; Brihadaranyaka and Chandogya oldest; Yajnavalkya-Gargi-Maitreyi in Brihadaranyaka.
8. Vedangas - Shiksha, Kalpa, Vyakarana (Panini), Nirukta (Yaska), Chhanda (Pingala), Jyotisha.
9. Early Vedic - pastoral, gavishti for war, Vidatha oldest assembly, bali voluntary, no untouchability.
10. Later Vedic - iron as shyama/krishna ayas, Painted Grey Ware, rajasuya-ashvamedha-vajapeya, gotra first in the Atharvaveda.
11. Sixteen Mahajanapadas listed in the Anguttara Nikaya and the Jain Bhagavati Sutra; Panini separately names the Yaudheyas and Salvas, which are not among the sixteen.
12. Rajasthan entries - Matsya, capital Viratnagar (Bairat, Jaipur); Shivi, capital Madhyamika (Nagari, Chittorgarh); Malava coins at Nagar, Tonk.
13. Avanti had two capitals - Ujjain and Mahishmati. Vajji - Vaishali. Vatsa - Kaushambi. Anga - Champa. Chedi - Shuktimati.
14. Magadha order: Haryanka, Shishunaga, Nanda, Maurya. Ajatashatru's rathamusala and mahashilakantaka; Udayin founded Pataliputra; Mahapadma Nanda = Ekarat and Sarvakshatrantaka; Dhana Nanda ruled at Alexander's invasion of 326 BCE.
15. Mahavira - Kundagrama near Vaishali, Jnatrika clan, kaivalya at 42 on the Rijupalika, died at Pavapuri; added brahmacharya.
16. Jain councils - Pataliputra under Sthulabhadra, Vallabhi under Devardhi Kshamashramana; Digambara-Bhadrabahu, Shvetambara-Sthulabhadra.
17. Buddha - Lumbini 563 BCE, Bodh Gaya, first sermon Sarnath, mahaparinirvana Kushinagar 483 BCE.
18. Councils - Rajagriha/Ajatashatru/Mahakassapa, Vaishali/Kalasoka/Sabakami, Pataliputra/Ashoka/Moggaliputta Tissa, Kashmir/Kanishka/Vasumitra.
19. Tripitaka in Pali; Jatakas in the Khuddaka Nikaya; Divyavadana is Sanskrit and outside the Tripitaka.
20. Makkhali Gosala - Ajivika, niyati. Purana Kassapa - akriyavada. Ajita Kesakambalin - materialism. Pakudha - atomism. Sanjaya - Ajnana.

IH03

Mauryas and Post-Mauryan India

Two to three questions a paper. The proven repeats are Bairat and the Bhabru edict (2024), the Barabar caves given to the Ajivikas (2013), and the Parkham yaksha with the Manibhadra inscription (2021). Chronological ordering questions come from this chapter more than any other in Indian History.

India's first pan-Indian empire, and then five hundred years of successor states. The Mauryan half is inscription-driven, which suits RPSC perfectly - edict to place to content. And because Ashoka left two records at Bairat in Jaipur district, this chapter carries a guaranteed Rajasthan angle.

Mauryas & Post-Mauryan India

Mauryan rulers

- Chandragupta c. 322 BCE, with Kautilya
- Bindusara - Amitraghata / Amitrochates
- Ashoka - acceded c. 268 BCE
- Brihadratha killed 185 BCE

Mauryan art

- Chunar sandstone, Mauryan polish
- Sarnath lion capital - State Emblem
- Barabar caves to the Ajivikas
- Parkham yaksha, Didarganj yakshi

Sources

- Arthashastra - 15 books, R. Shamasastri 1905
- Megasthenes' Indica - fragments
- Ashokan edicts - Brahmi, Kharoshthi, Greek, Aramaic
- Junagadh rock - Sudarshana lake

Successors in the north

- Shunga - Pushyamitra, Vidisha
- Kanva - Vasudeva c. 73 BCE
- Kharavela - Hathigumpha
- Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Parthians, Kushanas

Edicts & Rajasthan

- 14 Major Rock Edicts
- Minor Rock Edicts - Maski, Gujjarra, Bairat
- 7 Pillar Edicts; PE VII only at Delhi-Topra
- Bairat + Bhabru edict, Bijak-ki-Pahari

Deccan & South

- Satavahana - Simuka, Pratishthana
- Gautamiputra Satakarni, Nashik prashasti
- Sangam - Chera, Chola, Pandya
- Gandhara, Mathura, Amaravati schools

Chandragupta and Bindusara - the founding, and where we learn it from

Chandragupta Maurya founded the empire around 322-321 BCE by overthrowing Dhana Nanda of Magadha, with Kautilya - also called Chanakya and Vishnugupta - as his guide. Within twenty years he had pushed the Greeks back out of the north-west. Learn the treaty with Seleucus, because both the terms and the date are asked.

- Treaty with Seleucus Nicator, c. 305-303 BCE: Chandragupta received Aria, Arachosia, Gedrosia and the Paropanisadai; Seleucus received 500 elephants.
- Megasthenes came to Pataliputra as the Seleucid ambassador.
- Junagadh rock inscription: the Sudarshana lake was built by Pushyagupta, Chandragupta's governor in Saurashtra; conduits were added by the Yavana Tushaspha under Ashoka; Rudradaman I repaired it in 150 CE.
- Jain tradition holds that Chandragupta abdicated, followed Bhadrabahu to Shravanabelagola, and ended his life by sallekhana.
- Bindusara bore the title Amitraghata, which the Greeks wrote as Amitrochates; Deimachus was Antiochus I's ambassador at his court.

The two great sources - know their limits, not just their names

Arthashastra and Indica

Source	Author	What you must remember
Arthashastra	Kautilya	15 books (adhikaranas), 180 prakaranas; manuscript found by R. Shamasastri in 1905, published 1909
Indica	Megasthenes	Survives only in fragments quoted by later classical writers; describes a seven-fold division of Indian society; DENIES that slavery existed in India; says Pataliputra was run by six boards of five members each

- Megasthenes DENIES slavery in India - the planted false statement reads 'it states that slavery was widely prevalent'.
- Do not credit the Sudarshana lake to Rudradaman; he only repaired it in 150 CE. Pushyagupta built it.

Ashoka - the war, the dhamma, the names

Ashoka acceded around 268 BCE. Eight years into his reign, about 261 BCE, he fought the Kalinga war. The killing changed him, and Major Rock Edict XIII is his own account of that remorse. From then on his policy was dhamma - not a religion, but a moral code: non-violence, respect for elders, kindness to servants and animals, and toleration between sects.

- Major Rock Edict XIII describes the Kalinga war and its aftermath, and also names five contemporary Greek kings - the single most useful edict for dating the Mauryas.
- In his inscriptions Ashoka calls himself Devanampiya, beloved of the gods, and Piyadasi, of pleasing appearance.
- His personal name 'Ashoka' appears only at Maski, Gujjarra, Nettur and Udegolam.
- James Prinsep deciphered the Brahmi of the edicts in 1837 - that is what made Ashoka recoverable at all.
- Dhamma Mahamattas, the officers of dhamma, were created in his 14th regnal year.
- He sent missions abroad; his son Mahendra and daughter Sanghamitra carried Buddhism to Sri Lanka.

YAAD RAKHO

Where Ashoka's own name occurs - M-G-N-U: Maski, Gujarra, Nettur, Udegolam. Everywhere else he is only Devanampiya Piyadasi. If a question asks where his personal name is found, the answer is a Minor Rock Edict, never a Major one.

The edicts - the table this chapter is built on

Ashoka's records fall into four families: 14 Major Rock Edicts, the Minor Rock Edicts, 7 Pillar Edicts, and the Minor Pillar and commemorative inscriptions. Plus the two Separate or Kalinga Rock Edicts. Learn the family first, then the individual edict. Almost every question is edict-to-place or edict-to-content.

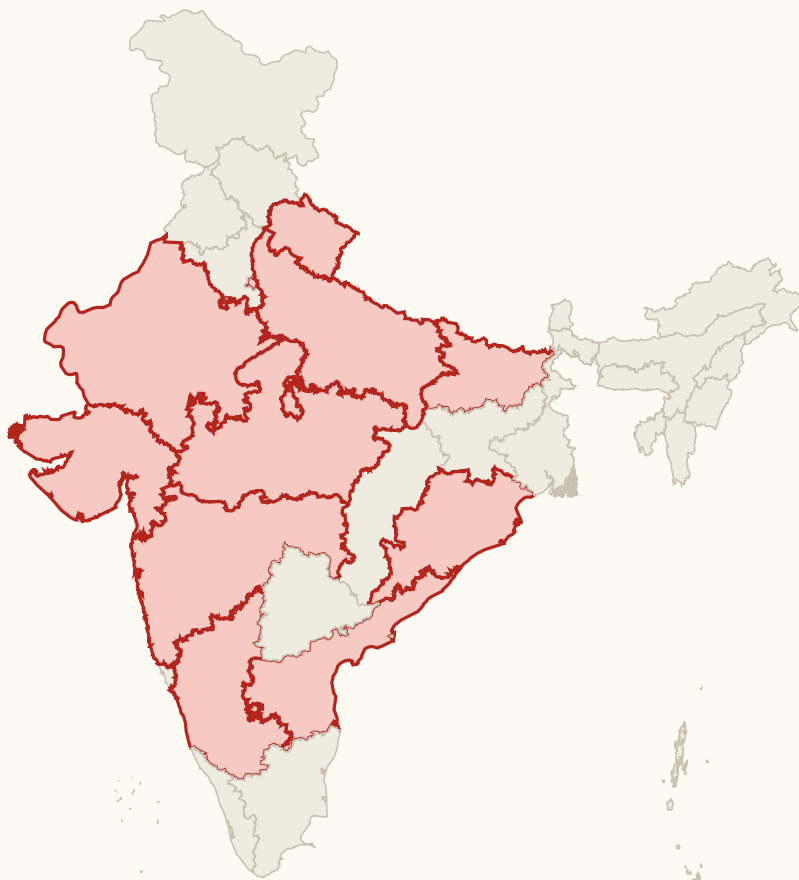
Ashoka's records - family, where they occur, script

Family	Where	Script
14 Major Rock Edicts	Kalsi, Girnar, Sopara, Dhauri, Jaugada, Shahbazgarhi, Mansehra, Yerragudi; later finds at Sannati and Kandahar	Brahmi, except Shahbazgarhi and Mansehra in Kharoshthi and Kandahar in Greek and Aramaic
Two Separate (Kalinga) Rock Edicts	Only at Dhauri and Jaugada	Brahmi
Minor Rock Edicts	Maski, Gujarra, Nettur, Udegolam, Bairat, Rupnath, Sasaram, Brahmagiri and others	Brahmi
7 Pillar Edicts	Delhi-Topra, Delhi-Meerut, Lauriya-Araraj, Lauriya-Nandangarh, Rampurva, Allahabad-Kosam	Brahmi
Minor Pillar / commemorative	Sarnath, Sanchi, Allahabad (schism edicts); Rummindei and Nigalisagar	Brahmi

Edict to content - the individual records RPSC actually asks

Edict / record	Place	Content
Major Rock Edict XIII	All the major rock sites	The Kalinga war, Ashoka's remorse, and the five Greek kings
Major Rock Edict XII	Major rock sites	Toleration and respect between religious sects
Separate Rock Edicts I & II	Dhauli and Jaugada only	Instructions to the officers of the newly conquered Kalinga
Pillar Edict VII	Only on the Delhi-Topra pillar	The longest of all the edicts - a review of his dhamma work
Rummindei pillar	Lumbini, Nepal	The village exempted from bali; its produce share fixed at one-eighth
Nigalisagar pillar	Nepal	Records the enlargement of the stupa of Konakamana
Bairat minor rock edict	Bijak-ki-Pahari, Bairat, Jaipur	Ashoka's minor rock edict, still at the site
Bhabru (Calcutta-Bairat) edict	Found at Bairat; now in the Asiatic Society, Kolkata	The only edict where Ashoka openly professes faith in the Buddha, the Dhamma and the Sangha, and recommends named Buddhist texts
Maski minor rock edict	Karnataka	Carries the personal name Ashoka
Barabar cave inscriptions	Barabar hills, Bihar	Dedication of the caves to the Ajivikas

Indian states with Ashokan inscriptions



Kalsi to Karnataka; Shahbazgarhi, Mansehra and Kandahar lie outside India

- Ashokan pillars are cut from Chunar sandstone and carry the distinctive high Mauryan polish.
- Pillar Edict VII, the longest, is found on the Delhi-Topra pillar alone. Not every pillar carries all seven.
- The Allahabad-Kosam pillar is special - besides Ashoka's edicts it carries the Queen's edict and, centuries later, Samudragupta's Allahabad prashasti.

TRAP

Two false statements RPSC has actually planted. First, 'all seven Pillar Edicts occur on every Ashokan pillar' - false, PE VII is on Delhi-Topra only. Second, no set of MAJOR Rock Edicts has been found at Sarnath - Sarnath has a minor pillar (schism) edict and the lion capital, not a rock edict.

Bairat - do this section slowly, it is your Rajasthan mark

Bairat, the old Viratnagar, sits in Jaipur district. It was the capital of the Matsya Mahajanapada, and under the Mauryas it became a Buddhist centre. Two Ashokan records come from Bairat, and RPSC has asked about them directly. Learn both, and learn the difference between them, because the exam separates them.

- Record one - the Bairat minor rock edict, on the hill called Bijak-ki-Pahari.
- Record two - the Bhabru edict, also called the Calcutta-Bairat edict. It was found by Captain Burt and moved to Kolkata; it is now in the Asiatic Society, Kolkata.
- The Bhabru edict is the only Ashokan record in which he openly professes faith in the Buddha, the Dhamma and the Sangha, and it recommends named Buddhist texts to monks and laity.
- Bairat also has India's earliest known free-standing circular Buddhist chaitya - a stupa inside a colonnade of octagonal wooden pillars.
- The Buddhist remains at Bairat were excavated by Daya Ram Sahni - the same man who dug Harappa in 1921.
- Bairat is MATSYA, not Surasena. Surasena's capital was Mathura.
- Do not confuse Bairat in Jaipur with Bagor in Bhilwara - Bagor is the Mesolithic site, Bairat is Buddhist and Ashokan.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2024 - India's earliest known free-standing circular Buddhist chaitya has been found at Bairat. The same year came the statement set: Bairat has two Ashokan inscriptions (true); the Bhabru edict was found here and later removed to Kolkata (true); Bairat was the capital of the Surasena Mahajanapada (FALSE - Surasena's capital was Mathura; Bairat was Matsya's).

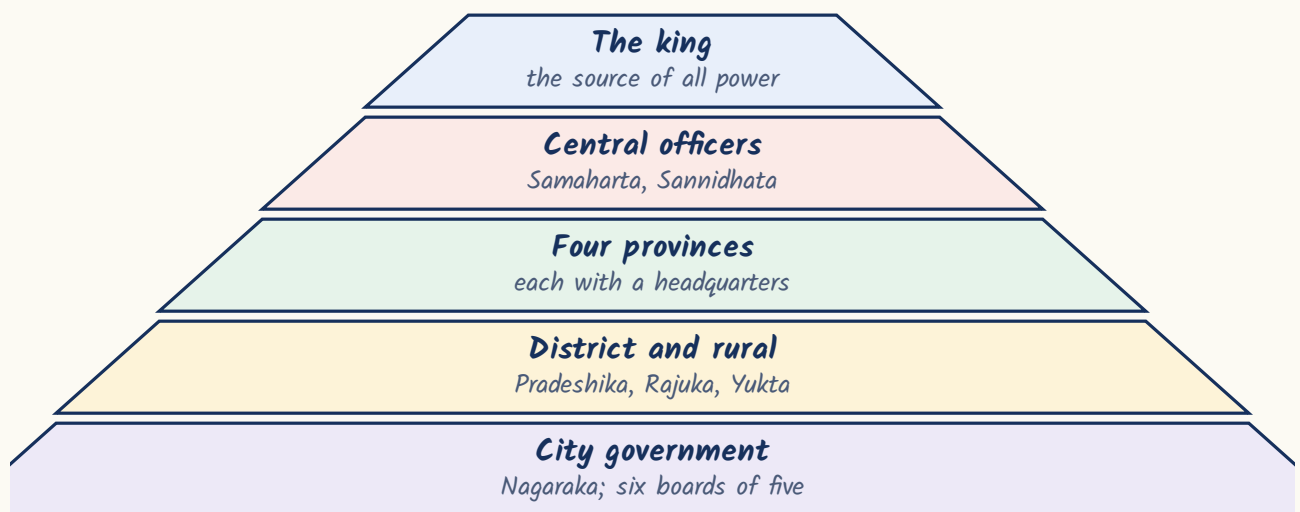
YAAD RAKHO

Bairat = B for Buddhist chaitya, B for Bhabru, B for Bijak-ki-Pahari, B for Burt who found it. Four Bs and you have the whole site.

Mauryan administration - officials and provinces

The Mauryan state was centralised and heavily officered. Learn the offices by function, because the negative-framed question always mismatches one official with one duty.

The Mauryan administrative ladder



Mauryan officials and what they did

Official	Function
Samaharta	Chief collector of revenue
Sannidhata	Treasurer, in charge of the state store-house
Rajuka	Rural administration and the dispensing of justice
Pradeshika	Provincial or district-level supervising officer
Yukta	Subordinate revenue and accounts officer
Nagaraka	Superintendent of the city

Official	Function
Dhamma Mahamatta	Officer of dhamma, created in the 14th regnal year

Provinces and their headquarters

Province	Headquarters
Uttarapatha	Taxila
Avantiratha	Ujjain
Kalinga	Tosali
Dakshinapatha	Suvarnagiri
Imperial capital	Pataliputra

- Megasthenes says Pataliputra was administered by six boards of five members each - thirty officials in all - handling industry, foreigners, births and deaths, trade, manufactures and the sales tax.
- The province-to-headquarters set is a standing matching question; take the four provinces clockwise - north Taxila, west Ujjain, east Tosali, south Suvarnagiri.
- The Rajuka is a RURAL administrator and judge, NOT the head of the royal household - that exact wrong pairing has been used.
- Samaharta is revenue, Sannidhata is treasury. The two get swapped in options.

Mauryan art - pillars, caves, yakshas

Mauryan art divides cleanly into court art, which is imperial and polished, and popular art, which is folk and unpolished. Pillars and caves are court art. The yaksha and yakshi statues are popular art. That division itself is examinable.

The Sarnath lion capital

Four lions

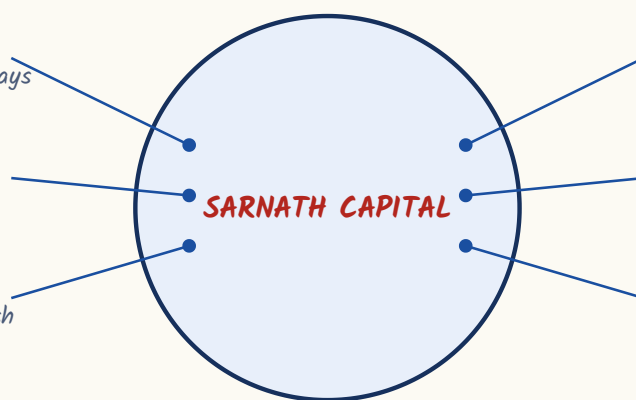
back to back, facing four ways

Dharmachakras

between the four animals

Monolithic shaft

Chunar sandstone, high polish



Abacus

lion, elephant, horse, bull

Inverted lotus

the bell-shaped base

State Emblem

adopted 26 January 1950

- Pillars: monolithic shafts of Chunar sandstone, with the celebrated Mauryan polish, topped by animal capitals - the lion at Sarnath, the bull at Rampurva, the elephant at Sankisa.
- The Sarnath lion capital was adopted as the State Emblem of India on 26 January 1950. Its abacus carries a lion, elephant, horse and bull separated by dharmachakras.
- Barabar hills, Bihar: Ashoka gave the Sudama, Vishvakarma and Karan Chaupar caves to the Ajivikas.
- Nagarjuni hills: his grandson Dasharatha gave the Gopika, Vadathika and Vapiyaka caves to the same sect.
- The Barabar caves are the earliest surviving rock-cut caves in India.
- The Lomas Rishi cave has the famous carved elephant-frieze doorway but carries NO Ashokan inscription.
- The Parkham yaksha near Mathura carries a Brahmi inscription naming the Manibhadra congregation and its maker Gomitaka, pupil of Kunika.
- The Didarganj chauri-bearer yakshi is in the Patna Museum.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2013 - Ashoka donated the rock-cut caves of the Barabar hills to the Ajivikas. Note the link back to the previous chapter: the Ajivikas are Makkhali Gosala's niyati sect.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2021 - the yaksha statue bearing the inscription that mentions the Manibhadra congregation was found at Parkham, near Mathura. The inscription also names its maker Gomitaka, pupil of Kunika.

TRAP

Lomas Rishi has the doorway, not an inscription. The wrong-pair option 'Lomas Rishi cave - an inscription of Ashoka' is a proven RPSC option. Ashoka's cave inscriptions are in Sudama, Vishvakarma and Karan Chaupar.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - the ASI has moved to seek UNESCO World Heritage status for the Barabar and Nagarjuni caves in Jehanabad district, Bihar (reported 2022), and the Bihar government has announced an eco-tourism development for the Barabar hills. They are still on the proposal track, not inscribed. Keep the Ajivika connection in mind if this appears in current affairs.

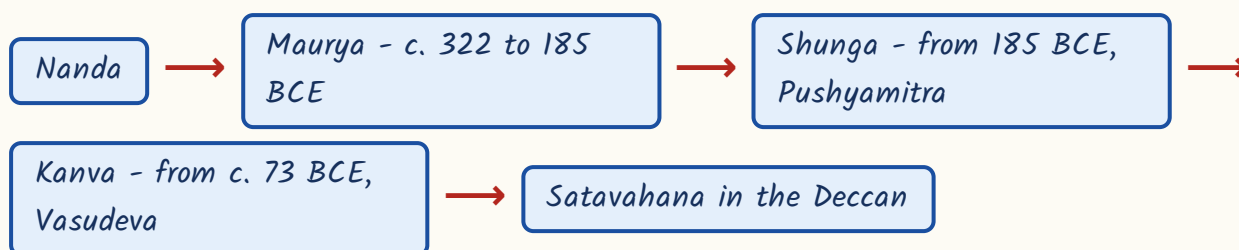
CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026 - the National Emblem cast in bronze for the roof of the new Parliament building was unveiled on 11 July 2022. It is a copy of the Sarnath lion capital, the same capital adopted as the State Emblem of India on 26 January 1950, so a current-affairs item and a Mauryan art question share one answer.

The fall, and the northern successors

The empire lasted about 137 years. In 185 BCE the last Maurya, Brihadratha, was killed by his own commander-in-chief Pushyamitra Shunga on the parade ground. Learn the chain of dynasties after that - it comes as a straight ordering question.

Dynasty chronology in Magadha - the ordering question



- Patanjali's Mahabhashya and the Ayodhya inscription of Dhanadeva connect Pushyamitra with two ashvamedha sacrifices; Patanjali was his contemporary.
- Kalidasa's play Malavikagnimitram is about his son Agnimitra.
- Vidisha was an important Shunga centre.
- The Kanva dynasty was founded by Vasudeva about 73 BCE, after the last Shunga, Devabhuti.
- Kharavela of Kalinga, of the Mahameghavahana or Chedi line, is known from the Hathigumpha inscription in the Udayagiri hills; he patronised Jainism.

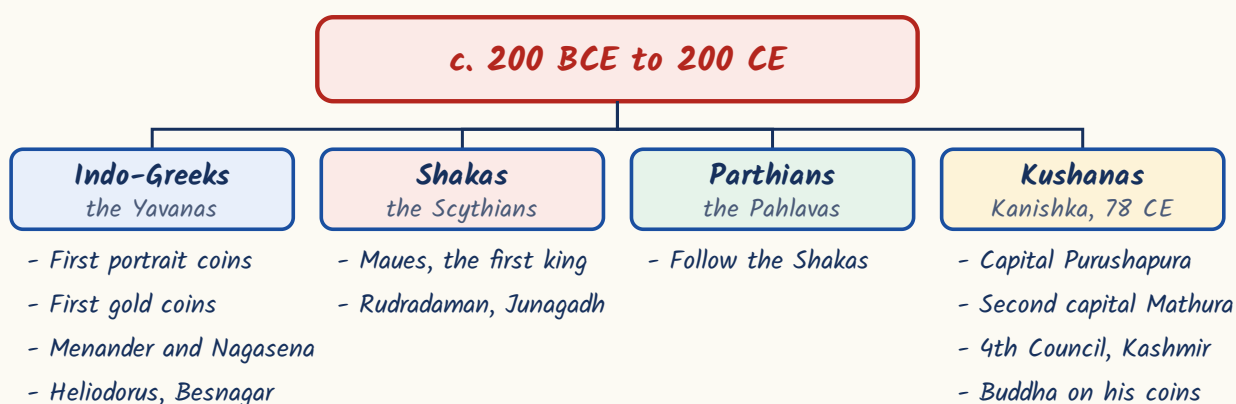
The Satavahanas of the Deccan

- Founder Simuka; capital Pratishthana, modern Paithan on the Godavari.
- Their kings used metronymics - named after the mother, hence Gautamiputra, Vashishthiputra.
- They were the first Indian rulers to grant land to brahmanas.
- The Nashik prashasti of Gautami Balashri praises her son Gautamiputra Satakarni as Ekabrahmana and destroyer of Shakas, Yavanas and Pahlavas.
- That record was issued in the 19th regnal year of Vashishthiputra Pulumavi - the date is asked.
- The Jogalthembi hoard contains coins of the Shaka ruler Nahapana restructured by Gautamiputra Satakarni - hard proof of his victory.
- Pushyamitra was NOT succeeded directly by the Kanva Vasudeva - the Shunga line ran on to Devabhuti first.
- Keep the two Vasudevas apart: Vasudeva founded the Kanva dynasty; Vasudeva I was the last great Kushana.

The foreign dynasties - Indo-Greeks to Kushanas

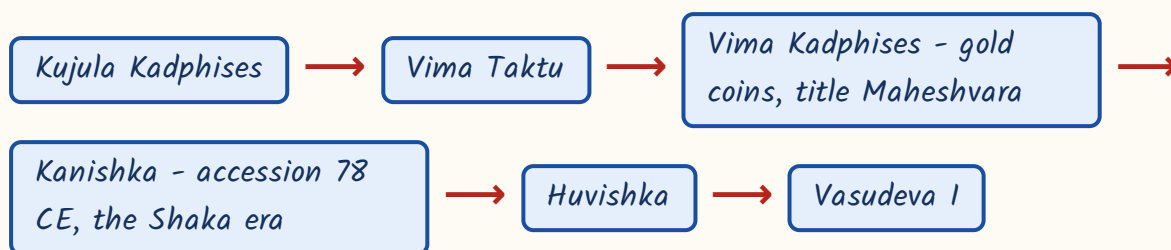
Between about 200 BCE and 200 CE, wave after wave came through the north-west - Indo-Greeks, then Shakas, then Parthians, then Kushanas. Remember them by their firsts, because that is how they are asked.

The four waves from the north-west



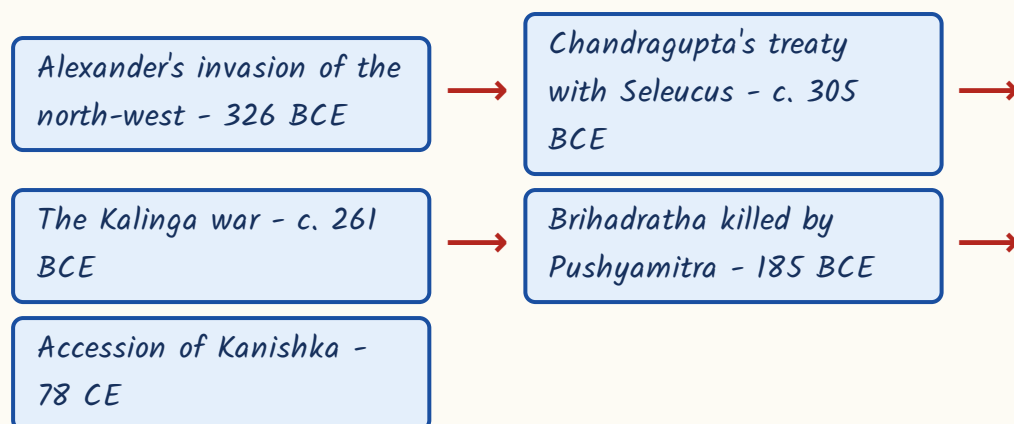
- The Indo-Greeks were the first rulers in India to issue coins bearing the king's portrait and name, and the first to issue gold coins.
- Menander, the Milinda of the Pali texts, was converted to Buddhism by the monk Nagasena - the dialogue is the Milindapanho.
- The Heliodorus or Garuda pillar at Besnagar near Vidisha was set up by Heliodorus, envoy of the Indo-Greek Antialcidas, at the court of Bhagabhadra. It is the earliest evidence of a Greek adopting Vaishnavism.
- Maues, also written Moga, was the first Shaka king in India.
- The Junagadh rock inscription of the Shaka ruler Rudradaman I, 150 CE, is the earliest long inscription in chaste Sanskrit.

The Kushana line



- Kanishka's capital was Purushapura, modern Peshawar; his second capital was Mathura.
- He convened the Fourth Buddhist Council in Kashmir under Vasumitra, which produced the Mahavibhasha.
- His court is associated with Ashvaghosha, Nagarjuna, the physician Charaka and the engineer Agesilaus.
- Kanishka's coins do carry an image of the Buddha - the statement that they never do is false.
- Bhavabhuti belongs to Harsha's period, centuries later. He is NOT of Kanishka's court.
- The Besnagar Garuda pillar goes with Heliodorus and Antialcidas, never with Kanishka.

The event chronology RPSC asks you to order



Art schools and the Sangam age

Two things close this chapter. First the three sculpture schools of the post-Mauryan centuries, which are asked as material-and-region matching. Second the Sangam age in the far south, which is a small but reliable one-liner source.

Gandhara vs Mathura - the two schools examiners set against each other

Gandhara	Mathura
North-west - Peshawar and Taxila region	Mathura, in the Ganga-Yamuna region
Grey schist	Spotted red sandstone from Sikri
Greco-Roman form on Buddhist subject matter	Indigenous form, wholly Indian tradition
Buddha with wavy hair, drapery in folds, sombre	Buddha shaven-headed, robe thin and close, smiling and robust
Buddhist subjects almost exclusively	Buddhist, Jain and Brahmanical subjects alike
Patronised by the Kushanas	Also flourished under the Kushanas

The three schools by material and region

School	Material	Region
Gandhara	Grey schist	North-west

School	Material	Region
Mathura	Spotted red sandstone	Middle Ganga - Mathura
Amaravati	White limestone	Krishna valley

The Sangam age

The three Sangam kingdoms

Kingdom	Capital	Emblem and port
Chera	Vanji	Bow emblem; port Muziris
Chola	Uraiyur, also Puhar	Tiger emblem; Karikala built the Kallanai on the Kaveri
Pandya	Madurai	Fish emblem; port Korkai

- Tolkappiyam is the oldest extant work in Tamil - a work on grammar and poetics.
- The Sangam corpus includes the Ettuthogai, eight anthologies, and the Pattuppattu, ten idylls.
- The Silappadikaram was composed by Ilango Adigal; the Manimekalai by Sittalai Sattanar. These twin epics are post-Sangam.
- The Pandya emblem is the FISH. The tiger is the Chola. That swap is the standard wrong option.

YAAD RAKHO

Sangam emblems - Chera bends the Bow, Chola wears the Tiger's stripes, Pandya swims like a Fish. B-T-F in the order Chera, Chola, Pandya.

REVISION RECAP

1. Chandragupta c. 322-321 BCE with Kautilya, overthrew Dhana Nanda; treaty with Seleucus c. 305 BCE - four provinces for 500 elephants.
2. Arthashastra - 15 books, 180 prakaranas; found by R. Shamasastri 1905, published 1909.

3. Megasthenes' Indica - fragments only; seven-fold division of society; denies slavery; Pataliputra run by six boards of five.
4. Junagadh rock - Sudarshana lake built by Pushyagupta, conduits by Tushaspha, repaired by Rudradaman I in 150 CE; Bindusara = Amitraghata = Amitrochates, with Deimachus as Antiochus I's envoy at his court.
5. Ashoka acceded c. 268 BCE; Kalinga war c. 261 BCE, described in Major Rock Edict XIII, which names five Greek kings.
6. Titles Devanampiya and Piyadasi; personal name only at Maski, Gujjarra, Nettur and Udegolam; Brahmi deciphered by James Prinsep in 1837.
7. Kharoshthi at Shahbazgarhi and Mansehra; Greek and Aramaic at Kandahar; the two Separate Rock Edicts only at Dhauili and Jaugada.
8. Pillar Edict VII, the longest, only on Delhi-Topra; pillars of Chunar sandstone with Mauryan polish.
9. Bairat, Jaipur - minor rock edict on Bijak-ki-Pahari plus the Bhabru edict found by Captain Burt, now in the Asiatic Society, Kolkata.
10. Bhabru is the only edict where Ashoka professes faith in the Buddha, Dhamma and Sangha; Bairat has India's earliest free-standing circular Buddhist chaitya, dug by Daya Ram Sahni.
11. Rummindei - Lumbini exempted from bali, produce share one-eighth. Nigalisagar - stupa of Konakamana enlarged.
12. Barabar caves (Sudama, Vishvakarma, Karan Chaupar) given by Ashoka to the Ajivikas; Nagarjuni caves by Dasharatha; Lomas Rishi has the doorway but no Ashokan inscription.
13. Sarnath lion capital adopted as the State Emblem on 26 January 1950; abacus with lion, elephant, horse and bull between dharmachakras.
14. Officials - Samaharta revenue, Sannidhata treasury, Rajuka rural justice, Nagaraka city, Dhamma Mahamatta from the 14th regnal year.
15. Provinces - Uttarapatha/Taxila, Avantiratha/Ujjain, Kalinga/Tosali, Dakshinapatha/Suvarnagiri; capital Pataliputra.
16. Brihadratha killed 185 BCE by Pushyamitra Shunga; Kanva founded by Vasudeva c. 73 BCE after Devabhuti; Kharavela's Hathigumpha inscription, Udayagiri.
17. Satavahanas - Simuka, capital Pratishthana; metonymics; first to grant land to brahmanas; Nashik prashasti of Gautami Balashri, Jogalthembi hoard.
18. Indo-Greeks first with portrait coins and gold coins; Menander and Nagasena in the Milindapanho; Heliodorus pillar at Besnagar for Antialcidas; Maues first Shaka.
19. Kushanas - Kujula, Vima Taktu, Vima Kadphises, Kanishka (78 CE, Shaka era), Huvishka, Vasudeva I; Purushapura capital; Fourth Council in Kashmir under Vasumitra.

20. Gandhara grey schist, Mathura spotted red sandstone, Amaravati white limestone; Sangam - Chera/Vanji/bow, Chola/Uraiyur/tiger, Pandya/Madurai/fish; Tolkappiyam oldest Tamil work.

IH04

Gupta, Post-Gupta and South Indian Dynasties

About 2–3 questions a paper from this chapter. The proven favourites are the Guptas

(Samudragupta's Prayag Prashasti, Prabhavati Gupta and the Vakatakas), the Rashtrakuta Kailasa temple at Ellora, and the Chola temples. Match-the-following and NOT-correctly-matched formats dominate.

Roughly a thousand years of Indian history - 320 CE to 1300 CE - packed into one chapter. Do not try to learn it as a story. RPSC asks it as a matching grid: ruler to inscription, ruler to monument, king to court poet, dynasty to capital. Learn the grid.

Guptas, Post-Gupta and the South

Guptas (c. 319–550 CE)

- Sri Gupta - founder
- Samudragupta - Prayag Prashasti
- Chandragupta II - Sakari, Vakataka tie
- Kumaragupta I - Nalanda
- Skandagupta - Hunas repelled

Vardhanas /

Pushyabhutis

- Harsha 606–647 CE
- Thanesar to Kannauj
- Banabhatta - Harshacharita
- Hiuen Tsang - Si-yu-ki
- Stopped at the Narmada

Eastern & Deccan north

- Palas - Gopala, Dharmapala
- Senas - Lakshmanasena, Jayadeva
- Rashtrakutas - Dantidurga, Krishna I
- Tripartite struggle for Kannauj

Deccan & Pallavas

- Chalukyas of Badami - Pulakeshin II
- Aihole inscription - Ravikirti
- Chalukyas of Kalyani - Vikramaditya VI
- Pallavas - Mahendravarman, Narasimhavarman
- Mamallapuram, Kanchi

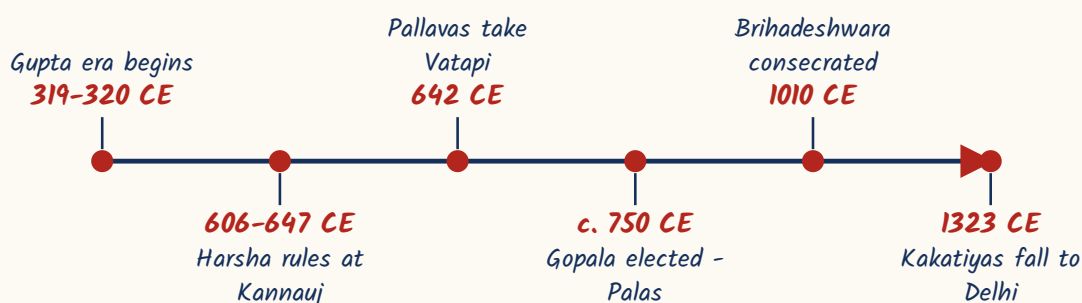
The far south

- Cholas - Rajaraja I, Rajendra I
- Uttaramerur - kudavolai
- Hoysalas - Belur, Halebidu
- Kakatiyas - Warangal, Rudramadevi
- Sangam - Chola tiger, Pandya fish, Chera bow

The frame - fix the grid before the story

This chapter covers two Indias at once. In the north: Guptas, then Harsha, then the Palas, Senas and Rashtrakutas fighting over Kannauj. In the south: Chalukyas, Pallavas, Cholas, and after them the Hoysalas and Kakatiyas. RPSC never asks you to narrate a war. It asks one of four things - who ruled from where, who wrote what, who built what, and which inscription says what. So build the grid first.

A thousand years on one line - the anchors of this chapter



Dynasty to capital to the one ruler you must know

Dynasty	Capital	Ruler to remember
Guptas	Pataliputra	Samudragupta
Vardhanas (Pushyabhutis)	Thanesar, later Kannauj	Harshavardhana
Palas	Bengal-Bihar (Gaur, Munger)	Dharmapala, Devapala
Senas	Lakshmanavati (Gaur)	Lakshmanasena
Rashtrakutas	Manyakheta (Malkhed)	Krishna I, Amoghavarsha I
Chalukyas of Badami	Vatapi (Badami)	Pulakeshin II
Chalukyas of Kalyani	Kalyani	Vikramaditya VI
Pallavas	Kanchi (Kanchipuram)	Narasimhavarman I

Dynasty	Capital	Ruler to remember
Cholas	Thanjavur, then Gangaikonda Cholapuram	Rajaraja I, Rajendra I
Hoyasalas	Dwarasamudra (Halebidu)	Vishnuvardhana
Kakatiyas	Warangal (Orugallu)	Rudramadevi, Prataparudra II
Pandys (Sangam)	Madurai, port Korkai	Emblem - fish
Cheras (Sangam)	Vanji, port Muziris	Emblem - bow and arrow

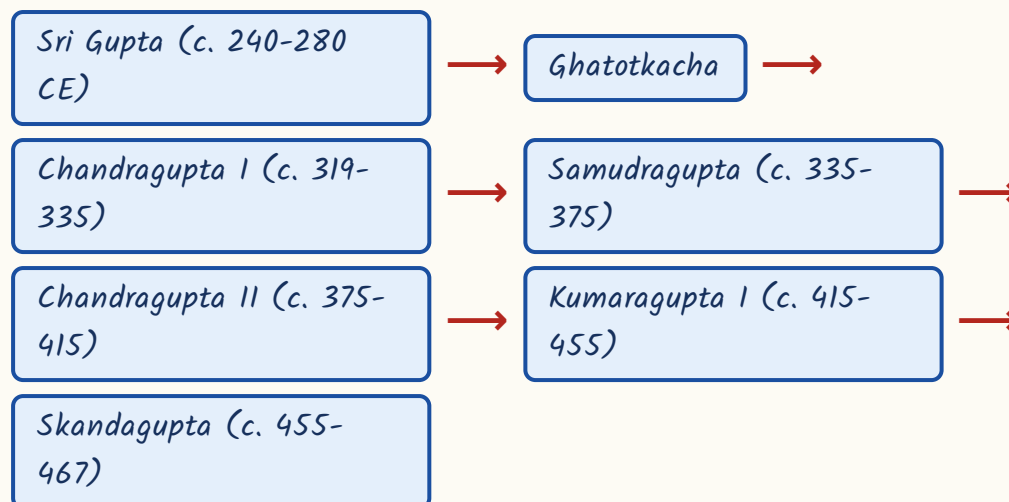
YAAD RAKHO

Store every dynasty in five slots: capital, one ruler, one monument, one book, one inscription. When RPSC gives you a match-the-following, you are only reading off those slots.

The Guptas take shape - Sri Gupta to Chandragupta I

The Guptas begin small. Sri Gupta is named in Gupta inscriptions as the founder, and he carried only the modest title Maharaja - a local chief, not an emperor. His son Ghatotkacha kept the same title. The jump comes with Chandragupta I, who takes the imperial title Maharajadhiraja and marries into the powerful Licchavi clan. That marriage is the political turning point, and it is why RPSC keeps asking about it.

The Gupta line - learn this order, it is asked as an ordering question



- Sri Gupta - founder, title only Maharaja.
- Chandragupta I - first Gupta to take Maharajadhiraja.
- Married the Licchavi princess Kumaradevi.
- Issued the King-Queen type gold coins showing both.
- Gupta era begins 319-320 CE - the standard reckoning date.

TRAP

Three men, one name. Chandragupta Maurya (4th century BCE, Chanakya), Chandragupta I (Licchavi marriage, Gupta era), Chandragupta II Vikramaditya (Sakari, Vakataka alliance). RPSC has set options mixing all three.

Samudragupta and the Prayag Prashasti

Samudragupta is the conqueror of the line. Everything we know about his campaigns comes from one document - the Allahabad or Prayag Prashasti, composed by his court poet Harisena in champu style, that is a mix of prose and verse in Sanskrit. Note the irony that gets asked: it is engraved on an Ashokan pillar. So one pillar carries a message of peace from Ashoka and a war record from Samudragupta.

- Composed by Harisena, court poet - champu (prose plus verse) Sanskrit.
- Engraved on an Ashokan pillar at Prayag (Allahabad).
- Titles - Kaviraja (king among poets), Ashvamedha-parakrama.
- Called the Napoleon of India by V.A. Smith - a historian's label, not a title of his.
- Lyrist type coins show him playing the veena; also ashvamedha type coins.

The two policies in the Prayag Prashasti - this contrast is the exam point

Aryavarta (the north)	Dakshinapatha (the south)
Kings were uprooted - prasabhoddharana	Kings were defeated, then reinstated
Territory annexed outright	Policy of grahana-moksha-anugraha - capture, release, favour
Nine kings named as uprooted	Twelve southern kings named
Direct Gupta rule	Tribute and acknowledgement of overlordship

CURRENT LINK

Current link: the Maha Kumbh at Prayagraj ran from 13 January to 26 February 2025. Position as of September 2026. The same Prayag carries Samudragupta's prashasti - Harisena's eulogy cut on an Ashokan pillar that now stands in the Allahabad Fort. When the current-affairs block names Prayagraj, the history question sitting behind it is the Prayag Prashasti, so keep Harisena, champu style and the Ashokan pillar ready together.

Chandragupta II Vikramaditya - the peak, and the two Chinese travellers

Chandragupta II is where the Gupta empire is at its widest and its richest. His big military achievement is finishing off the Western Kshatrapas, the Shaka rulers of Malwa and Gujarat - which is why he takes the title Sakari, slayer of the Shakas. That conquest gave the Guptas the western ports, and it also gave them silver: Gupta silver coinage begins only after this, because the Kshatrapas had a silver coin tradition and the Guptas continued it.

- Title Sakari after destroying the Western Kshatrapas of Malwa-Gujarat.
- First Gupta silver coinage; Ujjain became a second centre of power.
- Lion-slayer and horseman type gold coins are his.
- Navaratna, first four - Kalidasa, Amarasimha (Amarakosha), Varahamihira, Dhanvantari.
- Navaratna, next five - Vararuchi, Kshapanaka, Shanku, Ghatakarpara, Vetalaabhatta.
- The Navaratna list is traditional, not proved by inscription - but learn it, RPSC asks it as a list.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked twice in RAS Pre 2021, on the same alliance. (1) Chandragupta II married his daughter Prabhavati Gupta to the Vakataka ruler - answer: Rudrasena II. (2) After her husband's early death Prabhavati ruled as regent for her minor son - answer: Divakarasena. Her mother was the Naga princess Kuberanaga, and the Poona copper plates call her the mother of Yuvaraja Divakarasena.

- Fa-Hien (Faxian) visited India c. 399-414 CE, in Chandragupta II's reign.
- His account is the Fo-Kuo-Ki, Record of Buddhist Kingdoms.
- He came for Buddhist texts - he is silent on politics and never names the king.
- Hiuen Tsang came later, under Harsha; do not swap the two.

Kumaragupta I, Skandagupta and the inscription grid

Kumaragupta I ruled long and quietly, and his one permanent contribution is Nalanda - he founded the Mahavihara that became the greatest university of early India. His title was Mahendraditya and his coins carry the peacock, the vehicle of Kartikeya. Skandagupta then faces the Hunas. He beats them back, but the effort drains the treasury, and the Gupta decline sets in after him.

- Kumaragupta I (c. 415-455) - title Mahendraditya, founded Nalanda Mahavihara.
- Peacock type coins - linked to Kartikeya worship.
- Mandsaur inscription of his reign records a silk-weavers' guild that migrated and rebuilt a sun temple.
- Skandagupta (c. 455-467) - repelled the Hunas; last of the great Guptas.

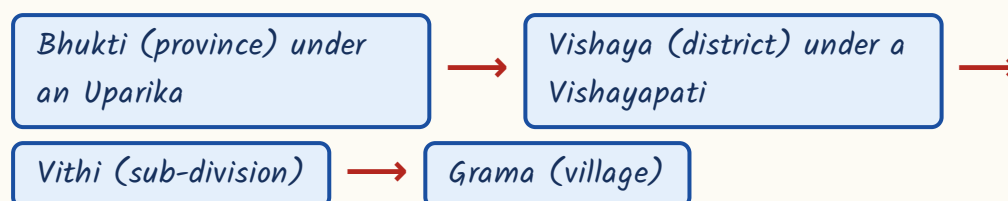
Inscription to ruler to what it records - a standing matching question

Inscription	Ruler	What it records
Allahabad / Prayag Prashasti	Samudragupta	Conquests; composed by Harisena
Junagadh rock inscription	Skandagupta	Repair of the Sudarshana lake in Saurashtra
Bhitari pillar inscription	Skandagupta	Victories over the Pushyamitras and the Hunas
Mandsaur inscription	Kumaragupta I	Silk-weavers' guild, sun temple
Poona copper plates	Prabhavati Gupta	Her regency for Yuvaraja Divakarasena
Mehrauli iron pillar	King Chandra (Chandragupta II)	Praise of Chandra; rust-free iron

Gupta administration, land and coins

Gupta government was looser than Mauryan government. The Mauryas ran a centralised bureaucracy; the Guptas ran a layered structure where provincial governors and local bodies had real room. The other big shift is land grants - kings began granting revenue-free villages to brahmanas and temples, which over centuries created a landed intermediary class. That is the standard explanation of Indian feudalism, and it starts here.

The administrative ladder - top to bottom



- Kumaramatyas - the highest cadre of officers, drawn on for top posts.
- Gold coin was called the dinara; Gupta gold coinage is the finest of ancient India.
- Agrahara - revenue-free grant to a brahmana; devagrahara - grant to a temple.
- Land grants were often made permanent and tax-free, weakening central revenue.
- Gupta-age science belongs here too - Aryabhata and Varahamihira; the detail is in the art and science chapter.

Coin type to ruler - a clean one-mark question

Coin type	Ruler
King-Queen type	Chandragupta I
Lyrist (veena) and ashvamedha type	Samudragupta
Lion-slayer, horseman, couch type	Chandragupta II
Peacock type	Kumaragupta I

Harsha and the Pushyabhutis - the last northern empire before the Turks

Harshavardhana belongs to the Pushyabhuti or Vardhana dynasty of Thanesar. He shifted his capital to Kannauj, and from then on Kannauj becomes the prize of north India - which is exactly why the tripartite struggle later happens over it. Harsha ruled 606 to 647 CE. His expansion southwards stopped hard: the Chalukya king Pulakeshin II beat him on the Narmada, and the Narmada stayed his southern limit.

- Reign 606-647 CE; titles Siladitya and Rajaputra.
- Capital shifted from Thanesar to Kannauj.
- Defeated by Chalukya Pulakeshin II on the Narmada, c. 618-619 CE.
- Madhuban and Banskhera copper plates are his own records.
- Banabhatta, his court poet, wrote the Harshacharita (his biography) and the Kadambari (a prose romance).
- Harsha himself wrote three Sanskrit plays - Nagananda, Ratnavali, Priyadarshika.
- Hiuen Tsang, the Prince of Pilgrims, wrote the Si-yu-ki.
- Kannauj religious assembly, 643 CE; Prayag Mahamoksha Parishad held every five years.

TRAP

Kadambari was written by Banabhatta, not by Harsha. Harsha wrote the three plays. A NOT-correct question has been built on exactly this swap.

After Harsha - Palas, Senas, Rashtrakutas and the fight for

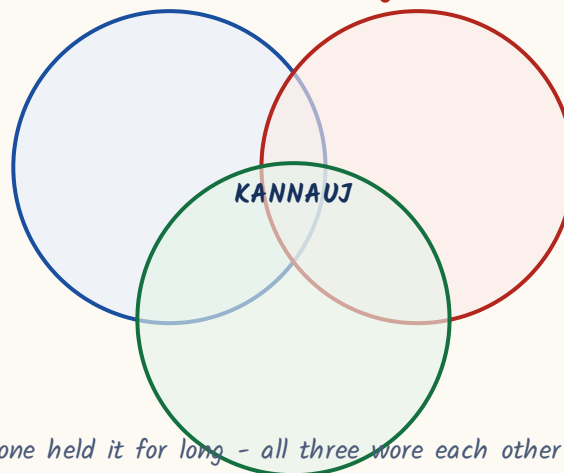
Kannauj

Harsha died without an heir and north India broke up. Three powers then spent nearly a century fighting over Kannauj - the Palas from the east, the Gurjara-Pratiharas from the west, and the Rashtrakutas from the Deccan. This is the tripartite struggle. Nobody won it permanently; all three exhausted themselves, and that weakness is part of why the Turkish invasions later succeeded.

The tripartite struggle - three powers, one prize

Palas (east)

Gurjara-Pratiharas (west)



No one held it for long - all three wore each other down

- Palas of Bengal-Bihar - Gopala was elected founder, c. 750 CE; election is the point RPSC likes.
 - Gopala built Odantapuri; Dharmapala founded Vikramshila and Somapura Mahavihara (Paharpur).
 - Devapala is counted the greatest Pala; the Palas were Buddhist patrons.
 - Palas patronised the Nalanda and Vikramshila monasteries and the Pala school of bronzes.
 - Senas replaced the Palas in Bengal - Samantasena, Vijayasena, Ballalasena, Lakshmanasena.
 - Ballalasena wrote Danasagara and Adbhutasagara.
 - Jayadeva, author of the Gita Govinda, adorned Lakshmanasena's court.
 - Lakshmanasena was ruling when Bakhtiyar Khalji took Bengal.
-
- Rashtrakutas - founder Dantidurga; capital Manyakheta (Malkhed).
 - Krishna I built the monolithic Kailasa temple, Cave 16 at Ellora.
 - Amoghavarsha I wrote Kavirajamarga, the earliest extant literary work in Kannada, and founded Manyakheta.
 - Arab traveller accounts rank the Rashtrakuta king among the great kings of the world.

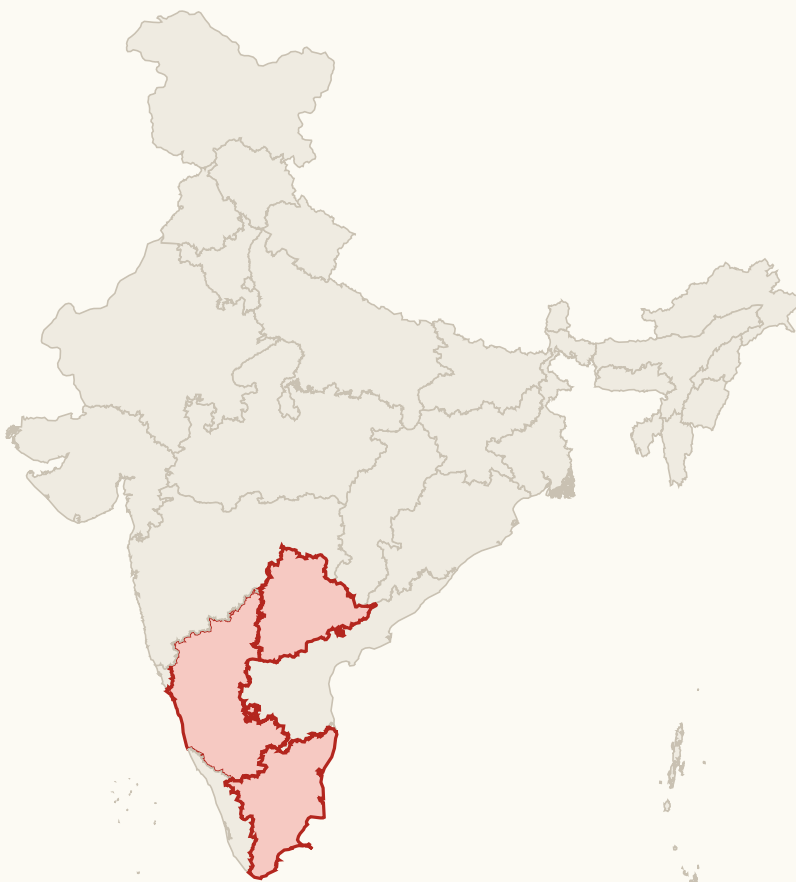
ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023 asked: the monolithic Kailasa temple at Ellora (Cave 16) was excavated under which Rashtrakuta ruler? Answer - Krishna I. Remember the pairing Krishna I - Kailasa - Ellora - Rashtrakuta as a single unit; it is the single most asked fact of the post-Gupta north.

The Deccan and the Pallavas - Badami against Kanchi

From the sixth to the eighth century the Deccan is one long duel: the Chalukyas of Badami against the Pallavas of Kanchi. Pulakeshin II is the Chalukya high point - he stopped Harsha on the Narmada. But then Pallava Narasimhavarman I marched south to north, captured the Chalukya capital Vatapi in 642 CE, and took the title Vatapikonda, conqueror of Vatapi. Pulakeshin II was defeated and killed. Learn the duel as one story and both sides fall into place.

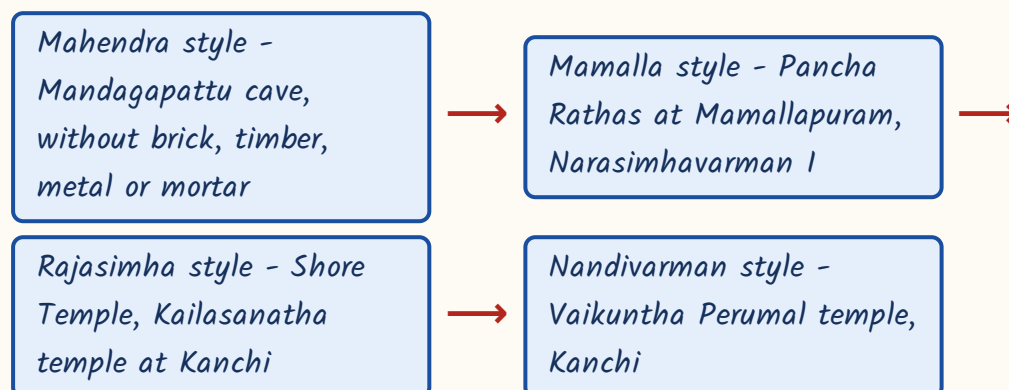
Where the southern dynasties sat



Badami, Manyakheta, Halebidu - Karnataka; Kanchi, Thanjavur - Tamil Nadu; Warangal - Telangana

- Pulakeshin II (610-642 CE) of Badami - defeated Harsha, defeated by Narasimhavarman I.
 - Aihole inscription, composed by the Jain poet Ravikirti on the Meguti temple, Saka 556 (634-35 CE), records his victories.
 - Pattadakal Virupaksha temple - built by queen Lokamahadevi for Vikramaditya II's victory over Kanchi.
 - Pattadakal is a UNESCO World Heritage Site, inscribed 1987.
 - Narasimhavarman I Mamalla captured Vatapi in 642 CE - title Vatapikonda.
 - Mahendravarman I wrote the Sanskrit farce Mattavilasa Prahasana.
 - Mamallapuram's monuments are a UNESCO World Heritage Site.
-
- Chalukyas of Kalyani - the later revival branch.
 - Vikramaditya VI - court poet Bilhana wrote Vikramankadevacharita; jurist Vijnaneshwara wrote the Mitakshara.
 - The Mitakshara is a commentary on the Yajnavalkya Smriti and became a school of Hindu law.
 - Someshvara III wrote the Manasollasa, an encyclopaedic work.

Pallava architecture in four stages - asked as an ordering question



ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023 asked a NOT-correctly-matched question on monument and builder dynasty. The wrong pair was Dashavatara temple, Deogarh - Pallavas. Deogarh is Gupta. Keep four pairs ready: Deogarh - Guptas, Kailasa Ellora - Rashtrakutas, Shore Temple - Pallavas, Virupaksha Pattadakal - Chalukyas of Badami.

TRAP

Three Chalukya branches, do not merge them - Badami or Vatapi (Pulakeshin II), Kalyani (Vikramaditya VI), and the Eastern Chalukyas of Vengi. Also keep Chalukya separate from Chola: Chalukya is Deccan and Kannada, Chola is Tamil.

The far south - Cholas, their village republics, and the last Deccan kingdoms

The imperial Cholas were revived by Vijayalaya around 850 CE with Thanjavur as capital, and under Rajaraja I and Rajendra I they became the strongest naval and temple-building power India had seen. Rajaraja I built the Brihadeshwara temple at Thanjavur, consecrated in 1010 CE. His son Rajendra I marched to the Ganga, took the title Gangaikondachola, founded a new capital called Gangaikonda Cholapuram, and sent a fleet across the sea against Srivijaya - the Kadaram expedition. No other Indian dynasty of the period did that.

- Vijayalaya revived the line c. 850 CE, capital Thanjavur.
- Rajaraja I - Brihadeshwara or Rajarajeshwara temple, consecrated 1010 CE.
- Rajendra I - Gangaikondachola, new capital Gangaikonda Cholapuram, naval expedition to Srivijaya (Kadaram).
- Rajaraja II built the Airavatesvara temple at Darasuram.
- Those three temples together are UNESCO's Great Living Chola Temples.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023 asked who built the Brihadeshwara (Rajarajeshwara) temple at Thanjavur. Answer - Rajaraja I. Fix the pair Rajaraja I = Brihadeshwara, Rajendra I = Gangaikonda Cholapuram. Swapping these two is the commonest slip.

CURRENT LINK

Current link: on 27 July 2025, at Gangaikonda Cholapuram during the Aadi Thiruvathirai festival, the Prime Minister released a 1000-rupee commemorative coin honouring Rajendra Chola I, marking a thousand years of his northern march and maritime expedition. Position as of September 2026. Coin-plus-anniversary items like this feed straight into the current-affairs block, and the history question that follows is always Rajendra I - Gangaikondachola - Srivijaya.

Chola local self-government - Uttaramerur, and why it matters

This is the one piece of south Indian history that gets asked as a concept, not as a name. Chola villages ran themselves. There were three kinds of village body, depending on who lived there. And the elections to their committees were run by lottery, not by show of hands - which is why the inscriptions describing them are famous. The record is at Uttaramerur in Tamil Nadu, in inscriptions of Parantaka I, around 920 CE.

Which village had which assembly



- Ur - the assembly of an ordinary village of landholders.
- Sabha or Mahasabha - the assembly of a brahmadeya village, that is a village granted to brahmanas.
- Nagaram - the assembly of merchants in a trading town.
- Nadu was the larger unit above the village; its assembly was the nattar.
- Kudavolai - the pot-ticket system: names on palm-leaf tickets drawn from a pot by a young boy.
- Those elected sat on variyams - committees for the tank, garden, gold, justice and the annual accounts.
- Qualifications were strict - ownership of land and a house, an age range, knowledge of the Vedas.
- Failure to submit accounts disqualified a man and his relatives from office.

YAAD RAKHO

Three words carry this whole topic - Ur, Sabha, Nagaram; and one word carries the method - kudavolai. If you remember Uttaramerur - Parantaka I - kudavolai - variyam, you have the full mark.

- Hoysalas - capital Dwarasamudra (Halebidu); Vishnuvardhana built the Chennakeshava temple at Belur; Vesara style.
- Sacred Ensembles of the Hoysalas were inscribed by UNESCO in 2023.
- Kakatiyas - capital Warangal (Orugallu); Rudramadevi ruled as a woman and was praised by Marco Polo.
- Prataparudra II was defeated by Delhi in 1323, ending the Kakatiyas.
- Ramappa or Rudreshwara temple at Palampet, a Kakatiya temple, became a UNESCO site in 2021.
- Sangam-age emblems - Chola tiger, Pandya fish, Chera bow and arrow; the three are the *muvendar*.
- Pandya capital Madurai, port Korkai; Chera capital Vanji, port Muziris.

REVISION RECAP

1. Sri Gupta founder, only Maharaja; Chandragupta I first Maharajadhiraja, Licchavi marriage, Gupta era 319-320 CE.
2. Prayag Prashasti - Harisena, champu Sanskrit, on an Ashokan pillar; Aryavarta uprooted, Dakshinapatha reinstated.
3. Samudragupta - Kaviraja, lyrist coins, Napoleon of India (V.A. Smith's phrase).
4. Chandragupta II - Sakari, first Gupta silver, Navaratna, daughter Prabhavati married Vakataka Rudrasena II.
5. Prabhavati Gupta ruled as regent for Divakarasena; Poona copper plates.
6. Fa-Hien under Chandragupta II, Fo-Kuo-Ki; Hiuen Tsang under Harsha, Si-yu-ki.
7. Kumaragupta I founded Nalanda, peacock coins; Skandagupta - Hunas, Junagadh and Bhitari inscriptions.
8. Gupta ladder - Bhukti (Uparika), Vishaya (Vishayapati), Vithi, Grama; Kumaramatyas top cadre; dinara.
9. Harsha 606-647, Thanesar to Kannauj, stopped by Pulakeshin II at the Narmada.

10. Bana wrote *Harshacharita* and *Kadambari*; Harsha wrote *Nagananda*, *Ratnavali*, *Priyadarshika*.
11. Tripartite struggle for Kannauj - Palas, Gurjara-Pratiharas, Rashtrakutas.
12. Gopala elected, built Odantapuri; Dharmapala founded Vikramshila and Somapura; Jayadeva at Lakshmanasena's court.
13. Rashtrakutas - Dantidurga founder, Krishna I built Ellora Kailasa, Amoghavarsha I wrote *Kavirajamarga*.
14. Aihole inscription - Ravikirti, Meguti temple, Saka 556, on Pulakeshin II.
15. Narasimhavarman I took Vatapi in 642 CE, title Vatapikonda; Mahendravarman I wrote *Mattavilasa Prahasana*.
16. Pallava architecture - Mahendra, Mamalla, Rajasimha, Nandivarman stages.
17. Rajaraja I - Brihadeshwara 1010 CE; Rajendra I - Gangaikonda Cholapuram, Srivijaya expedition.
18. Uttaramerur, Parantaka I, c. 920 CE - kudavolai lottery, variyam committees; Ur, Sabha, Nagaram.
19. Hoysalas - Belur and Halebidu, UNESCO 2023; Kakatiyas - Warangal, Rudramadevi, Ramappa UNESCO 2021.
20. Sangam emblems - Chola tiger, Pandya fish (Madurai, Korkai), Chera bow (Vanji, Muziris).

IH05

Ancient Indian Art, Science and the Indian Knowledge & Value System

2-3 questions a paper, and the split has been shifting towards the knowledge-system half. Stupa architecture came in 2023 and 2024. Expect match-the-following on darshana-to-founder, sanskara-to-meaning and temple-style-to-feature - all pure list recall.

Two chapters bolted together. The first half is art history - stupas, caves, temple styles, sculpture schools. The second half is the Indian Knowledge and Value System - Varna, Ashrama, Purushartha, the sixteen Sanskaras, the three Rinas, the six Darshanas. That second half is newly emphasised in the RAS syllabus and most candidates skip it. Do not skip it; it is the cheapest scoring block in Indian History because the answers are fixed lists.

Ancient Art, Science and the Indian Knowledge System

Stupas

- Bharhut - Shunga, Cunningham 1873
- Sanchi - Ashoka, Shunga, Satavahana toranas
- Amaravati - Krishna river, limestone
- Parts - anda, harmika, yashti, chhatra, vedika, torana

Science

- Aryabhata - Aryabhatiya 499 CE
- Varahamihira - Brihat Samhita
- Brahmagupta - zero rules, 628 CE
- Charaka and Sushruta
- Mehrauli iron pillar

Rock-cut caves

- Ajanta - 30 caves, all Buddhist
- Ellora - 34 caves, three religions
- Karle - largest chaitya
- Barabar - Ajivikas
- Elephanta - Trimurti

Value system

- 4 Varna - Purusha Sukta
- 4 Ashrama - Brahmacharya to Sannyasa
- 4 Purushartha - Dharma to Moksha
- 16 Sanskara
- 3 Rina, 5 Mahayajna

Temple styles

- Nagara - shikhara, north
- Dravida - vimana and gopuram, south
- Vesara - Deccan hybrid
- Latina, Phamsana, Valabhi

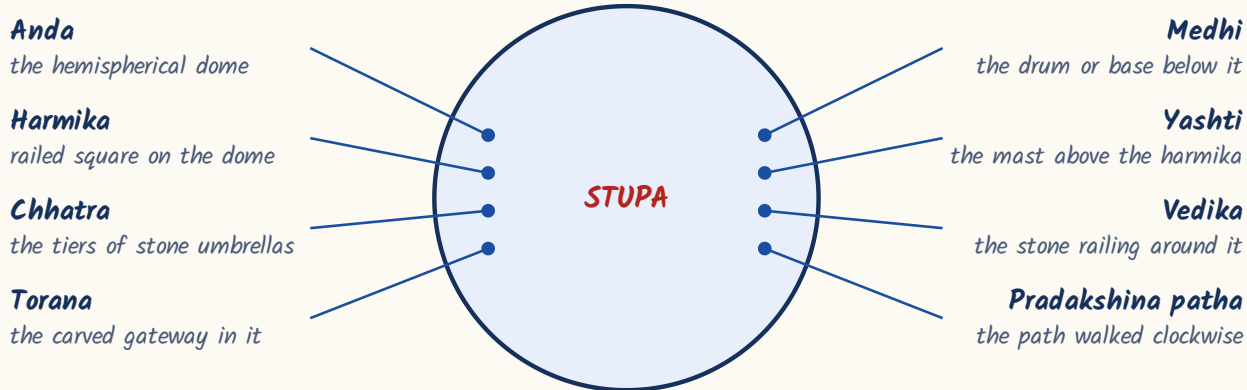
Knowledge system

- 6 Darshana with founders
- 6 Vedanga
- Nalanda, Takshashila, Vikramshila
- Valabhi, Odantapuri

The stupa - learn the anatomy, then the three sites

A stupa is a burial mound turned into a place of worship - it holds relics of the Buddha or of a monk, and you worship it by walking around it, not by entering it. RPSC does not ask you to appreciate a stupa. It asks you to name its parts and to match a stupa to its state, its period and its excavator. So take the anatomy first; every part is a possible one-mark question.

Anatomy of a stupa - every part is a one-mark question



- **Medhi** - the drum or base; **Anda** - the hemispherical dome, the core of the stupa.
- **Harmika** - the railed square balcony sitting on top of the dome.
- **Yashti** - the mast rising from the harmika; **Chhatra** - the tiers of stone umbrellas on it.
- **Vedika** - the stone railing around the stupa; **Torana** - the carved gateway in the railing.
- **Pradakshina patha** - the circumambulatory path you walk on, clockwise.

The three great stupas - site, state, period, the fact that gets asked

Stupa	State	The examinable fact
Bharhut	Madhya Pradesh (Satna)	Shunga period; chief donor King Dhanabhuti; discovered by Alexander Cunningham, 1873; sculptures now in the Indian Museum, Kolkata
Sanchi	Madhya Pradesh (Raisen)	Brick stupa by Ashoka, enlarged and stone-cased under the Shungas, four toranas under the Satavahanas; Ashokan pillar with the Schism Edict; UNESCO 1989
Amaravati	Andhra Pradesh	On the Krishna river; Satavahana period; white limestone, called Palnad marble; narrative panels
Dhamek, Sarnath	Uttar Pradesh	Gupta period; marks the site of the first sermon

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023 and again in 2024 asked who discovered the Bharhut stupa in 1873 - answer Alexander Cunningham. The 2023 paper also asked the period and donor of its railings and gateway - Shunga period, King Dhanabhuti - and which river the Amaravati stupa stands on - the Krishna. Three separate facts, one site cluster. Learn the whole cluster.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023-24 set a statement question on the Great Stupa at Sanchi: the original brick stupa was built by Ashoka, it was enlarged and encased in dressed stone in the Shunga period, and the four carved toranas were added under the Satavahanas. All three statements are correct. Note the three-dynasty sequence - it is the whole answer.

TRAP

Bharhut is in Madhya Pradesh, not Bihar. The Dhamek stupa at Sarnath is in Uttar Pradesh, not Bihar - Sarnath is near Varanasi. RPSC has used exactly these two state-swaps in NOT-correctly-matched questions.

Rock-cut caves - Ajanta, Ellora and the rest

Rock-cut architecture means cutting a whole building out of a living rock face, from the top downwards, with no separate blocks assembled. Two words you need: chaitya is the prayer hall with the stupa at the far end, vihara is the monastery with cells for monks. Ajanta and Ellora are both in Maharashtra, both UNESCO sites from 1983, and both are asked almost every other year - but they are completely different in religion, which is the point RPSC exploits.

- Ajanta - 30 caves in the Waghora river gorge, Aurangabad district, exclusively Buddhist.
- Two phases - phase I Satavahana and Hinayana, phase II under Vakataka Harisena, c. 460-480 CE.
- Rediscovered in 1819 by Captain John Smith of the British army, while hunting.
- Paintings - Padmapani and Vajrapani Bodhisattvas in Cave I; Mahajanaka and Chhadanta Jataka scenes.
- Technique is tempera on a lime-plaster ground, not true fresco - a favourite trick option.

- Ellora - 34 caves: Caves 1-12 Buddhist, 13-29 Hindu, 30-34 Jain. That is 12, 17 and 5.
- Cave 16 is the monolithic Kailasa temple of the Rashtrakuta king Krishna I.
- Cave 10 is the Vishvakarma chaitya, the carpenter's cave.
- Ellora is the only site where all three religions carved side by side - that tolerance is the exam line.
- Remember the split - Ajanta is only Buddhist, Ellora is Buddhist, Hindu and Jain; both are in Maharashtra and both UNESCO 1983.
- There are two Udayagiris - Kharavela's in Odisha with the Hathigumpha inscription, and the Gupta one near Vidisha in MP with the Varaha panel.

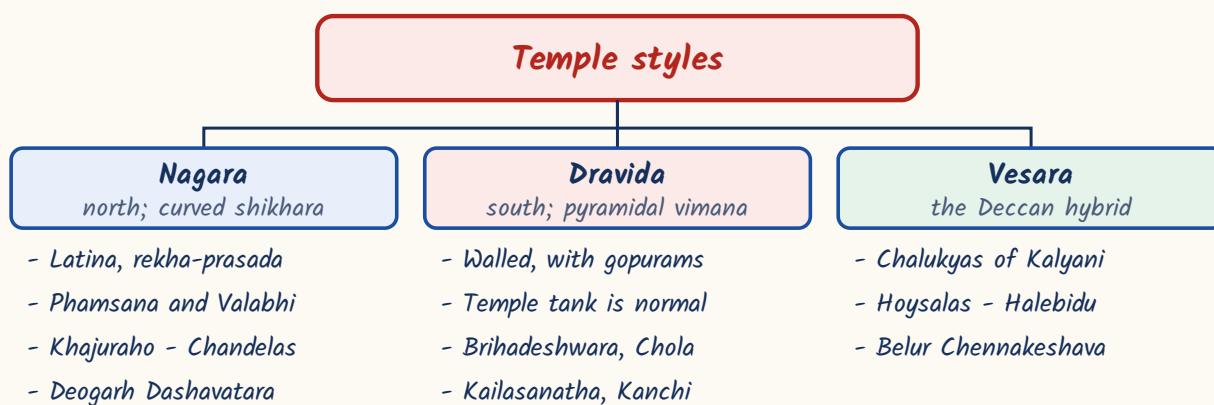
The other rock-cut sites you must be able to place

Site	State	The one fact
Karle	Maharashtra	Largest chaitya hall in India; Satavahana
Bhaja and Bedsa	Maharashtra	Among the earliest chaityas
Bagh caves	Madhya Pradesh	Painted caves, close in style to Ajanta
Barabar caves	Bihar	Oldest rock-cut caves; made under Ashoka, gifted to the Ajivikas
Udayagiri-Khandagiri	Odisha	Jain caves of Kharavela; Hathigumpha inscription
Udayagiri near Vidisha	Madhya Pradesh	Gupta period; the great Varaha panel
Elephanta	Maharashtra	Trimurti (Maheshmurti); UNESCO 1987

Temple styles - Nagara, Dravida, Vesara

From the Gupta period onwards Indian temple building settles into regional idioms, and the textbook classification is threefold. The simplest way to hold it: the north builds a curving tower over the sanctum and leaves the compound open; the south builds a stepped pyramid over the sanctum and puts a huge gateway in the wall around it; the Deccan mixes the two. Learn the vocabulary, because the question is always feature-to-style.

The three styles, with the examples that get asked



Nagara against Dravida - the contrast RPSC asks

Nagara (North)	Dravida (South)
Curvilinear shikhara over the sanctum	Pyramidal vimana over the sanctum
Usually no boundary wall or gateway	Walled enclosure with towering gopurams
Tallest structure is over the garbhagriha	In later temples the gopuram outgrows the vimana
No large temple tank as a rule	Temple tank is normal
Amalaka and kalasha crown the shikhara	Stupika or octagonal crown on the vimana

- Nagara sub-types - Latina or rekha-prasada (single curved tower), Phamsana (broader, lower, straight slopes), Valabhi (barrel-roofed).
- The Odisha idiom uses its own words - deul for the tower, jagamohana for the assembly hall.
- Khajuraho temples were built by the Chandelas; the Modhera Sun temple and Dilwara by the Solankis.
- Vesara is the Deccan hybrid - associated with the Chalukyas of Kalyani and the Hoysalas.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023 set a match-the-following on temple styles: Nagara with curvilinear shikhara usually without a boundary wall, Dravida with a pyramidal vimana within a walled enclosure with gopurams, Vesara as the hybrid form associated with the Hoysalas. Read the feature, not the name - that is how the question is set.

Sculpture schools, Gupta art and coins

Three sculpture schools grew up in the early centuries CE, and each is identified by its stone and its style, not by its subject. Gandhara used grey schist and looked Greek. Mathura used spotted red sandstone and looked Indian. Amaravati used white limestone and told stories in panels. Gandhara and Mathura both produced the earliest images of the Buddha, roughly at the same time - that simultaneity is the statement RPSC likes to test.

The three schools - stone, style, patron

School	Material and style	Patron and region
Gandhara	Grey schist; Greco-Roman realism, wavy hair, drapery folds	Kushanas; north-west, Peshawar-Taxila

School	Material and style	Patron and region
Mathura	Spotted red sandstone; indigenous idiom, robust figures	Kushanas; Mathura, Uttar Pradesh
Amaravati	White limestone; crowded narrative panels	Satavahanas; Krishna valley, Andhra

- Gupta art - Sarnath Buddha in the Dharmachakra-pravartana pose is the classic image.
- Dashavatara temple at Deogarh - an early Nagara stone temple.
- Bhitargaon - the finest surviving Gupta brick temple.
- Sultanganj bronze Buddha - a large Gupta bronze.
- Ajanta Caves 16 and 17 paintings belong to this classical phase.
- Numismatics is the study of coins - and coins are a standard RPSC one-liner.
- Punch-marked karshapana coins are the earliest Indian coins.
- Indo-Greeks were the first to issue coins bearing the king's portrait and name.
- Kushanas issued the first large gold coins in India.
- Gupta gold coin was the dinara; Gupta silver coinage begins only after the Shaka conquest.

Ancient Indian science - mathematics, astronomy, medicine, metallurgy

This block is pure matching - name to work to contribution. Two cautions before the table. First, Aryabhata said the earth rotates on its axis and that eclipses are caused by shadows, not by Rahu and Ketu; that is the statement question. Second, do not confuse Brahmagupta with Bhaskara II - Brahmagupta is 628 CE and gave the rules for zero and negative numbers, Bhaskara II is much later and wrote the Siddhanta Shiromani.

Scientist to work to contribution

Name	Work	Contribution
Aryabhata (b. 476 CE)	Aryabhatiya, 499 CE	Earth rotates on its axis; eclipses by shadow; pi as 3.1416; place-value
Varahamihira (6th century)	Brihat Samhita, Panchasiddhantika, Brihat Jataka	Encyclopaedia; five astronomical systems; astrology; a Navaratna of Chandragupta II
Brahmagupta	Brahmasphutasiddhanta, 628 CE; Khandakhadyaka	First systematic rules for arithmetic with zero and negative numbers
Bhaskara II	Siddhanta Shiromani	Its four parts include Lilavati and Bijaganita

- Charaka Samhita - medicine; Charaka is traditionally placed at Kanishka's court.
- Sushruta Samhita - surgery; rhinoplasty, cataract operations, the eight branches of Ayurveda.
- Vagbhata wrote the Ashtanga Hridaya.
- Nagarjuna wrote the Rasaratnakara, on alchemy and metallurgy.
- Do not pair Sushruta with the Ashtanga Hridaya - that is Vagbhata's book, and the swap is a set question.

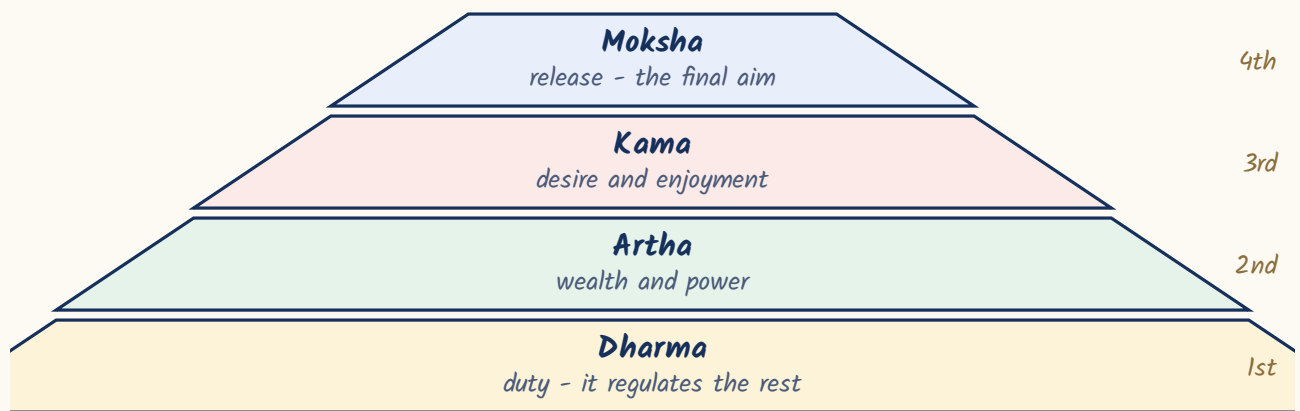
- The Mehrauli iron pillar stands in the Qutb complex, Delhi.
- It carries a Sanskrit praise of King Chandra, identified with Chandragupta II.
- It has resisted rust for about 1600 years - the standing proof of ancient Indian metallurgy.
- Sulbasutras, part of the Kalpa Vedanga, contain the earliest Indian geometry - written to lay out Vedic fire altars.

The Indian Value System - Varna, Ashrama, Purushartha

Now the second half of the chapter. The classical Indian scheme organises a life along three axes at once - who you are in society (Varna), where you are in your own lifetime (Ashrama), and what you are pursuing (Purushartha). Four in each. That symmetry is the whole design, and it is why examiners love it: the answers are closed lists that cannot change. Learn them as lists, in order, and you will never lose these marks.

- Varna - the fourfold order, first mentioned in the Purusha Sukta of the tenth mandala of the Rigveda.
- Brahmana from the mouth, Kshatriya from the arms, Vaishya from the thighs, Shudra from the feet.
- Varna is fourfold and theoretical; jati is the local birth-group and runs into thousands.
- The four Purusharthas - Dharma, Artha, Kama, Moksha - in that order.
- Dharma regulates the pursuit of Artha and Kama; Moksha is the final aim.
- Dharma, Artha and Kama together are called the trivarga.

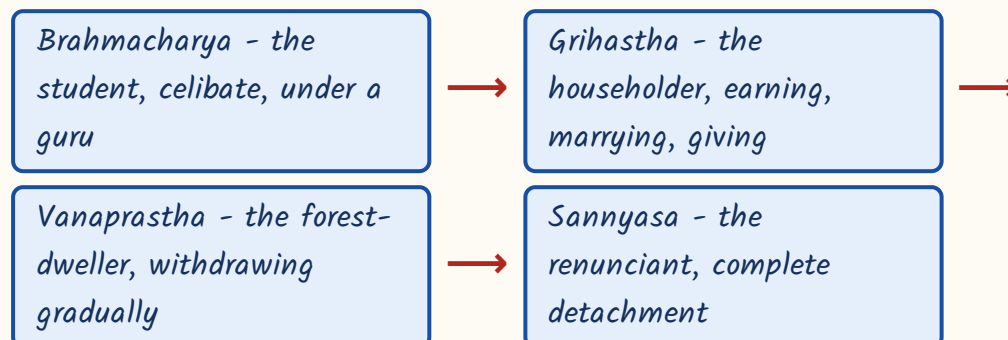
The four Purusharthas - counted 1 to 4, Moksha last



TRAP

Varna is not jati. Varna is the four-fold classical order named in the Purusha Sukta; jati is the actual endogamous group on the ground and there are thousands of them. RPSC sets statement questions that swap these two words.

The four Ashramas - ideally 25 years each, in this order



- Grihastha is treated as the support of the other three - the student, the forest-dweller and the renunciant all live off the householder's giving.
- That is why the Grihastha ashrama is called indispensable, not merely one stage among four.
- Entry into Brahmacharya is marked by the Upanayana sanskara; its close by Samavartana.
- The ashrama scheme is a prescription in the Dharmashastras, not a description of how everyone actually lived.

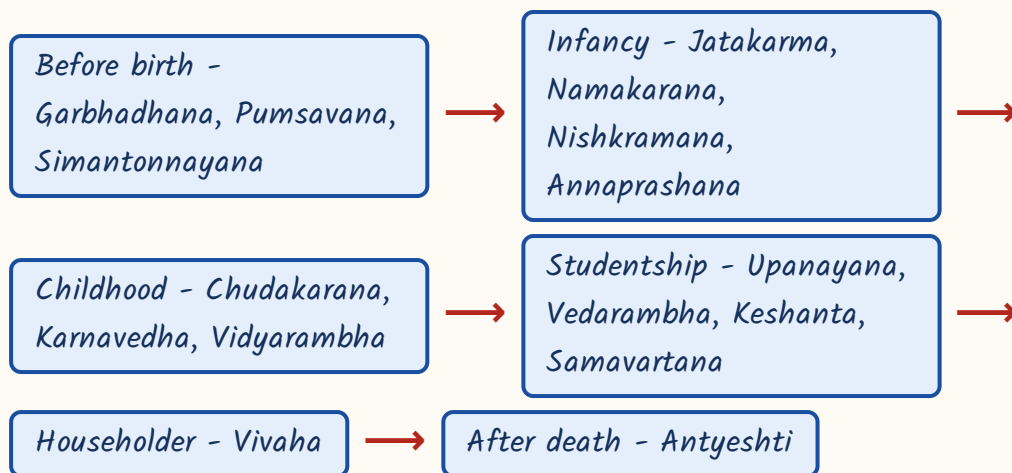
YAAD RAKHO

Two four-word chains to write on your palm. Ashrama - Brahmacharya, Grihastha, Vanaprastha, Sannyasa: B-G-V-S. Purushartha - Dharma, Artha, Kama, Moksha: D-A-K-M. Order is the question; the words alone are not enough.

The sixteen Sanskaras, the three Rinas and the five Mahayajnas

A sanskara is a sacrament - a rite that marks and refines a stage of life. The Grihya Sutras lay down sixteen of them, the shodasha sanskara, running from before birth to after death. Learn the count first - sixteen - because that alone has been asked. Then learn the order, because it is a natural life sequence and easy to reconstruct: three before birth, then infancy, then education, then marriage, then the last rites.

The sixteen sanskaras as a life-cycle - reconstruct the order from this



Sanskaras 1 to 8 - conception to childhood

No.	Sanskara	What it marks
1	Garbhadhana	Conception
2	Pumsavana	Rite in early pregnancy
3	Simantonnayana	Parting of the hair in later pregnancy
4	Jatakarma	Birth ceremony
5	Namakarana	Naming, on the 10th to 12th day
6	Nishkramana	First outing from the house
7	Annaprashana	First solid food, around six months
8	Chudakarana	Tonsure, first cutting of the hair

Sanskaras 9 to 16 - education to the last rites

No.	Sanskara	What it marks
9	Karnavedha	Piercing of the ears
10	Vidyarambha	Beginning of learning the alphabet
11	Upanayana	Investiture with the sacred thread; entry into studentship
12	Vedarambha	Beginning of Vedic study
13	Keshanta	First shaving of the beard
14	Samavartana	Graduation - return from the guru's house
15	Vivaha	Marriage

No.	Sanskara	What it marks
16	Antyeshti	Last rites - the only posthumous sanskara

- Antyeshti is the only sanskara performed after death - that single line is a ready-made one-mark question.
- Upanayana is the pivot: it opens the Brahmacharya ashrama and formal education.
- Samavartana closes studentship; Vivaha opens the Grihastha ashrama.
- Namakarana on the 10th-12th day and Annaprashana at about six months are the two dated ones.

The three Rinas from the Taittiriya Samhita - gods paid by sacrifice, sages by study, ancestors by children

Rina	Owed to	Repaid by
Deva-rina	The gods	Yajna, sacrifice
Rishi-rina (Brahma-rina)	The sages	Svadhyaya - study and teaching
Pitri-rina	The ancestors	Raising progeny, continuing the line

- Pancha Mahayajna - the householder's five daily duties.
- Brahma yajna - study of the Vedas; Deva yajna - offerings to the gods.
- Pitri yajna - to the ancestors; Bhuta yajna - to all living beings.
- Nri or Manushya yajna - hospitality to the guest.
- Note the pairing: three Rinas are lifetime debts, five Mahayajnas are daily duties. Do not merge the lists.

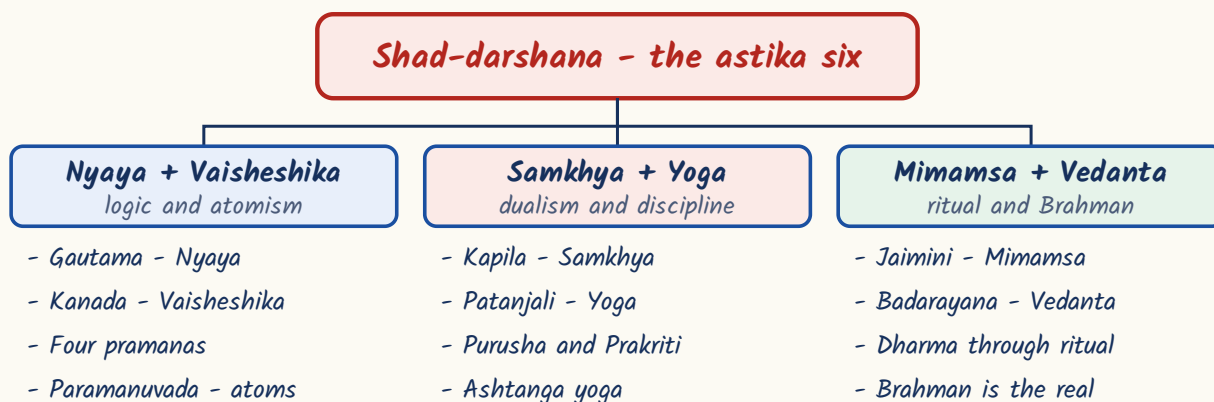
Shad-darshana - the six systems of Indian philosophy

Darshana means a way of seeing. Six schools accept the authority of the Vedas and are called astika; the ones that reject it are nastika. The six always come in three traditional pairs, because each pair shares a framework - Nyaya with Vaisheshika, Samkhya with Yoga, Mimamsa with Vedanta. RPSC asks this as a straight match-the-following: school to founder, or school to core idea. Learn the table cold.

The six darshanas - founder, basic text, core idea

Darshana	Founder	Core idea
Nyaya	Gautama (Akshapada)	Logic; four pramanas - pratyaksha, anumana, upamana, shabda
Vaisheshika	Kanada	Atomism (paramanuvada) and the doctrine of categories (padarthas)
Samkhya	Kapila	Dualism of Purusha and Prakriti; twenty-five tattvas
Yoga	Patanjali	Ashtanga yoga - yama, niyama, asana, pranayama, pratyahara, dharana, dhyana, samadhi
Purva Mimamsa	Jaimini	Authority of ritual; dharma as the object of enquiry
Uttara Mimamsa (Vedanta)	Badarayana	Brahman as the ultimate reality

The six schools come in three pairs



- Basic texts - Nyaya Sutra, Vaisheshika Sutra, Samkhya Karika of Ishvarakrishna, Yoga Sutra, Purva Mimamsa Sutra, Brahma Sutra.
- Samkhya is the oldest of the six and is atheistic in its classical form; Yoga adds Ishvara.
- Nastika schools - Charvaka (materialist), Buddhism and Jainism; the Ajivikas are also outside the six.
- The three pairs - Nyaya and Vaisheshika, Samkhya and Yoga, Mimamsa and Vedanta.
- The Gautama of the Nyaya school is not Gautama Buddha - a standing trap option.
- Keep Kapila (Samkhya) apart from Kanada (Vaisheshika); the names are one letter apart.

YAAD RAKHO

Founders in order, as one chant: Gautama, Kanada, Kapila, Patanjali, Jaimini, Badarayana. Six names, six schools, same sequence as the standard list Nyaya-Vaisheshika-Samkhya-Yoga-Mimamsa-Vedanta.

TRAP

Samkhya's basic text is the Samkhya Karika, not the Mimamsa Sutra. RPSC has set a NOT-correctly-matched question on exactly that pairing.

CURRENT LINK

Current link: Yoga is the one darshana with a live policy footprint. The UN General Assembly declared 21 June the International Day of Yoga in December 2014 on India's proposal, and it has been observed every year since 2015; UNESCO inscribed yoga on its Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity in 2016. Position as of September 2026. If a question pairs the day with a school, the school is Patanjali's Yoga and its basic text is the Yoga Sutra.

How knowledge was transmitted - Vedangas, gurukul and the ancient universities

Learning in ancient India moved from the gurukul, where a student lived in the teacher's house, to the mahavihara, a large residential monastery-university with thousands of students and a formal syllabus. Takshashila belongs to the earlier type - a cluster of famous teachers rather than a single institution with degrees. Nalanda belongs to the later type, and it is the one asked most often.

The ancient centres of learning

Centre	Founder or patron	Remember this
Takshashila	Gandhara region; ancient, no single founder	Panini, Chanakya, Charaka and Jivaka linked to it; a cluster of teachers, not a chartered university
Nalanda	Founded under Kumaragupta I; Palas later	Head Shilabhadra; Xuanzang and I-tsing studied there; sacked by Bakhtiyar Khalji c. 1193; UNESCO 2016
Vikramshila	Dharmapala (Pala)	Tantric studies; strong in Buddhist logic
Somapura (Paharpur)	Dharmapala (Pala)	Great monastery, now in Bangladesh
Odantapuri	Gopala (Pala)	Earliest of the Pala foundations
Valabhi	Maitrakas of Gujarat	Rival of Nalanda; Hinayana learning

The six Vedangas - the limbs of Vedic study

Vedanga	Subject	Key name
Shiksha	Phonetics, pronunciation	-
Kalpa	Ritual; includes the Sulbasutras	Geometry of the fire altar
Vyakarana	Grammar	Panini's Ashtadhyayi
Nirukta	Etymology	Yaska

Vedanga	Subject	Key name
Chhanda	Metre	-
Jyotisha	Astronomy	-

- Sanskrit literature of the classical age - Kalidasa wrote *Abhijnanashakuntalam*, *Meghadutam*, *Raghuvamsha* and *Kumarasambhava*.
- Vishakhadatta wrote the *Mudrarakshasa*; Shudraka the *Mrichchhakatika*; Bhasa the earliest surviving Sanskrit plays.
- Panini's *Ashtadhyayi* on grammar; Patanjali's *Mahabhashya* is its great commentary.
- Amarasimha's *Amarakosha* is the classical Sanskrit thesaurus.

CURRENT LINK

Current link: the Indian Knowledge Systems are now official policy, not just syllabus. NEP 2020 mandates their integration into curricula, the Ministry of Education runs a dedicated IKS Division, and the new Nalanda University campus at Rajgir in Bihar was inaugurated on 19 June 2024 - a deliberate revival of the ancient mahavihara on a site UNESCO listed in 2016. Position as of September 2026. This is why the RAS syllabus now names Varna, Ashrama, Purushartha and the Darshanas explicitly - expect the weight here to rise, not fall.

REVISION RECAP

1. Stupa parts - medhi, anda, harmika, yashti, chhatra, vedika, torana, pradakshina patha.
2. Bharhut - MP, Shunga, donor Dhanabhuti, found by Cunningham 1873, sculptures in Indian Museum Kolkata.
3. Sanchi - Ashoka brick, Shunga stone casing, Satavahana toranas; Schism Edict pillar; UNESCO 1989.
4. Amaravati - Krishna river, Satavahana, white limestone; Dhamek Sarnath is Gupta.
5. Ajanta - 30 caves, only Buddhist, Waghora gorge, found 1819 by John Smith; tempera, not fresco.

6. Ellora - 34 caves, 12 Buddhist + 17 Hindu + 5 Jain; Cave 16 Kailasa by Krishna I.
7. Karle - largest chaitya; Barabar - Ashoka, given to Ajivikas; Hathigumpha - Kharavela, Odisha.
8. Nagara shikhara and open compound; Dravida vimana, gopuram and enclosure; Vesara hybrid - Kalyani Chalukyas and Hoysalas.
9. Gandhara grey schist Greco-Roman; Mathura spotted red sandstone; Amaravati white limestone.
10. Coins - punch-marked earliest, Indo-Greek portraits, Kushana first big gold, Gupta dinara.
11. Aryabhatiya 499 CE - rotation of the earth, eclipse by shadow, pi 3.1416; Brahmagupta 628 CE - rules for zero.
12. Sushruta - surgery; Charaka - medicine; Vagbhata - Ashtanga Hridaya; Nagarjuna - Rasaratnakara.
13. Mehrauli iron pillar - King Chandra, rust-free for about 1600 years; Sulbasutras - geometry of fire altars.
14. Varna from the Purusha Sukta, Rigveda tenth mandala; varna is fourfold, jati runs into thousands.
15. Ashrama order B-G-V-S, 25 years each, Grihastha supports the rest; Purushartha order D-A-K-M.
16. Sixteen sanskaras from Garbhadhana to Antyeshti; Antyeshti is the only posthumous one; Upanayana opens studentship.
17. Three Rinas from the Taittiriya Samhita - Deva by yajna, Rishi by svadhyaya, Pitri by progeny.
18. Pancha Mahayajna - Brahma, Deva, Pitri, Bhuta, Nri - the householder's five daily duties.
19. Darshana founders - Gautama, Kanada, Kapila, Patanjali, Jaimini, Badarayana; nastika are Charvaka, Buddhism, Jainism.
20. Nalanda under Kumaragupta I, head Shilabhadra, sacked c. 1193; Vikramshila and Somapura by Dharmapala, Odantapuri by Gopala, Valabhi by the Maitrakas.

IH06

Delhi Sultanate

2-3 questions a paper. The two proven hotspots are Alauddin Khalji's market regulations (2024, a full statement question plus a source question) and Krishnadevaraya with the Ashtadiggajas (2021, 2023 and 2024 - three papers running). There is also a permanent Rajasthan hook: Aibak built the Adhai Din ka Jhonpra at Ajmer, and Alauddin took Ranthambore in 1301 and Chittor in 1303.

Three hundred and twenty years, five dynasties, one throne. From Aibak in 1206 to Ibrahim Lodi at Panipat in 1526. RPSC asks this chapter through administration and personalities - Alauddin Khalji's market control, Muhammad bin Tughlaq's experiments, Firoz Shah's taxes - plus Vijayanagara, which it has now asked in three consecutive papers.

Delhi Sultanate 1206-1526

Slave / Mamluk 1206-90

- Aibak - Lakh Baksh
- Iltutmish - Iqta, Chalisa, tanka
- Raziya - only woman ruler
- Balban - Zill-i-Ilahi, sijda

Sayyid and Lodi

- Khizr Khan 1414
- Bahlul Lodi 1451 - first Afghan
- Sikandar Lodi - Agra 1504
- Ibrahim Lodi - Panipat 1526

Khalji 1290-1320

- Jalaluddin Firoz - founder
- Alauddin - market control
- Kharaj 50%, masahat
- Gujarat, Ranthambore, Chittor, Malwa
- Malik Kafur in the Deccan

Administration

- Diwan-i-Wizarat, Arz, Insha, Risalat, Qaza
- Iqta - muqti, fawazil
- Tanka and jital

Tughlaq 1320-1414

- Ghiyasuddin - Tughlaqabad
- Muhammad bin Tughlaq - five experiments
- Ibn Battuta - Rihla
- Firoz Shah - canals, jizya, Ashokan pillars

The south

- Vijayanagara 1336 - Harihara and Bukka
- Krishnadevaraya - Amuktamalyada
- Ashtadiggajas
- Talikota 1565
- Bahmani 1347 - Mahmud Gawan

From Tarain to Delhi - how the Sultanate begins

Turkish rule in north India is settled by two battles at the same place. In 1191 Prithviraj Chauhan III beat Muhammad Ghori at Tarain. In 1192 Ghori came back and beat Prithviraj at the same field. Two years later Ghori defeated Jaichandra of Kannauj at Chandawar. After Ghori's death his slave-general Qutbuddin Aibak declared himself sultan at Lahore in 1206, and the Delhi Sultanate begins. Note the pattern the examiner likes: first Tarain the Rajput won, second Tarain the Turk won.

- First Battle of Tarain, 1191 - Prithviraj Chauhan III defeated Muhammad Ghori.
- Second Battle of Tarain, 1192 - Ghori defeated Prithviraj.
- Battle of Chandawar, 1194 - Ghori defeated Jaichandra of Kannauj.
- Delhi Sultanate runs 1206 to 1526.

The five dynasties with dates - learn this as one string



YAAD RAKHO

Five dynasties, one order: Slave, Khalji, Tughlaq, Sayyid, Lodi - S-K-T-S-L.
 And anchor four dates: 1206 start, 1290 Khalji, 1320 Tughlaq, 1526 end.
 Ordering questions on the five dynasties are a standing RAS format.

The Slave or Mamluk dynasty - the state gets built

Mamluk means a slave of Turkish origin who rose to be an officer. Aibak founded the line but ruled only four years and left everything unfinished. The real builder is Iltutmish. He moved the capital from Lahore to Delhi, created the iqta system to pay his soldiers with land revenue instead of cash, formed the Chalisa or corps of forty Turkish nobles to run the state, and issued the two coins the Sultanate then used for three centuries - the silver tanka and the copper jital. He also got formal recognition from the Abbasid Caliph in 1229, which made his rule legitimate in Islamic law.

- Qutbuddin Aibak (1206-1210) - called Lakh Baksh, giver of lakhs, for his charity.
 - Began the Qutb Minar; built the Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque at Delhi and the Adhai Din ka Jhonpra at Ajmer.
 - Died at Lahore falling from his horse while playing chaugan, that is polo.
 - The Ajmer link matters for RAS - Adhai Din ka Jhonpra appears in the Rajasthan architecture chapter too.
-
- Iltutmish (1211-1236) - the real consolidator; shifted the capital from Lahore to Delhi.
 - Created the Iqta system and the Turkan-i-Chahalgani, the Chalisa or corps of forty.
 - Issued the silver tanka and the copper jital; completed the Qutb Minar.
 - Received investiture from the Abbasid Caliph in 1229.
-
- Raziya (1236-1240) - the only woman ever to rule the Delhi Sultanate.
 - Nominated by Iltutmish over his own sons - a deliberate choice, not an accident.
 - Raised the Abyssinian Jamal-ud-din Yaqut to Amir-i-Akhur, master of the horse.
 - Overthrown by the Turkish nobility, who would not accept a woman ruler.

- Balban (1266-1287) - kingship as Zill-i-Ilahi, the Shadow of God on earth.
- Introduced sijda, prostration before the sultan, and paibos, kissing his feet; revived the Persian Nauroz.
- Destroyed the Chalisa that had made him - the forty were the rival power centre.
- Blood and iron policy; created the Diwan-i-Arz, the military department, and an espionage network of barids.

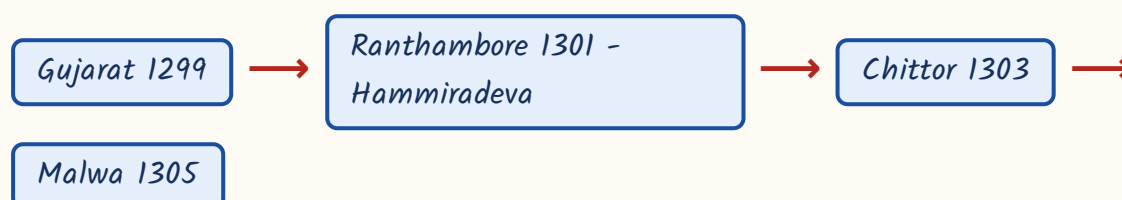
TRAP

Aibak began the Qutb Minar, Iltutmish completed it - do not credit either with the whole. And Balban was not the last Slave ruler; weak successors followed him before the Khaljis took over in 1290.

The Khaljis - Alauddin's conquests

The Khalji dynasty was founded by Jalaluddin Firoz Khalji in 1290. He was old and mild, and his nephew and son-in-law Alauddin was neither. Alauddin raided Devagiri in the Deccan in 1296, came back loaded with treasure, murdered his uncle and seized the throne. That Deccan wealth is what financed everything he then did. Then he swept the north-west and Rajasthan, and sent Malik Kafur south.

Alauddin's conquests in order - a proven ordering question



- Malik Kafur's Deccan campaigns hit Devagiri, Warangal, Dwarasamudra and Madurai.
- The Deccan kingdoms were made tributaries rather than annexed.
- Ranthambore and Chittor tie this chapter directly to Rajasthan History - Hammiradeva of Ranthambore and the 1303 siege of Chittor.
- Alauddin was the first Sultan to attempt a systematic control of prices.
- Alauddin built the Alai Darwaza in 1311, the Siri fort and the Hauz-i-Alai (Hauz Khas).
- The Alai Minar, meant to dwarf the Qutb Minar, was left unfinished.
- Amir Khusrau, called Tuti-i-Hind, the Parrot of India, wrote Khazain-ul-Futuh and Qiran-us-Sadain.
- Khusrau served several sultans, not Alauddin alone - a common trap option.

Alauddin Khalji's market and revenue reforms - the single most asked topic here

Understand why before you learn what. Alauddin needed a very large standing army to face Mongol raids, and he paid it in cash. A large army paid in fixed cash salaries only works if prices stay fixed too - otherwise the salary buys less each year and the soldiers desert. So the price control was not welfare policy; it was military finance. That reasoning is worth writing down, because RPSC's statement questions on this topic reward understanding the system, not just naming officers.

Alauddin's control system under three heads



- Four markets were regulated - the grain mandi; the Sarai Adl for cloth and manufactures; a market for horses, slaves and cattle; and a general market.
- Prices were fixed by the Sultan and enforced, not negotiated.
- Grain was stockpiled in state granaries so supply could be released when traders held back.
- Merchants were registered and the fixed rates were enforced on pain of punishment.
- Diwan-i-Riyasat - the officer in overall charge of the markets.
- Shahna-i-Mandi - superintendent of the grain market.
- Barids - intelligence officers; munhiyans - secret spies.
- Barids and munhiyans reported on the markets directly to the Sultan, bypassing the officials they watched.
- The fullest account is Ziauddin Barani's Tarikh-i-Firuz Shahi.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2024 set a statement question on exactly this: the Diwan-i-Riyasat was in overall charge, the Shahna-i-Mandi supervised the grain market, and barids and munhiyans reported directly to the Sultan. All three statements were correct. Learn the three names and who they answered to.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2024 also asked where our fullest account of the market regulations comes from. Answer - the Tarikh-i-Firuz Shahi of Ziauddin Barani. Note the trap in the title: Barani's book is named after Firoz Shah Tughlaq but is our main source for Alauddin Khalji.

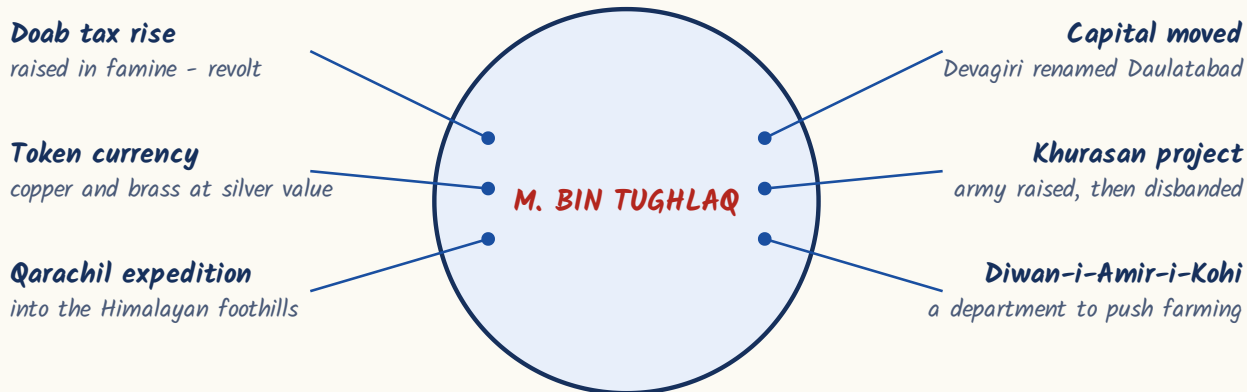
- Revenue side - kharaj raised to 50 per cent of produce, the highest in the Sultanate.
- Assessment by measurement, masahat, on the yield per biswa - not by guess or by sharing.
- Two new taxes added - ghari, a house tax, and charai, a grazing tax.
- The privileges of the khuts, muqaddams and chaudharis, the rural intermediaries, were abolished.
- Diwan-i-Mustakhraj created to recover arrears; milk, inam and waqf grants were resumed by the state.

The Tughlaqs - the reformer who failed and the one who lasted

Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq founded the dynasty in 1320 and built the fortified city of Tughlaqabad. His son Muhammad bin Tughlaq, 1325 to 1351, is the most discussed sultan of the whole period. He was learned, original and disastrous. Every one of his major projects was defensible on paper and failed in practice - which is exactly why examiners like him. Learn the five experiments as a set, and learn one reason for each failure.

Take the two most asked. The capital transfer: Devagiri, renamed Daulatabad, sits in the middle of the empire and was the sensible administrative centre - but he moved the whole population of Delhi, not just the government, and the march killed people; he then reversed it. The token currency: copper and brass coins issued at the value of silver would have worked if the mint had been a state monopoly - but the coins had no distinctive mark, households forged them freely, and the treasury had to redeem the forgeries. It failed on counterfeiting, not on the idea.

The experiments of Muhammad bin Tughlaq, 1325-1351



- Increase of taxation in the Doab - imposed during famine, it provoked revolt.
- Transfer of the capital from Delhi to Devagiri, renamed Daulatabad.
- Token currency in copper and brass at the value of silver - widely counterfeited.
- The Khurasan project - a huge army raised for a foreign expedition, then disbanded.
- The Qarachil expedition into the Himalayan foothills - destroyed by terrain and weather.
- Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi created to promote agriculture - a state department for farming.

- Ibn Battuta, the Moroccan traveller, was made qazi of Delhi by Muhammad bin Tughlaq.
- He was later sent as envoy to China; his account is the Rihla.
- Firoz Shah Tughlaq (1351-1388) dug the largest canal network of the Sultanate.
- He levied four taxes on the Islamic model - kharaj, zakat, jizya, khams - and added the irrigation cess haqq-i-sharb at one-tenth.
- He was the first to impose jizya on Brahmanas, who had been exempt before.
- Founded Firozabad, Hisar, Fatehabad and Jaunpur; set up the Diwan-i-Khairat, a charity department, and the Dar-ul-Shafa, a free hospital.
- Brought Ashokan pillars from Topra and Meerut to Delhi; his memoir is the Futuh-i-Firozshahi.

Alauddin Khalji against Muhammad bin Tughlaq - the standard contrast

Alauddin Khalji	Muhammad bin Tughlaq
Controlled prices to pay a cash army	Issued token currency to stretch the treasury
Kharaj at 50 per cent, measured by masahat	Raised Doab taxes during a famine
Kept Delhi as capital and fortified Siri	Moved the capital to Daulatabad and back
Made the Deccan tributary through Malik Kafur	Tried to hold the Deccan directly and lost it
Ruthless but effective	Original but unworkable

TRAP

Muhammad bin Tughlaq's token currency was copper and brass, not leather and not paper. And it failed because it was easily counterfeited, not because people refused to accept it.

Sayyids, Lodis, and how the Sultanate was run

After Timur sacked Delhi in 1398, during the reign of Nasiruddin Mahmud Tughlaq, the Sultanate never recovered its reach. The Sayyids and Lodis ruled a shrunken kingdom. The Lodis matter for one reason: they were Afghans, not Turks, and Afghan nobles treated the king as first among equals rather than as a master. Ibrahim Lodi tried to reverse that, alienated his nobles, and one of them invited Babur. That is how 1526 happens.

- Timur invaded and sacked Delhi in 1398, under Nasiruddin Mahmud Tughlaq.
- Sayyid dynasty founded by Khizr Khan in 1414, Timur's deputy at Multan; last ruler Alam Shah.
- Lodi dynasty founded by Bahlul Lodi in 1451 - the first Afghan dynasty of Delhi.
- Sikandar Lodi founded Agra in 1504, introduced the Gaz-i-Sikandari measure, wrote Persian verse as Gulrukhi.
- Ibrahim Lodi was defeated and killed by Babur at the First Battle of Panipat, 21 April 1526.

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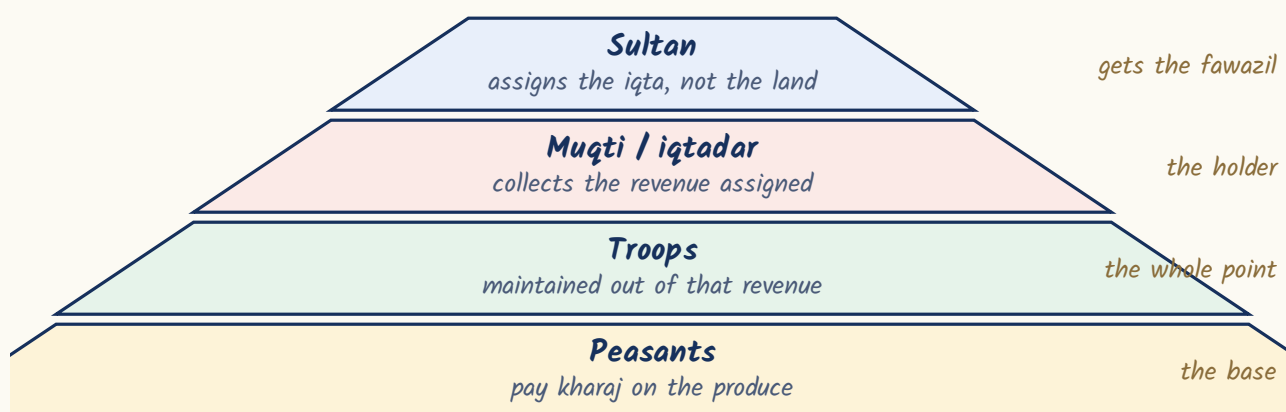
Current link: April 2026 completed five hundred years since the First Battle of Panipat, fought on 21 April 1526, where Babur defeated and killed Ibrahim Lodi and the Delhi Sultanate ended. Position as of September 2026. Round-number anniversaries are a standing source for the current-affairs block, so keep the three Panipats apart - 1526 Babur against Ibrahim Lodi, 1556 Akbar's side against Hemu, 1761 the Marathas against Ahmad Shah Abdali.

The central departments - diwan means department

Department	Charge	Head
Diwan-i-Wizarat	Finance and revenue	Wazir
Diwan-i-Arz	Military	Ariz-i-Mamalik
Diwan-i-Insha	Royal correspondence	Dabir-i-Khas
Diwan-i-Risalat	Religious affairs and appeals	Sadr-us-Sudur
Diwan-i-Qaza	Justice	Qazi-ul-Quzat

- *Iqta* was a revenue assignment, not ownership of land - this distinction is the exam point.
- The holder was the *muqti* or *iqtdar*; he maintained troops from the revenue and remitted the surplus, called *fawazil*.
- Formalised by *Iltutmish*; made transferable and strictly audited under *Alauddin Khalji*.
- *Firoz Shah* made *iqtas* hereditary - which weakened central control.
- Coins - the silver *tanka* and the copper *jital*, both from *Iltutmish* onwards.

The *iqta* - a revenue assignment, never land ownership



TRAP

An *iqta* is not a *jagir* in the Mughal sense and it is never land ownership. The *muqti* collects revenue, pays troops and sends the surplus up. If an option says the *iqtdar* owned the land, it is wrong.

Provincial kingdoms – the Sultanate breaks into pieces

Every time Delhi weakened, a governor declared independence. By the fifteenth century there were half a dozen rich regional sultanates, each with its own architecture and its own court language. RPSC asks these purely as matching – kingdom to ruler, or kingdom to monument. Four rows will carry you.

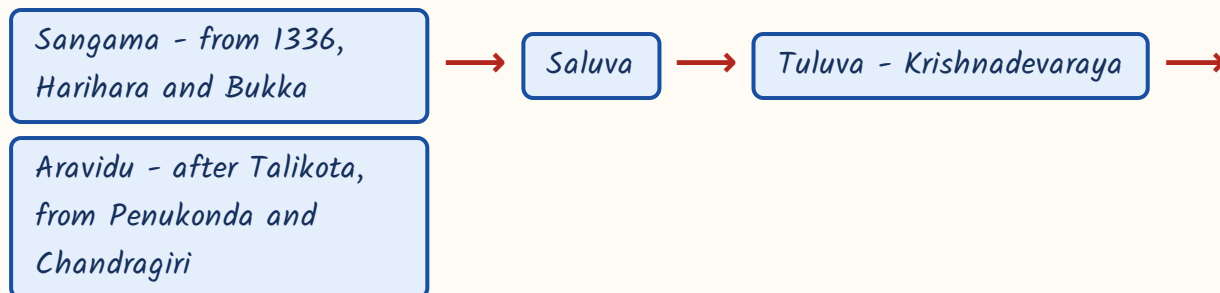
Provincial kingdom to the fact that gets asked

Kingdom	Ruler or dynasty	Remember this
Jaunpur	Sharqi dynasty	Atala Masjid; called the Shiraz of the East
Gujarat	Ahmad Shah	Founded Ahmedabad
Malwa	Sultans of Mandu	Jahaz Mahal at Mandu
Kashmir	Zain-ul-Abidin	Called Budshah, the great king; religious tolerance, Sanskrit patronage
Bengal	Ilyas Shahi and Hussain Shahi	Independent from Delhi through most of this period

Vijayanagara – asked in three consecutive papers, so do it properly

Vijayanagara was founded in 1336 by two brothers, Harihara and Bukka, of the Sangama dynasty, traditionally on the advice of the sage Vidyananya. The capital was Hampi on the Tungabhadra. Four dynasties ruled in succession, and the empire's whole purpose was to hold the south against the Bahmani sultans. RPSC has asked Krishnadevaraya in 2021, 2023 and 2024 – three papers running. That is as clear a signal as this exam ever gives.

The four Vijayanagara dynasties in order



- Krishnadevaraya ruled 1509-1529 and belonged to the Tuluva dynasty.
- Titles - Andhra Bhoja and Abhinava Bhoja.
- Wrote the Amuktamalyada in Telugu and the Jambavati Kalyanam in Sanskrit.
- Built the Vitthalaswamy and Hazara Rama temples at Hampi and founded the town of Nagalapuram.
- The Amuktamalyada is also a treatise on statecraft, not only a poem.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2024 asked who composed the Telugu work Amuktamalyada - answer, Krishnadevaraya himself. RAS Pre 2023 asked which court poet bore the title Andhra Kavita Pitamaha - answer, Allasani Peddana. RAS Pre 2024 also asked in which language Mallanarya, a poet he patronised, wrote - answer, Kannada. Note that last one: Krishnadevaraya's patronage was not Telugu only.

The Ashtadiggajas - the eight Telugu poets of his court

Poet	Work or title
Allasani Peddana	Manucharitramu (Swarochisha Manu Sambhavam); title Andhra Kavita Pitamaha
Nandi Thimmana	Parijatapaharanam
Tenali Ramakrishna	Panduranga Mahatmyamu
Pingali Surana	Raghavapandaveeyamu
Dhurjati	Court poet, devotional verse on Srikalahasti

Poet	Work or title
Madayyagari Mallana	One of the eight
Ayyalaraju Ramabhadru	One of the eight
Ramarajabhushanudu (Bhattumurti)	One of the eight

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023 set a match-the-following on poet and work: Peddana with Manucharitramu, Nandi Thimmana with Parijatapaharanam, Tenali Ramakrishna with Panduranga Mahatmyamu, Pingali Surana with Raghavapandaveeyamu. Those four pairs are the ones that get used. Memorise the four; recognise the other four names.

- Administration - the Nayankara system of military assignments to nayakas.
- The Ayagar system - twelve hereditary village functionaries running the village.
- Foreign visitors - Nicolo Conti (Italian), Abdur Razzaq (Persian), Domingo Paes, Fernao Nuniz and Duarte Barbosa (Portuguese).
- Battle of Talikota, also called Rakshasa-Tangadi, 1565 - the allied Deccan sultanates defeated Rama Raya and sacked Hampi.
- After Talikota the Aravidu dynasty ruled from Penukonda and later Chandragiri.

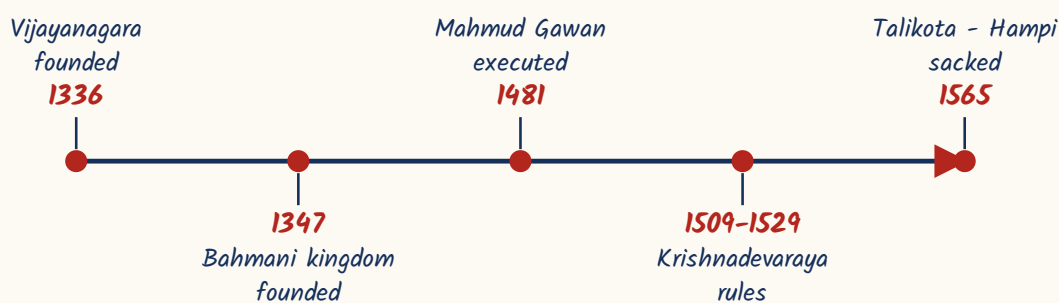
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Current link: Hampi, the Group of Monuments at the Vijayanagara capital, was inscribed by UNESCO in 1986 and spent 1999 to 2006 on the List of World Heritage in Danger before being taken off it. Position as of September 2026. RPSC's current-affairs block regularly pairs a heritage site with its listing status, and Hampi is the one it reaches for in this chapter.

The Bahmani kingdom and its successors

The Bahmani kingdom was the Muslim power of the Deccan and Vijayanagara's permanent rival - the two fought for over two centuries, mostly over the Raichur Doab between the Krishna and the Tungabhadra. It was founded in 1347 by Alauddin Hasan Bahman Shah, better known as Hasan Gangu, after a revolt against Muhammad bin Tughlaq. Its greatest administrator was not a king but a wazir, Mahmud Gawan, and his story is the one that gets asked.

Vijayanagara and the Bahmanis - the five dates



- Founded 1347 by Alauddin Hasan Bahman Shah (Hasan Gangu).
- First capital Gulbarga, shifted to Bidar by Ahmad Shah Wali.
- Mahmud Gawan was wazir under Muhammad Shah III.
- He divided the kingdom into eight tarafs or provinces, tightening central control.
- He built the celebrated madrasa at Bidar and was executed in 1481 on a forged charge - after which the kingdom broke up.

- Five successor states of the Bahmani kingdom, all founded around 1490-1518.
- Adil Shahi at Bijapur; Nizam Shahi at Ahmadnagar; Imad Shahi at Berar.
- Qutb Shahi at Golconda; Barid Shahi at Bidar.
- It was an alliance of these Deccan sultanates that destroyed Vijayanagara at Talikota in 1565.

REVISION RECAP

1. Tarain 1191 Prithviraj won, Tarain 1192 Ghoris won, Chandawar 1194 Jaichandra defeated.
2. Five dynasties in order - Slave 1206, Khalji 1290, Tughlaq 1320, Sayyid 1414, Lodi 1451-1526.
3. Aibak - Lakh Baksh, Quwwat-ul-Islam at Delhi, Adhai Din ka Jhonpra at Ajmer, died playing chaugan.
4. Iltutmish - capital to Delhi, iqta, Chalisa, tanka and jital, completed Qutb Minar, Caliph's investiture 1229.
5. Raziya - only woman ruler, raised Yaqut as Amir-i-Akbar, overthrown by the Turkish nobles.
6. Balban - Zill-i-Ilahi, sijda and paibos, Nauroz, destroyed the Chalisa, created Diwan-i-Arz and the barids.
7. Alauddin's conquests in order - Gujarat 1299, Ranthambore 1301, Chittor 1303, Malwa 1305; Malik Kafur in the Deccan.
8. Market control - Diwan-i-Riyasat over all, Shahna-i-Mandi over grain, barids and munhiyans direct to the Sultan; source Barani.
9. Revenue - kharaj 50 per cent, masahat measurement per biswa, ghari and charai, Diwan-i-Mustakhraj.
10. Alai Darwaza 1311, Siri, Hauz-i-Alai; Alai Minar unfinished; Amir Khusrau Tuti-i-Hind.
11. Muhammad bin Tughlaq - Doab tax, Daulatabad transfer, token currency in copper and brass, Khurasan and Qarachil, Diwan-i-Amir-i-Kohi.
12. Ibn Battuta made qazi of Delhi, sent to China, wrote the Rihla.
13. Firoz Shah - canals, four Islamic taxes plus haqq-i-sharb one-tenth, jizya on Brahmanas, Ashokan pillars from Topra and Meerut, Futuhat-i-Firozshahi.
14. Timur sacked Delhi 1398; Khizr Khan 1414; Bahlul Lodi 1451 first Afghan; Sikandar Lodi founded Agra 1504; Panipat 21 April 1526.
15. Five diwans - Wizarat finance, Arz military, Insha correspondence, Risalat religious, Qaza justice.

16. *Iqta is a revenue assignment; muqti keeps troops and remits fawazil; hereditary under Firoz Shah.*
17. *Jaunpur Sharqis and the Atala Masjid, Shiraz of the East; Zain-ul-Abidin Budshah of Kashmir; Ahmad Shah founded Ahmedabad.*
18. *Vijayanagara 1336 Harihara and Bukka, Vidyaranya, Hampi on the Tungabhadra; Sangama, Saluva, Tuluva, Aravidu.*
19. *Krishnadevaraya 1509-1529, Tuluva, Andhra Bhoja, Amuktamalyada in Telugu, Jambavati Kalyanam in Sanskrit; Peddana Andhra Kavita Pitamaha.*
20. *Nayankara and Ayagar systems; Talikota 1565 defeated Rama Raya; Bahmani 1347 Hasan Gangu, Gulbarga to Bidar, Mahmud Gawan's eight tarafs, executed 1481.*

IH07

Mughal Empire and the Marathas

The heaviest single chapter in Indian History - expect 2-3 questions a paper from the medieval block, and most of them land here. Proven repeaters: Sher Shah's monuments and his rupiya (2024), Akbar's Razmnama and the Panch Mahal (2016 and 2023), the Ashtapradhan, the three Panipats and the Anglo-Maratha treaties.

Two centuries of Mughal rule and the Maratha power that broke it. RPSC never asks you to argue about the Mughals - it asks you to date them and to name the officer, the coin, the building, the treaty. Learn this chapter as a set of tables, not as a story.

Mughals and Marathas (1526-1818)

Babur & Humayun

- Panipat I - 21 Apr 1526
- Khanwa 1527 - title Ghazi
- Tuzuk-i-Baburi (Chaghatai Turkish)
- Din Panah; Sher Mandal fall, 1556

Sur interlude 1540-55

- Farid Khan = Sher Shah
- Chausa 1539, Kannauj 1540
- Rupiya 178 grains, dam
- Sasaram tomb; Qila-i-Kuhna 1541
- Sadak-i-Azam (GT Road)

Akbar 1556-1605

- Panipat II - 5 Nov 1556, Hemu
- Ibadat Khana 1575, Mahzar 1579
- Din-i-Ilahi 1582, Sulh-i-Kul
- Fatehpur Sikri 1571, Panch Mahal
- Razmnama = Mahabharata

Administration

- Mansabdari - zat and sawar
- Dahsala/Zabti 1580 - Todar Mal
- 12 subas in 1580 (15 later)
- Diwan, Mir Bakhshi, Mir Saman
- Ain-i-Akbari = vol. 3

Jahangir to Aurangzeb

- Zanjir-i-adl; Nur Jahan's coins
- Dharmat-Samugarh-Khajwa-Deorai
- Jizya reimposed 1679
- Bijapur 1686, Golconda 1687
- Died 1707, buried Khuldabad

The Rajput angle

- Bharmal of Amber, 1562
- Chittor 1568 - Jaimal & Patta
- Haldighati 1576 - Man Singh
- Amar Singh treaty 1615
- Rajput war 1679-81, Durgadas

Decline

- Jagirdari crisis; paibaqi shortage
- Farrukhsiyar's farman 1717
- Karnal 1739 - Nadir Shah
- Peacock Throne & Kohinoor gone

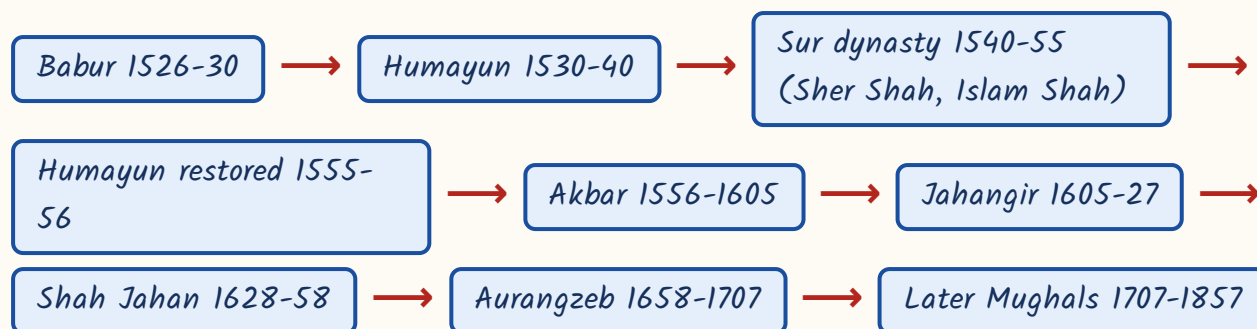
Marathas

- Raigad coronation, 6 June 1674
- Ashtapradhan - eight ministers
- Chauth 1/4, Sardeshmukhi 1/10
- Peshwas hereditary from 1713
- Panipat III - 14 Jan 1761
- Salbai 1782, Bassein 1802

The spine - hold the whole chapter on one line of succession

Before any fact, fix the order of rulers. Almost every trap in this chapter works by moving a fact one emperor up or down the line. Six great Mughals, and an Afghan interruption of fifteen years in the middle. Say the line out loud until it is automatic.

The line of succession - and the Sur break in the middle



- Babur was a Timurid on his father's side and a Chingizid on his mother's - that double descent is why he claimed both Samargand and Delhi.
- Humayun is the only Mughal who lost the empire and won it back; he ruled twice.
- Akbar came to the throne at thirteen; Bairam Khan was regent till 1560.
- Aurangzeb ruled forty-nine years, the longest reign - and the empire was at its largest and weakest by its end.
- Bahadur Shah Zafar was the last, deposed after 1857 and deported to Rangoon.

YAAD RAKHO

Eight date pegs cover half the chapter: 1526 Panipat I, 1556 Panipat II, 1576 Haldighati, 1615 Mewar treaty, 1674 Raigad, 1707 Aurangzeb dies, 1739 Karnal, 1761 Panipat III.

Babur and Humayun - the founding, and the losing of it

Babur did not walk in and take India in one battle. He fought four, in four consecutive years, and each removed a different rival - the Lodis, the Rajputs, a Rajput holdout in Malwa, and finally the Afghans of the east. Learn the four as a run of years: 1526, 1527, 1528, 1529. Then his son lost the whole thing in ten.

- First Battle of Panipat, 21 April 1526 - the first large-scale use of field artillery in India, with the tulughma flanking manoeuvre and the araba cart-and-rope formation.
- Khanwa, 17 March 1527, against Rana Sanga of Mewar - after it Babur declared the war a jihad and took the title Ghazi. That title comes from Khanwa, not Panipat.
- Chanderi 1528 against Medini Rai; Ghaghra 1529 against the Afghans and Nusrat Shah of Bengal.
- Babur's memoir is the Tuzuk-i-Baburi, written in Chaghatai Turkish, his mother tongue; Abdur Rahim Khan-i-Khanan rendered it into Persian as the Baburnama under Akbar.
- Babur died in 1530 at Agra; his body was later moved to Kabul as he had wished.

- Humayun's problem was that he divided the empire among his brothers - Kamran, Askari, Hindal - and then had to fight all three.
- Chausa 1539 and Kannauj (Bilgram) 1540 are two different battles a year apart, both against Humayun. Chausa gave Sher Khan the royal title Sher Shah; Kannauj gave him Delhi and drove Humayun out for fifteen years. Do not merge them.
- In exile he reached Persia; his son Akbar was born at Amarkot in Sindh in 1542, in the house of Rana Prasad.
- Humayun built Din Panah at Delhi, retook Delhi in 1555 and died in January 1556 falling from the staircase of the Sher Mandal inside the Purana Qila.
- Sources: Humayun-nama by Gulbadan Begum (Babur's daughter), Tazkirat-ul-Waqiat by Jauhar Aftabchi, his ewer-bearer.

Sher Shah Suri - five years, and the Mughals copied everything

Sher Shah ruled only from 1540 to 1545, but RPSC gives him more space than that suggests, because Akbar's whole administration is built on his. Learn him under three heads and you will get every question: who he was, how he governed, and what he built. The 2024 paper asked his tomb, his mosque and a 'which is NOT his' question - all three out of the same small pool.

- Original name Farid Khan, son of Hasan Khan Sur, a jagirdar of Sasaram in Bihar.
- The title 'Sher Khan' was given by Bahar Khan Lohani of Bihar, traditionally for killing a tiger.
- He beat Humayun at Chausa (1539) and Kannauj (1540) and ruled from Delhi as Sher Shah.
- He died on 22 May 1545 at the siege of Kalinjar, hit by an exploding gunpowder magazine; his son Islam Shah succeeded him.

Now the administration, which is the part actually asked. His system worked because it reached below the province, right down to the pargana, and because he paid the army centrally instead of through land assignments. Four pargana officers, one job each - learn the pairs, they come as match-the-following.

Sher Shah's pargana officials

<i>Officer</i>	<i>Function</i>
<i>Shiqdar</i>	<i>Law and order, military charge of the pargana</i>
<i>Amin (Munsif)</i>	<i>Measurement and assessment of land revenue</i>
<i>Fotedar</i>	<i>Treasurer - kept the collected cash</i>
<i>Karkun</i>	<i>Clerk - kept the records, in Hindi and Persian</i>

- Mnemonic for the four: Shiqdar Sambhale (order), Amin Aanke (assess), Fotedar Fund (treasury), Karkun Kagaz (records).
- Above the pargana stood the sarkar, under a shiqdar-i-shiqdaran (order) and a munsif-i-munsifan (revenue and civil justice).
- Land was measured with the sikandari gaz and the rope; revenue was fixed at about one-third of the average produce, payable in cash or kind.
- Every peasant got a patta (title deed) and signed a qabuliyat (deed of agreement) - the state dealt with the cultivator directly.
- The army was recruited and paid centrally, with dagh (branding of horses) and chehra (descriptive roll) - Alauddin Khalji's device, revived.
- Silver rupiya of 178 grains and the copper dam - the direct ancestor of the modern rupee; his coins carried the mint name in Devanagari as well as Persian.
- Sadak-i-Azam, the Grand Trunk Road, revived from Sonargaon in Bengal to the Indus, with sarais and shade trees; four highways in all, and the sarais doubled as dak chowkis.
- Buildings: Qila-i-Kuhna Masjid (1541) inside the Purana Qila at Delhi, Rohtasgarh fort in Bihar, and his own tomb at Sasaram - octagonal, standing in an artificial lake, architect Aliwal Khan, finished 1545.
- Malik Muhammad Jayasi wrote the Padmavat in his reign.

Sher Shah's state - the machine Akbar inherited

Land measured
sikandari gaz; 1/3 of produce

Pargana officers
Shiqdar, Amin, Fotedar, Karkun

Army paid centrally
dagh and chehra revived

Sadak-i-Azam
Sonargaon to the Indus; sarais

SHER SHAH

Patta and qabuliyat
deed and counter-deed

Sarkar above it
order and revenue heads

Coinage
rupiya 178 grains; copper dam

Buildings
Qila-i-Kuhna 1541, Sasaram tomb

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2024 took three questions from this one page - the octagonal tomb in the middle of an artificial lake is Sher Shah's, at Sasaram (Bihar); the Qila-i-Kuhna Masjid stands inside the Purana Qila, Delhi; and in the negative format, the item NOT associated with Sher Shah was the Jahangiri Mahal, which is Akbar's work inside the Agra Fort.

The battle ledger - Panipat I to Panipat III

This is the single most useful table in the chapter. RPSC asks battles three ways - straight one-liner, chronological ordering, and 'who fought whom'. Keep this one ledger in your head and all three formats collapse into the same recall. Note one detail while you read it: Hemu was actually winning Panipat II until an arrow struck his eye and the elephant-borne commander fell.

Every battle you must be able to date, 1526 to 1761

Year	Battle	Contenders	Outcome
1526	Panipat I (21 Apr)	Babur vs Ibrahim Lodi	Babur wins; Lodi dynasty and the Sultanate end
1527	Khanwa (17 Mar)	Babur vs Rana Sanga of Mewar	Babur wins; takes the title Ghazi
1528	Chanderi	Babur vs Medini Rai	Babur wins; Malwa Rajput resistance ends
1529	Ghaghra	Babur vs Afghans and Nusrat Shah of Bengal	Babur wins; the east secured
1539	Chausa	Sher Khan vs Humayun	Sher Khan wins; assumes the title Sher Shah
1540	Kannauj / Bilgram	Sher Shah vs Humayun	Humayun driven out of India for 15 years
1556	Panipat II (5 Nov)	Bairam Khan, for Akbar, vs Hemu (Hemchandra Vikramaditya)	Mughal victory; Akbar's throne secured

Year	Battle	Contenders	Outcome
1576	Haldighati (18 Jun)	Man Singh and Asaf Khan vs Maharana Pratap	Mughal field victory; Pratap escapes and fights on
1658	Dharmat (Apr)	Aurangzeb and Murad vs Dara's army	Aurangzeb wins
1658	Samugarh (May)	Aurangzeb vs Dara Shukoh	Decisive - Dara's power broken
1659	Khajwa (Jan)	Aurangzeb vs Shah Shuja	Aurangzeb wins
1659	Deorai	Aurangzeb vs Dara Shukoh	Dara's last stand; executed soon after
1739	Karnal	Nadir Shah vs Muhammad Shah	Delhi sacked; Peacock Throne and Kohinoor carried off
1761	Panipat III (14 Jan)	Ahmad Shah Abdali vs Sadashivrao Bhau	Maratha disaster; Vishwasrao killed

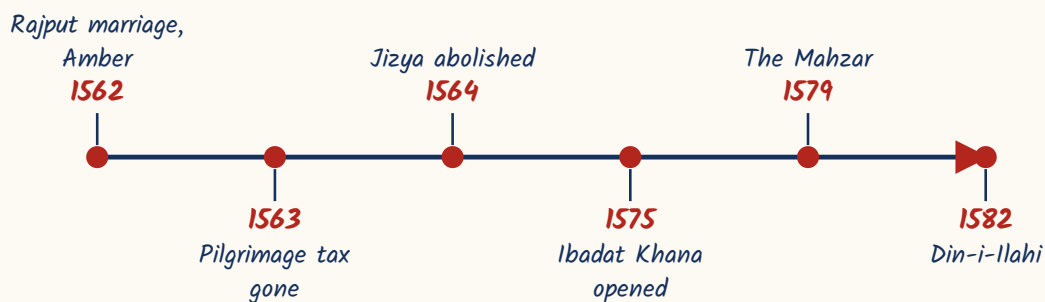
TRAP

The three Panipats are the classic mix-up. 1526 Babur vs Ibrahim Lodi. 1556 Bairam Khan (for Akbar) vs Hemu. 1761 Ahmad Shah Abdali vs the Marathas. In all three the loser's commander died on the field - Lodi, Hemu, Vishwasrao. Ordering questions in the bank: Panipat-Khanwa-Chanderi-Ghaghra for Babur, and Dharmat-Samugarh-Khajwa-Deorai for the succession war.

Akbar - Sulh-i-Kul and the religious experiment

Akbar's religious policy is asked as a chronology, not as an idea. Every step has a year, and the years run in a clean sequence: 1562 the Rajput marriage, 1563 the pilgrimage tax gone, 1564 the jizya gone, 1575 the Ibadat Khana, 1579 the Mahzar, 1582 the Din-i-Ilahi. Sulh-i-Kul, 'peace with all', is the umbrella term - it means the state takes no side between faiths.

Akbar's religious policy - one step at a time



- The Ibadat Khana was opened at Fatehpur Sikri in 1575, first to Muslim divines, then from 1578 to Hindus, Jains, Parsis, Christians and Charvakas.
- The Mahzar of 1579 made Akbar the final arbiter in disputed religious matters - it did not make him a prophet.
- Din-i-Ilahi (Tauhid-i-Ilahi), 1582, was an order of discipleship, not a religion with a scripture. Very few joined; Raja Birbal is named as the only Hindu adherent.
- Abul Fazl and Faizi, sons of Shaikh Mubarak, were the intellectual engine of the policy; Badauni, author of the Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh, was its bitterest critic - and was still ordered to translate the Ramayana.
- Fatehpur Sikri founded 1571, in thanksgiving for the birth of Salim, near the hospice of Shaikh Salim Chishti.
- Panch Mahal - five storeys, entirely columnar, no walls, 176 pillars in all, each storey smaller than the one below; eighty-four columns on the ground floor and a four-pillar kiosk at the top.
- Buland Darwaza, 1601, commemorates the Gujarat conquest of 1572-73; the loftiest gateway in India.
- The navaratnas: Abul Fazl, Faizi, Tansen, Birbal, Raja Todar Mal, Raja Man Singh, Abdur Rahim Khan-i-Khanan, Mulla Do-Pigaza, Hakim Humam (the last two vary between lists).
- Ain-i-Akbari is the third and concluding volume of Abul Fazl's Akbarnama - the richest single source for Mughal administration, revenue rates and provincial geography.

Sanskrit works turned into Persian at Akbar's court

Original	Persian title	Translator
Mahabharata	Razmnama ('Book of War')	Naqib Khan and associates; preface by Abul Fazl
Ramayana	-	Abdul Qadir Badauni
Lilavati (Bhaskaracharya)	-	Faizi

Original	Persian title	Translator
Panchatantra	Ayar Danish	Abul Fazl

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2016 and again in 2023 - the Razmnama is the Persian translation of the Mahabharata, and the five-storeyed columnar Panch Mahal at Fatehpur Sikri was built by Akbar. In 2023 the Panch Mahal came back as a statement question on its storeys and its pillars. Two facts, three appearances, one small pool.

TRAP

Do not call Din-i-Ilahi a religion Akbar imposed on India - no book, no priesthood, no compulsion, a handful of followers. And keep the two abolitions a year apart: pilgrimage tax 1563, jizya 1564. Aurangzeb brought the jizya back in 1679, 115 years later.

Akbar's machine - mansabdari, dahsala and the offices

Understand what a mansab is before you learn any number. A mansab is a rank in one single imperial service - there is no separate civil list and military list. Every noble, whether he commands cavalry or runs a treasury, holds a mansab. The rank carries two figures, and those two figures are the whole examinable content.

Zat vs Sawar - the two numbers of a mansab

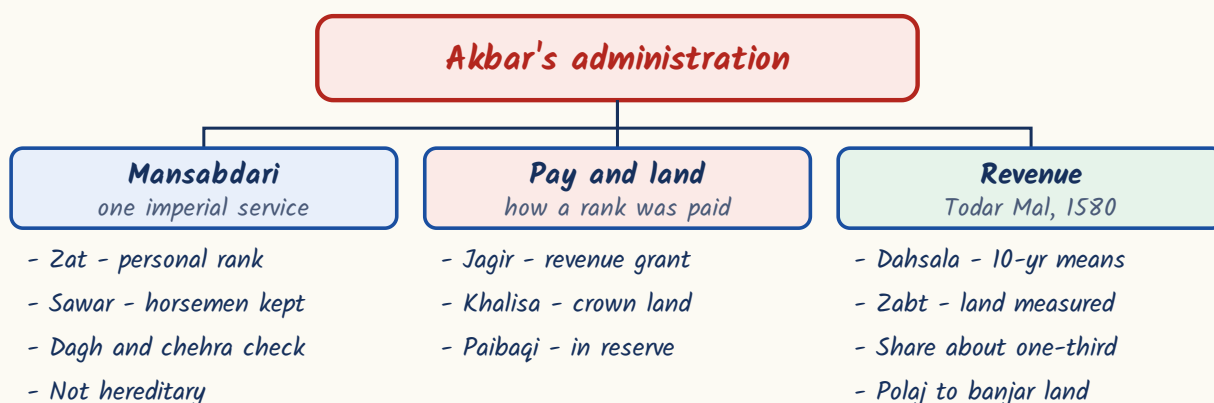
Zat	Sawar
Fixes personal rank, status and personal pay.	Fixes how many cavalymen the holder must maintain.
Decides seniority and place at court.	Decides the extra allowance paid for those horsemen.
Every mansabdar has a zat.	Sawar can never exceed zat, except in the special du-aspa sih-aspa grant.
Highest ordinary rank 5,000; princes went higher.	A noble whose sawar equalled his zat stood in the first class of his rank.

- Mansabs were neither hereditary nor permanent - on death the rank and the assignment reverted to the emperor.
- Dagh (branding of horses) and chehra (descriptive roll of the trooper) checked cheating at musters.
- Du-aspa sih-aspa - 'two-horse, three-horse' - was introduced by Jahangir, letting a favoured noble double his contingent without raising his zat.
- Ranks ran from 10 to 5,000 for nobles; Raja Man Singh of Amber held the highest mansab given to any Rajput.
- Payment was normally not in cash but by jagir - an assignment of the revenue of a tract, transferable, and never ownership of the land.
- Khalisa = crown land, its revenue going straight to the imperial treasury.
Paibagi = land held unassigned, in reserve, waiting to be given out as jagir.
- Akbar created 12 subas in 1580; the number reached 15 by the end of the reign with Berar, Khandesh and Ahmadnagar.

Now the revenue. Todar Mal's problem was that yields and prices swing every year, so a demand fixed on one year's harvest is unfair the next. His answer, the Dahsala of 1580, was to average. Take the produce and the prices of the previous ten years, average them, convert the state's share into cash per bigha, and publish the rate. The peasant then knows his demand in advance, and the state knows its income.

- *Dahsala or Ain-i-Dahsala, 1580, by Raja Todar Mal - the averages of the ten years 1570-71 to 1579-80.*
- *Also called Zabt, because it rested on measurement (zabt) of the land with the bamboo jarib.*
- *State share roughly one-third of the average produce, demanded in cash per bigha, crop by crop.*
- *Land was classed as polaj (cropped every year), parauti (fallow one year), chachar (fallow three to four years), banjar (waste over five years).*
- *The Karori experiment of 1574 was the trial run - karoris were appointed to collect a crore of dams each and to verify assessments.*

Rank, pay and land - the three parts of the system



The four Mughal revenue systems - method, not just name

System	How the demand was fixed
Zabt / Dahsala	Measurement of land plus the ten-year average of produce and prices; cash rate per bigha
Kankut	Eye estimate of the standing crop (kan = grain, kut = estimate)
Ghalla-bakhshi / Batai	Actual division of the harvested crop between state and peasant
Nasaq	Lump sum fixed from past collection figures - common in Bengal

Central and provincial officers - pure matching material

Officer	Level	Charge
Diwan-i-Ala	Centre	Revenue and finance
Mir Bakhshi	Centre	Military department - mansabs, musters, pay
Mir Saman	Centre	Imperial household and the karkhanas
Sadr-us-Sudur	Centre	Charity, grants and religious endowments
Qazi-ul-Quzat	Centre	Justice
Subedar / Sipahsalar	Suba	Governor of the province
Faujdar	Sarkar	Law and order - the armed arm of the district
Amil / Amalguzar	Pargana	Revenue collection
Kotwal	City	Policing, prices, weights, the night watch
Qanungo	Pargana	Custodian of revenue records

TRAP

The amil (amalguzar) is a revenue officer of the pargana, not a judge.

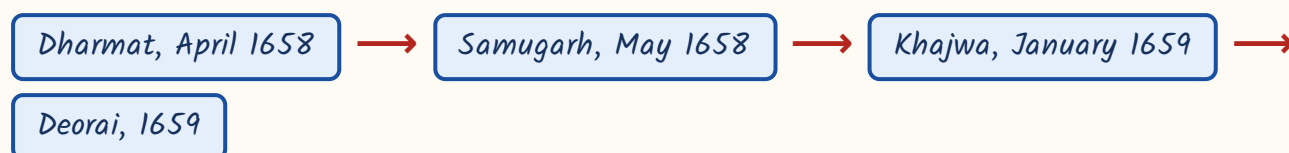
Judicial work in a province was the qazi's. The 'which pair is NOT correctly matched' question lives on exactly this slip.

Jahangir to Aurangzeb - and the fall that followed

Three reigns, and you need a small handful of facts from each. Jahangir for justice, Nur Jahan and the English envoys. Shah Jahan for buildings and the war of succession. Aurangzeb for policy reversals and the Deccan.

- Jahangir hung the zanjir-i-adl, a golden chain of justice, at Agra Fort, running from the fort wall down to the Jamuna bank.
- Nur Jahan (Mehr-un-Nisa) had coins struck in her name jointly with the emperor's, and her name entered royal farmans - unique for a Mughal queen.
- English at his court: Captain William Hawkins 1608-11, given a mansab and the title Khan; Sir Thomas Roe 1615-19, sent by James I.
- Jahangir's memoir is the Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri; the du-aspa sih-aspa rank is his.
- Shah Jahan's reign is the architectural peak - Taj Mahal, Red Fort, Jama Masjid Delhi, Moti Masjid Agra, the Peacock Throne; his chronicler was Abdul Hamid Lahori (Padshahnama).
- Shah Jahan was deposed in 1658 and kept at Agra Fort until his death in 1666.

War of succession, 1658-59 - the exam's favourite ordering question



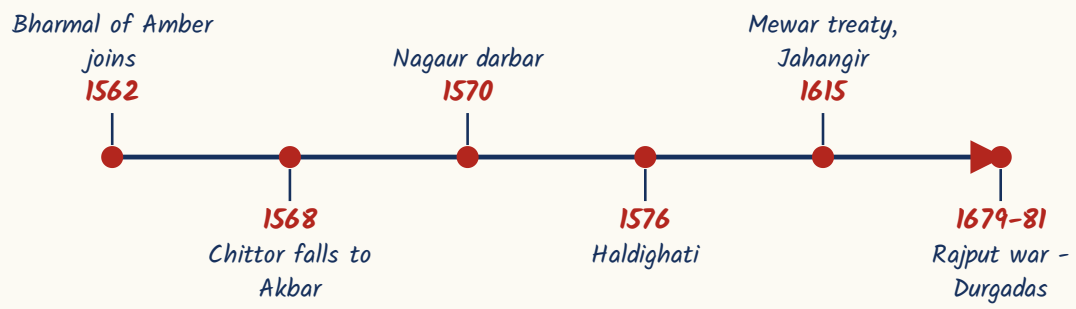
The decline that follows is not one event. The standard answer is the jagirdari crisis - too many nobles chasing too few productive jagirs. The Deccan wars added mansabdars faster than they added revenue, the reserve land ran out, assignments were made on paper that yielded nothing, and jagirdars squeezed the peasant to make up the gap between the paper figure (jama) and the actual collection (hasil).

- Four brothers in 1658: Dara Shukoh (Punjab), Shah Shuja (Bengal), Aurangzeb (Deccan), Murad Bakhsh (Gujarat). Aurangzeb crowned himself Alamgir; Dara was executed in 1659 on a charge of apostasy.
- Jizya reimposed 1679. Bijapur annexed 1686, Golconda 1687 - Bijapur FIRST, and the order is what gets asked.
- Fatawa-i-Alamgiri, a digest of Hanafi law, was compiled under his orders; he died in 1707 and lies in a plain grave at Khuldabad near Aurangabad.
- Later Mughals: Bahadur Shah I, Jahandar Shah, Farrukhsiyar (a puppet of the Sayyid brothers, the 'king makers'), Muhammad Shah 'Rangeela'.
- Farrukhsiyar's farman of 1717 gave the English Company duty-free trade in Bengal for Rs 3,000 a year - the Company's 'Magna Carta'.
- Nadir Shah beat Muhammad Shah at Karnal in 1739, sacked Delhi and took the Peacock Throne and the Kohinoor; Ahmad Shah Abdali invaded repeatedly from 1748.
- Successor states broke away: Bengal under Murshid Quli Khan, Awadh under Saadat Khan, Hyderabad under Nizam-ul-Mulk Asaf Jah in 1724.

The Rajput angle - where RPSC bends this chapter

This is a Rajasthan exam. Every Mughal reign gets re-asked from its Rajput side, and that side is also your bridge to the RH06 chapter. Read this as the same chronology told from Amber, Chittor and Jodhpur instead of from Agra.

The Mughals and the Rajputs - the dates that matter



- 1562 - Raja Bharmal of Amber is the first major Rajput chief to accept Mughal service; his daughter married Akbar, his son Bhagwant Das and grandson Man Singh rose to the very top.
- The alliance was not only matrimonial - Rajput chiefs kept their watan jagirs (homelands) and served as mansabdars elsewhere in the empire.
- 1568 - Chittor falls to Akbar; Jaimal and Patta (Fatta) die defending it, and Akbar set up their elephant-mounted statues at the Agra Fort gate.
- 1569 - Ranthambore surrenders under Surjan Hada and Kalinjar falls; 1570 - the Nagaur darbar brings in Bikaner and Jaisalmer.
- Mewar alone refused. Haldighati, 18 June 1576 - remember that the Mughal army was commanded by Raja Man Singh of Amber, with Asaf Khan. Akbar was not on the field, so this was Rajput against Rajput. Pratap escaped; Dewair in 1582 was his counter-stroke.
- 1615 - Rana Amar Singh I makes terms with Jahangir, negotiated by Prince Khurram: Mewar keeps Chittor but may not repair its fortifications, and the Rana need not attend court in person, sending his heir instead.
- Mirza Raja Jai Singh of Amber was Aurangzeb's commander against Shivaji - the Treaty of Purandar, 1665, is his work.
- 1678 - Maharaja Jaswant Singh of Marwar dies at Jamrud and Aurangzeb tries to bring Marwar under direct rule.
- 1679-81 - the Rajput war. Durgadas Rathore shields the infant Ajit Singh, Mewar's Rana Raj Singh joins the resistance, and Prince Akbar revolts against his father in 1681. Ajit Singh recovered Marwar only after Aurangzeb's death.
- Sawai Jai Singh II of Amber served the later Mughals, founded Jaipur in 1727 and built the Jantar Mantars.

Akbar's Rajput policy vs Aurangzeb's

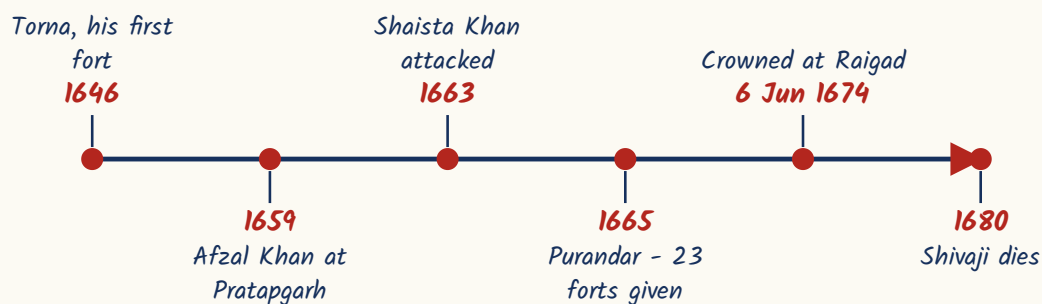
Akbar	Aurangzeb
Alliance by marriage and high mansabs; Rajputs as partners in the empire.	Suspicion and annexation; Marwar taken under imperial rule in 1679.
Pilgrimage tax and jizya abolished, 1563-64.	Jizya reimposed 1679 - a direct grievance for Rajput and Maratha chiefs alike.
Man Singh commands imperial armies from Kabul to Bengal.	Durgadas Rathore fights a long guerrilla war for Ajit Singh.
Mewar isolated, the rest of Rajputana integrated.	Marwar and Mewar in revolt together - the alliance breaks.

Shivaji and the Marathas - the power that broke the Mughals

The Marathas are examined in four blocks: Shivaji's campaigns, his administration, the Peshwas, and the wars with the English. His method was the fort and the fast light cavalry - never a set-piece battle if he could avoid one. Learn the encounters by name and date, then the council of eight, which comes as a straight match.

- Son of Shahji Bhonsle and Jijabai; guardian Dadaji Kondadev; born at Shivneri. First capture: Torna fort, 1646.
- 1659 - Afzal Khan of Bijapur killed at the foot of Pratapgarh and his army routed.
- 1663 - night attack on Shaista Khan, the Mughal governor, at Pune; he lost his fingers escaping.
- 1664 and 1670 - Surat, the richest Mughal port, sacked twice.
- 1665 - Treaty of Purandar with Mirza Raja Jai Singh: Shivaji surrendered 23 forts and kept 12. In 1666 he was taken to Agra, insulted at court, and escaped in a fruit basket.
- 6 June 1674 - crowned Chhatrapati at Raigad by the Banaras scholar Gaga Bhatt, with a new era, the Rajyabhisheka Shaka. He died in 1680.

Shivaji, fort to crown

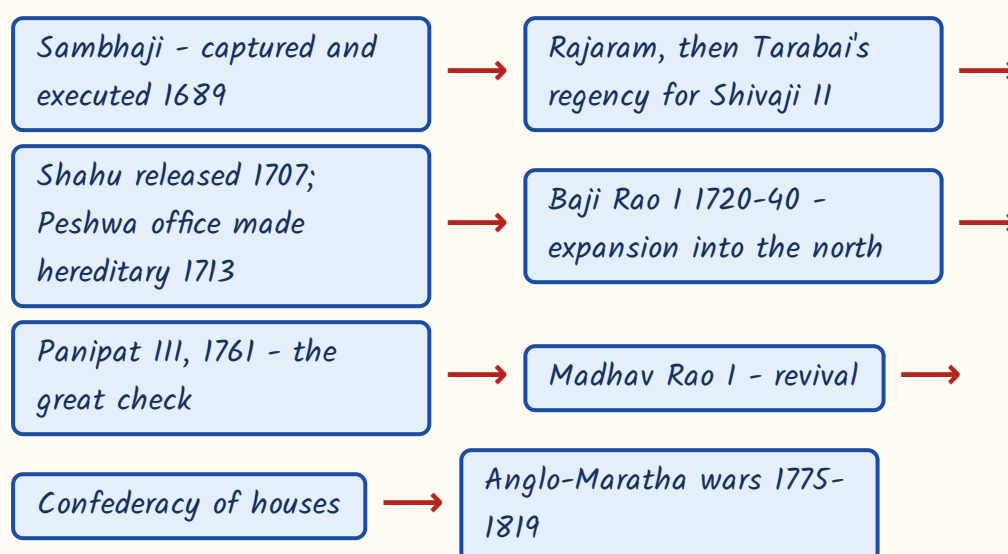


Shivaji's Ashtapradhan - the council of eight

Minister	Other name	Department
Peshwa	Mukhya Pradhan	Chief minister, general administration; first holder Moropant Trimbak Pingle
Amatya	Majumdar	Finance and revenue; audited the accounts
Sachiv	Surnavis	Royal correspondence and the checking of despatches
Mantri	Waqenavis	The king's personal records, daily journal and intelligence
Senapati	Sar-i-Naubat	Commander-in-chief of the army
Sumant	Dabir	Foreign affairs
Nyayadhish	-	Chief justice
Panditrao	Danadhyaksha	Religious affairs, charity and grants

- The Ashtapradhan was not a modern cabinet - ministers were not collectively responsible and could be posted to military command.
- Chauth = one-fourth of the assessed revenue of a territory; Sardeshmukhi = a further one-tenth, claimed as the hereditary right of the sardeshmukh.
- The two together are a protection levy, not a land tax - raised from lands outside Shivaji's own kingdom, and later from Malwa, Gujarat and the Rajput states.
- In his own swarajya, revenue was assessed on measured land at about one-third to two-fifths of the produce.
- A standing army on regular pay, and no hereditary jagirs for nobles - a deliberate rejection of the Mughal jagir model.
- Land forts (giri-durg), sea forts (jal-durg) and a navy: Raigad, Pratapgarh, Torna, Rajgad, Shivneri, Sindhudurg, Vijaydurg.

Maratha power after Shivaji



- Balaji Vishwanath, appointed Peshwa by Shahu in 1713, made the office hereditary in his Chitpavan Brahmin family and secured the Mughal grant of chauth and sardeshmukhi over the Deccan in 1719.
- Baji Rao I - the greatest of them; beat the Nizam-ul-Mulk at Palkhed (1728) and again near Bhopal (1737-38); the idea of Hindu Pad Padshahi; took Bassein from the Portuguese in 1739.
- Balaji Baji Rao (Nana Saheb) was Peshwa at Panipat III; Madhav Rao I rebuilt the power after it; Baji Rao II was the last.
- Third Battle of Panipat, 14 January 1761 - the Maratha army under Sadashivrao Bhau with artillery under Ibrahim Khan Gardi, defeated by Ahmad Shah Abdali. Vishwasrao, the Peshwa's son, was killed. The Marathas fought without Rajput, Jat or Sikh allies.
- The confederacy, house to seat: Peshwa-Poona, Gaekwad-Baroda, Holkar-Indore, Scindia-Gwalior, Bhonsle-Nagpur.
- Sambhaji was executed in 1689, not 1681 - the statement question in the bank turns on exactly that year.

Anglo-Maratha Wars

War	Years	Key treaties and battles
First	1775-82	Treaty of Surat 1775; Convention of Wadgaon 1779; ended by the Treaty of Salbai 1782
Second	1803-05	Treaty of Bassein 1802, a subsidiary alliance, triggered it; Assaye 1803
Third	1817-19	Peshwa Baji Rao II deposed in 1818 and pensioned at Bithur; Maratha power ends

ASKED IN RAS

Repeatedly examined: chauth is one-fourth and sardeshmukhi one-tenth; the 1674 coronation was performed by Gaga Bhatt; the First Anglo-Maratha War ended with Salbai, not Bassein. The 'NOT correctly matched' version usually plants the Convention of Wadgaon in 1802 instead of 1779. Keep the three straight - Wadgaon 1779 a convention, Salbai 1782 ended the First War, Bassein 1802 began the Second.

CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of September 2026): 'Maratha Military Landscapes of India' - twelve forts, eleven in Maharashtra and Gingee in Tamil Nadu, including Shivneri, Raigad, Pratapgarrh, Vijaydurg and Sindhudurg - was inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage List on 11 July 2025 at the 47th session of the World Heritage Committee in Paris. It took India's tally to 44 sites. A fort-to-state or fort-to-Shivaji-event question from this list is very likely.

CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of September 2026): 2024 was the 350th year of Shivaji's coronation at Raigad on 6 June 1674, and the anniversary was marked through the year in Maharashtra. In the same year a wagh nakh (tiger claw) associated with Shivaji, held by the Victoria and Albert Museum in London, was brought to India on loan and put on public display at Satara from 19 July 2024. The coronation date, the place (Raigad) and the priest (Gaga Bhatt) are what a current-affairs hook of this kind is used to ask.

REVISION RECAP

1. Panipat I 1526 Babur-Ibrahim Lodi; Panipat II 1556 Bairam Khan-Hemu; Panipat III 1761 Abdali-Marathas.
2. Babur's four battles run 1526-27-28-29: Panipat, Khanwa, Chanderi, Ghaghra. The title Ghazi comes from Khanwa.

3. *Tuzuk-i-Baburi* in Chaghatai Turkish; the Persian *Baburnama* by Abdur Rahim Khan-i-Khanan.
4. Sher Shah = Farid Khan, title from Bahar Khan Lohani. Chausa 1539, Kannauj 1540, died at Kalinjar 22 May 1545.
5. Sher Shah: rupiya of 178 grains and the dam; octagonal Sasaram tomb in a lake (Aliwal Khan); Qila-i-Kuhna 1541 in the Purana Qila; Rohtasgarh; Sadak-i-Azam.
6. Sher Shah's pargana: shiqdar order, amin assessment, fotedar treasury, karkun records.
7. Humayun built Din Panah and died in 1556 off the Sher Mandal stairs; Humayun-nama by Gulbadan Begum.
8. Akbar's religious calendar: 1563 pilgrimage tax, 1564 jizya, 1575 Ibadat Khana, 1579 Mahzar, 1582 Din-i-Ilahi with Birbal the only Hindu adherent.
9. A mansab has two figures - zat is rank and personal pay, sawar is the cavalry contingent. Du-aspa sih-aspa is Jahangir's.
10. Dahsala 1580 by Todar Mal averages ten years of produce and prices, state share about one-third; the other systems are kankut, batai and nasaq.
11. Khalisa crown land, jagir salary assignment, paibaqi reserve. Twelve subas in 1580, fifteen by 1605. *Ain-i-Akbari* is volume three of the *Akbarnama*.
12. Centre: Diwan revenue, Mir Bakhshi military, Mir Saman household, Sadr-us-Sudur charity. Province: subedar, faujdar, amil, kotwal, qanungo.
13. Rajput arc: Amber 1562, Chittor 1568, Ranthambore 1569, Nagaur darbar 1570, Haldighati 1576 under Man Singh, Mewar treaty 1615, Rajput war 1679-81 with Durgadas Rathore.
14. Succession war order: Dharmat, Samugarh, Khajwa, Deorai. Aurangzeb = Alamgir; jizya back 1679; Bijapur 1686 then Golconda 1687; died 1707, buried at Khuldabad.
15. Decline markers: jagirdari crisis and the paibaqi shortage, Farrukhsiyar's farman 1717, Karnal 1739 and the loss of the Peacock Throne.
16. Shivaji: Pratapgarh 1659, Shaista Khan 1663, Surat 1664 and 1670, Purandar 1665, coronation at Raigad 6 June 1674 by Gaga Bhatt.
17. Ashtapradhan: Peshwa, Amatya, Sachiv, Mantri, Senapati, Sumant, Nyayadhish, Panditrao. Chauth one-fourth, sardeshmukhi one-tenth.
18. Peshwas: Balaji Vishwanath hereditary 1713, Baji Rao I (Palkhed 1728), Balaji Baji Rao at Panipat III, Baji Rao II last.
19. Confederacy: Gaekwad-Baroda, Holkar-Indore, Scindia-Gwalior, Bhonsle-Nagpur, Peshwa-Poona.
20. Anglo-Maratha: the First ends at Salbai 1782, the Second begins from Bassein 1802, the Third ends 1818-19 with the Peshwa pensioned at Bithur.

IH08

Medieval Art, Architecture, Literature, Painting, Music; Bhakti & Sufi Movements

1-2 questions a paper, but the Bhakti-Sufi block is the most repeated medieval theme in the exam. Chishti and Suhrawardi centres came in 2016 and again in 2023; acharya-to-school of Vedanta in 2018 and 2024; the Varkari sampradaya in 2024. Architecture and painting rotate in as chronology or 'NOT correctly matched'.

Everything the medieval centuries made - buildings, pictures, ragas, poems - plus the two great devotional movements. RPSC asks almost all of it as matching: monument to builder, painter to title, saint to school, silsila to dargah. Get the pairs right and the chapter is easy marks.

Medieval Art, Culture, Bhakti and Sufism

Sultanate architecture

- Quwwat-ul-Islam 1192-98, Aibak
- Qutb Minar - Aibak to Iltutmish
- Sultan Ghori 1231 - first mausoleum
- Alai Darwaza 1311 - true arch & dome
- Tughlaqabad - battered walls

Painting

- Mir Sayyid Ali & Abd-us-Samad (Humayun)
- Hamzanama, Daswanth, Basawan (Akbar)
- Ustad Mansur, Abul Hasan (Jahangir)
- Deccani - Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda
- Pahari - Basohli, Guler, Kangra

Bhakti - north, west, east

- Ramananda - first in the vernacular
- Kabir (Bijak), Nanak, Raidas - nirguna
- Surdas, Tulsidas, Mirabai - saguna
- Varkari - Vitthala, Tukaram
- Chaitanya - Gaudiya; Basavanna - Lingayat

Provincial & Deccan

- Adina Masjid, Pandua (Bengal)
- Atala Masjid, Jaunpur (Sharqi)
- Hindola & Jahaz Mahal, Mandu
- Sidi Saiyyed jali, Ahmedabad
- Gol Gumbaz, Bijapur; Char Minar 1591

Music & literature

- Amir Khusrau - qawwali, tarana, sitar
- Man Singh Tomar - dhrupad, Man Kautuhal
- Tansen - Rewa, then Akbar
- Padmavat (Jayasi), Surr-i-Akbar (Dara)
- Akbarnama, Padshahnama, Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh

Sufism

- Chishti - Ajmer, Delhi, Ajodhan, Gulbarga
- Suhrawardi - Multan, state patronage
- Qadiri - Miyan Mir, Lahore
- Naqshbandi - Sirhindi, Wahdat-ul-Shuhud
- khangah, sama, zikr, urs, pir, murid

Mughal architecture

- Humayun's tomb 1565-72 - first charbagh tomb
- Fatehpur Sikri 1571
- Itmad-ud-Daulah 1622-28
- first all-marble, pietra dura
- Taj Mahal 1632-53 - Ustad Ahmad Lahauri
- Red Fort & Jama Masjid, Delhi

Bhakti - south

- Alvars 12 (Vishnu), Nayanars 63 (Shiva)
- Ramana - Vishishtadvaita
- Madhva - Dvaita, Udupi
- Nimbarka - Dvaitadvaita
- Vallabha - Shuddhadvaita, Pushtimarg

How this chapter is asked - read this before the facts

This chapter has no argument in it for RPSC. It has pairs. Monument and builder. Painter and title. Saint and sect. Silsila and dargah. So do not read it as history - build the pairs, and check that you can go both ways: given Ajmer, say Moinuddin Chishti; given Moinuddin Chishti, say Ajmer.

- Four question shapes cover almost everything here: straight one-liner, match-the-following, 'which is NOT correctly matched', and chronological ordering of monuments.
- The ordering question uses a fixed set - Quwwat-ul-Islam 1192-98, Alai Darwaza 1311, Tughlaqabad 1321-25, Gol Gumbaz 1656.
- Bhakti and Sufism together yield more questions than architecture and painting put together.
- Anything with the word 'first' attached is a target - first mosque, first mausoleum, first true arch, first garden tomb, first all-marble building.

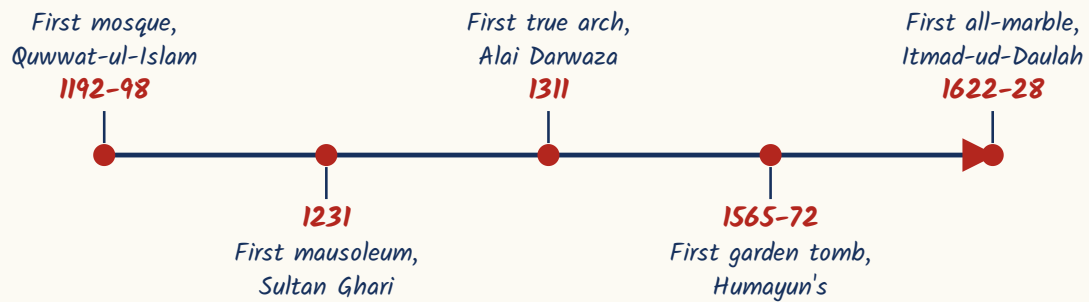
The architectural spine of the medieval period



YAAD RAKHO

Five 'firsts' in one line: first mosque Quwwat-ul-Islam, first mausoleum Sultan Ghari, first true arch and dome Alai Darwaza, first garden tomb Humayun's tomb, first all-marble building Itmad-ud-Daulah.

The five 'firsts', in date order



Sultanate architecture - phase by phase

Indo-Islamic architecture is the name for what follows - Islamic plan and purpose executed by Indian hands. The first Turkish builders had no masons of their own, so they used Indian craftsmen and Indian temple material. That is why the earliest buildings look Islamic in plan and Indian in surface. The technical story of the next century is one thing only - the move from the corbelled arch, which is Indian, to the true arch and dome, which is Islamic.

- *Quwwat-ul-Islam Masjid, Delhi, 1192-98, by Qutbuddin Aibak - the first mosque of the Delhi Sultanate, raised on the plinth of demolished temples.*
- *Qutb Minar - begun by Aibak, completed by Iltutmish; the topmost storey was repaired by Firoz Shah Tughlaq after lightning damage. Dedicated to the Sufi Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki.*
- *Adhai Din ka Jhonpra at Ajmer - Aibak's second great mosque, the Rajasthan link in this list.*
- *Sultan Ghari, 1231 - built by Iltutmish for his son Nasiruddin Mahmud; regarded as the first Islamic mausoleum in India.*
- *Alai Darwaza, 1311, added by Alauddin Khalji to the Qutb complex - the first Indian building to use the true arch and the true dome. He also began the Alai Minar and built Siri, the second city of Delhi, and the Hauz Khas tank.*
- *Tughlaq style: battered (sloping) walls, grey rubble and local stone, arch-and-lintel used together, almost no ornament, a fortress look. Tughlaqabad (Ghiyasuddin), Jahanpanah (Muhammad bin Tughlaq), Firoz Shah Kotla and the Hauz Khas madrasa (Firoz Shah).*
- *Sayyid and Lodi tombs introduce the octagonal tomb with a verandah and the square tomb without one, and the double dome - Lodi Gardens at Delhi is the museum of this phase.*
- *Remember that Tughlaq work is austere. If a statement says Tughlaq buildings are marked by white marble and rich ornament, it is false - that description belongs to Shah Jahan.*

TRAP

The Quwwat-ul-Islam's arches are corbelled - stones stepped out and then dressed to look like an arch. The true arch, with voussoirs and a keystone, arrives only with the Alai Darwaza in 1311. RPSC has asked exactly this.

Provincial and Deccan styles - one monument per region

When Delhi weakened after Timur's raid, the provincial governors turned into sultans and each built in his own way, mixing the local temple tradition with Islamic form. You need one flagship building per region, because that is exactly how the match question is set.

Provincial styles - monument to place

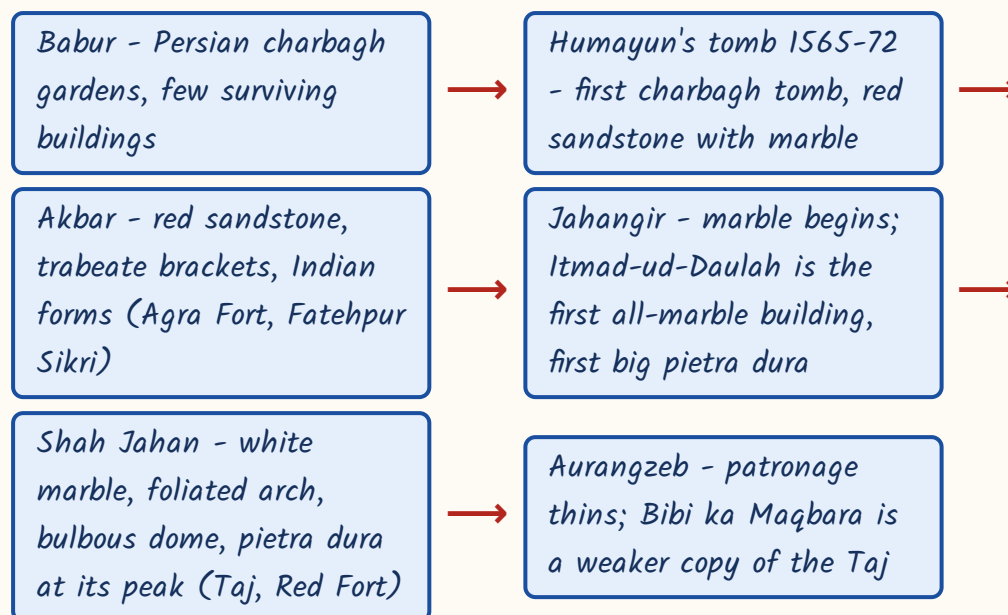
Monument	Place	Style / kingdom
Adina Masjid	Pandua	Bengal - brick and terracotta, curved 'bangla' roof
Atala Masjid	Jaunpur	Sharqi - giant propylon screen, no minarets
Jahaz Mahal and Hindola Mahal	Mandu	Malwa - Hindola's sloping buttressed walls
Sidi Saiyyed Masjid (the jali)	Ahmedabad	Gujarat - finest stone tracery in India
Gol Gumbaz	Bijapur	Adil Shahi Deccan - whispering gallery
Char Minar	Hyderabad	Qutb Shahi Deccan

- Gol Gumbaz is the tomb of Muhammad Adil Shah, completed 1656; one of the largest masonry domes in the world, famous for its whispering gallery.
- Char Minar was built in 1591 by Muhammad Quli Qutb Shah of Golconda, at the centre of the new city of Hyderabad.
- Gujarat also gave the Jama Masjid of Ahmedabad and Rani Sipri's mosque; Bengal gave the Chhota Sona and Bara Sona mosques at Gaur.
- Kashmir's mosques were built in wood - the Jama Masjid of Srinagar and the Shah Hamadan mosque.
- Do not file Gol Gumbaz under Mughal. It is Adil Shahi, at Bijapur, finished in the 1650s - contemporary with the Taj Mahal, but a different kingdom and a different aesthetic.

Mughal architecture - emperor by emperor

The Mughal arc is easy to hold because it moves in one direction - from red sandstone to white marble, from carved ornament to inlaid stone. Akbar is sandstone and bracket, Shah Jahan is marble and pietra dura, and Jahangir's reign is the hinge between them.

Materials and manner - the Mughal direction of travel



Who built what

Ruler	Buildings	Note
Babur	Kabuli Bagh mosque (Panipat), Aram Bagh (Agra)	Introduces the formal Persian garden
Humayun	Din Panah, Delhi	His tomb was built after his death by Bega Begum, designed by Mirak Mirza Ghiyas; UNESCO 1993
Akbar	Agra Fort (from 1565), Jahangiri Mahal, Fatehpur Sikri (1571), Buland Darwaza (1601), Lahore Fort	Fatehpur Sikri holds the Panch Mahal, Diwan-i-Khas, Jama Masjid and Salim Chishti's tomb
Jahangir	Akbar's tomb at Sikandra completed; Shalimar Bagh, Srinagar	Itmad-ud-Daulah's tomb (1622-28) was built by Nur Jahan for her father Mirza Ghiyas Beg
Shah Jahan	Taj Mahal (1632-53), Red Fort and Jama Masjid Delhi, Moti Masjid Agra, Shahjahanabad	Chief architect of the Taj: Ustad Ahmad Lahauri. UNESCO 1983

Ruler	Buildings	Note
Aurangzeb	Badshahi Mosque Lahore, Moti Masjid inside the Red Fort	Bibi ka Maqbara at Aurangabad was raised by his son Azam Shah

- *Salim Chishti's tomb at Fatehpur Sikri is white marble set inside Akbar's red sandstone courtyard - the exception that proves the rule about Akbar's material.*
- *Pietra dura (parchin kari) is semi-precious stone inlaid into marble - it appears first in a big way at Itmad-ud-Daulah and reaches its height at the Taj.*
- *The Taj's plan is a charbagh with the tomb at the end rather than the centre - a deliberate break from Humayun's tomb.*
- *Char-bagh, iwan, pishtaq, bulbous dome, chhatri, jali - the vocabulary the exam uses without defining.*

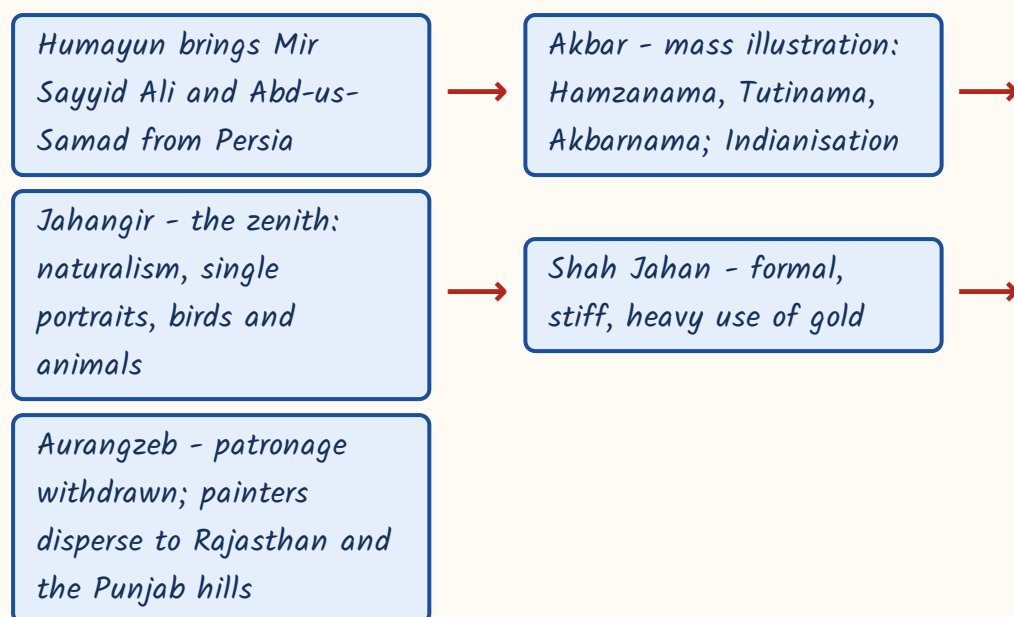
TRAP

The Agra Fort is Akbar's, begun 1565. Shah Jahan only added marble palaces inside it - the Khas Mahal, the Sheesh Mahal and the Moti Masjid. A 'which was NOT built by Shah Jahan' question has used the Agra Fort as the answer. And the Jahangiri Mahal inside it is Akbar's work, not Jahangir's, despite the name.

Painting - the Mughal school and its offshoots

Mughal painting is an imported Persian technique that turned Indian within one generation. Humayun brought the two masters home from Persia; Akbar put them in charge of a workshop of a hundred painters, most of them Indian; and by Jahangir's time the pictures are being made for a connoisseur rather than for a book. Learn the arc reign by reign - that is how the statement questions are built.

Mughal painting, reign by reign



- Akbar's atelier produced the *Hamzanama* (Dastan-i-Amir Hamza) - about 1,400 large paintings on cloth, the largest project of the workshop.
- Akbar's leading painters: Daswanth, Basawan, Kesu Das, Miskin, Lal, Farrukh Beg.
- Jahangir's: Ustad Mansur, given the title *Nadir-ul-Asr* ('wonder of the age') for birds and animals - the Siberian crane, the dodo, the turkey cock; Abul Hasan, titled *Nadir-uz-Zaman*; Bishandas for portraits; Manohar and Govardhan.
- European influence enters under Jahangir - shading, perspective, the halo around the emperor's head.
- Under Aurangzeb the dispersal of artists is what feeds the Rajasthani and Pahari schools - the decline of one school is the birth of the others.
- Say it correctly: Mughal painting peaked under JAHANGIR, not Akbar. Akbar gave it volume and Indian character, Jahangir gave it quality. A statement putting the zenith under Akbar and the decline under Jahangir is false, and it has been set that way.
- Pahari in one sentence - Basohli is the beginning, Kangra is the climax.

The three schools RPSC sets against each other

School	Centres / sub-schools	Marks of style and key names
Mughal	Delhi, Agra, Lahore - the imperial atelier	Realism, portraiture, court and hunt scenes; Mansur, Abul Hasan, Daswanth, Basawan
Deccani	Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda	Older than the Mughal school; rich colour, Persian and Turkish influence; <i>Nujum-al-Ulum</i> from Bijapur
Pahari	Basohli, Guler, Kangra, Chamba, Garhwal, Mandi, Nurpur	Basohli earliest - bold colour, beetle-wing inlay, <i>Rasamanjari</i> for Raja Kripal Pal; Kangra the climax under Raja Sansar Chand - <i>Gita Govinda</i> , <i>Bihari Satsai</i> , <i>Nala-Damayanti</i>
Rajasthani / Rajput	Mewar, Bundi, Kota, Kishangarh, Bikaner, Amber-Jaipur, Marwar	Develops parallel to the Mughal, not out of it - covered in detail in your Rajasthan chapter

TRAP

Two titles, two men, and the exam swaps them. Ustad Mansur = Nadir-ul-Asr, the painter of birds and animals. Abul Hasan = Nadir-uz-Zaman. Both are Jahangir's.

Music and literature - Khusrau, Tansen and the chroniclers

Medieval music questions come from a very small list, and Amir Khusrau is half of it. He was a court poet under several sultans and the devoted disciple of Nizamuddin Auliya - which is why he sits in both the music answer and the Sufi answer.

Amir Khusrau - what tradition credits to him

1253-1325

poet to several sultans

Murid of Nizamuddin

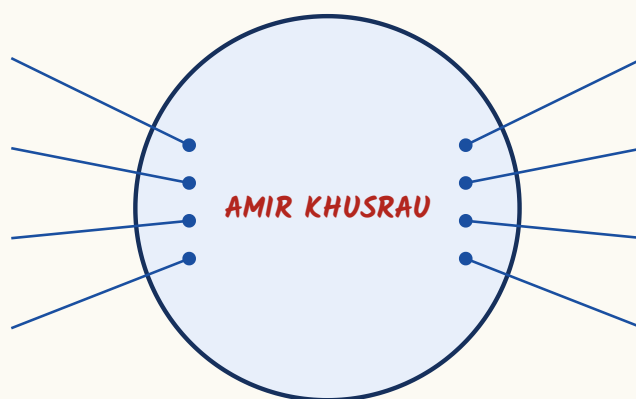
buried at the same dargah

Tarana

a syllabic song form

Sitar

reworked from the veena



Tuti-i-Hind

the parrot of India

Qawwali

out of the Chishti sama

Khayal

the form credited to him

Persian and Hindavi

wrote in both

- Amir Khusrau (1253-1325), called Tuti-i-Hind, the 'parrot of India'; murid of Nizamuddin Auliya, buried beside him at the Nizamuddin dargah, Delhi.
- Tradition credits him with the qawwali, the tarana, the khayal form, and with reworking the veena into the sitar. He wrote in Persian and in Hindavi.
- Raja Man Singh Tomar of Gwalior is the great medieval patron of dhrupad; the treatise Man Kautuhal is associated with his court.
- Tansen, born Ramtanu Pandey, served Raja Ramchandra of Rewa before Akbar summoned him; one of the navaratnas; the ragas Miyan ki Malhar and Miyan ki Todi are his; he is buried at Gwalior.
- Sultan Hussain Shah Sharqi of Jaunpur is associated with the development of khayal; Sharngadeva's Sangita Ratnakara remains the text both Hindustani and Carnatic traditions accept.
- Purandaradasa of Karnataka is called the Pitamaha (grandfather) of Carnatic music.
- Aurangzeb withdrew patronage from music as from painting.

Persian chronicles - work to author

Work	Author	Written under
Tabaqat-i-Nasiri	Minhaj-us-Siraj	Nasiruddin Mahmud
Tarikh-i-Firozshahi	Ziauddin Barani	Firoz Shah Tughlaq
Akbarnama and Ain-i-Akbari	Abul Fazl	Akbar
Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh	Abdul Qadir Badauni	Akbar (written in secret, hostile)
Padshahnama	Abdul Hamid Lahori	Shah Jahan
Muntakhab-ul-Lubab	Khafi Khan	Aurangzeb and after
Humayun-nama	Gulbadan Begum	Akbar's request

Vernacular and devotional literature

Work	Author	Language
Padmavat	Malik Muhammad Jayasi	Awadhi - a Sufi allegory on the siege of Chittor

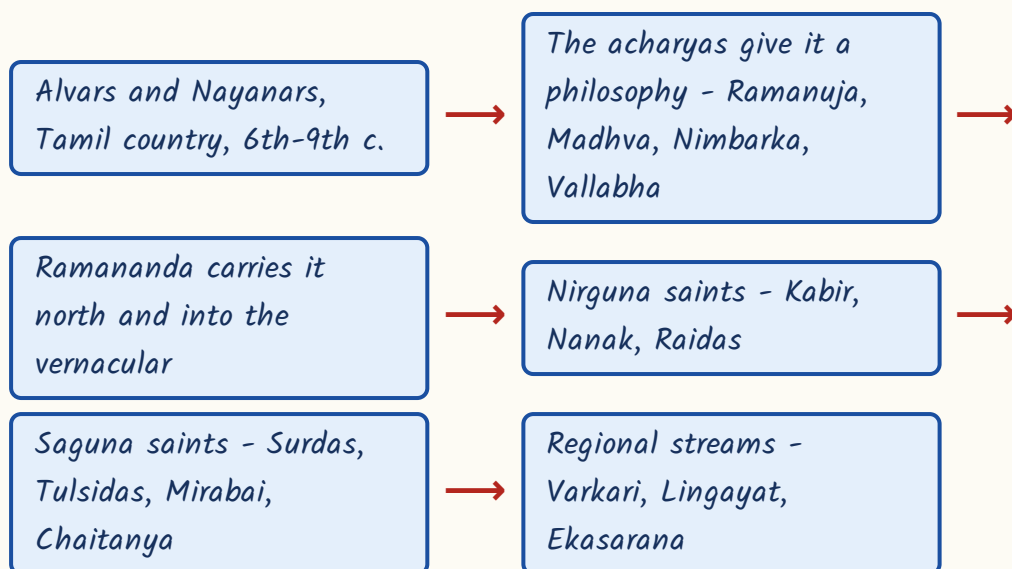
Work	Author	Language
Ramcharitmanas	Tulsidas	Awadhi
Sursagar	Surdas	Brajbhasha
Gita Govinda	Jayadeva	Sanskrit (12th century, the fountainhead of Krishna bhakti verse)
Jnaneshwari	Dnyaneshwar	Marathi - commentary on the Gita
Bijak	Kabir	Sadhukkadi Hindi - Sakhi, Sabad, Ramaini
Vachanas	Basavanna and the Lingayats	Kannada
Padavali	Vidyapati	Maithili

- Dara Shukoh translated fifty Upanishads into Persian as the *Sirr-i-Akbar* ('the Greatest Secret') and wrote the *Majma-ul-Bahrain* ('the Mingling of Two Oceans'), arguing that Vedanta and Sufism say the same thing.
- Abul Fazl's *Ain-i-Akbari* is the third and final volume of the *Akbarnama*.
- Zia Nakhshabi's *Tutinama* and the Persian *Razmnama* belong to the same translation movement at Akbar's court.
- Watch the regions: Vidyapati is a Maithili poet of Mithila in Bihar, not a Punjabi, and Shankaradeva belongs to Assam, where he founded the *Ekasarana dharma* and the *sattr*. The saint-to-region NOT-matched question is built from exactly these two.

The Bhakti movement - the idea, then the list

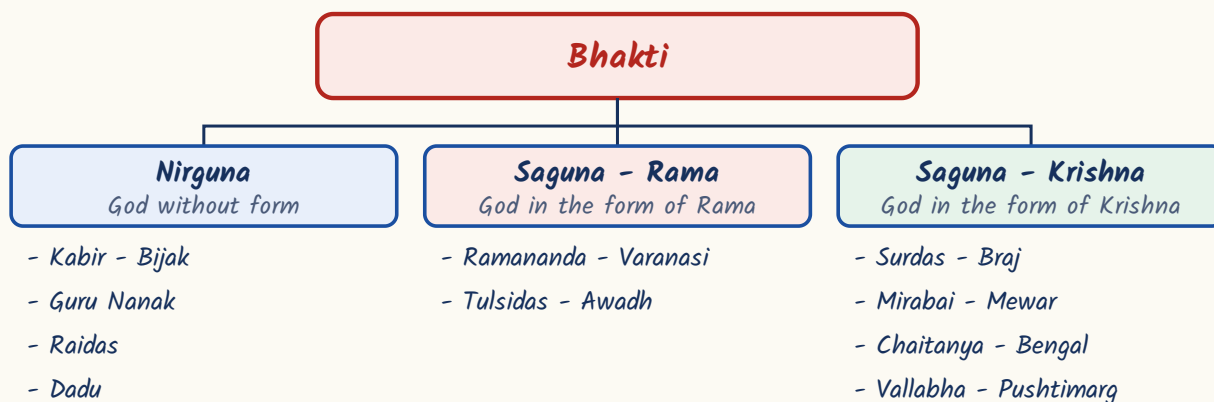
Bhakti means loving devotion to a personal God, offered directly, without a priest in between. That single idea is what makes it socially explosive - if God can be reached by love alone, then caste, ritual, Sanskrit and the temple establishment are all optional. It begins in the Tamil country between the sixth and ninth centuries and travels north over the next six hundred years.

How Bhakti travelled



- Alvars - twelve, devotees of Vishnu; their hymns form the Nalayira Divya Prabandham; Andal is the only woman among them.
- Nayanars - sixty-three, devotees of Shiva; their hymns form the Tevaram. Appar, Sambandar and Sundarar are the best known.
- Nirguna bhakti worships God without form or attribute - Kabir, Nanak, Raidas, Dadu.
- Saguna bhakti worships God in a form, usually Rama or Krishna - Tulsidas, Surdas, Mirabai, Chaitanya.
- The saints wrote in the people's languages, and that is the movement's lasting effect - Marathi abhanga, Hindi doha, Kannada vachana, Bengali padavali all come out of it.

Nirguna and Saguna - sort every saint into one of three



The acharyas - founder, philosophy, sampradaya

Acharya	School of Vedanta	Sampradaya / centre
Ramanuja	Vishishtadvaita - qualified non-dualism	Sri sampradaya; Srirangam
Madhvacharya (Ananda Tirtha)	Dvaita / Tattvavada - dualism	Brahma sampradaya; Udupi, the Ashta Mathas
Nimbarka	Dvaitadvaita - dualistic non-dualism	Sanaka sampradaya; Radha-Krishna worship
Vallabhacharya	Shuddhadvaita - pure non-dualism	Rudra sampradaya, Pushtimarg; Nathdwara in Rajasthan

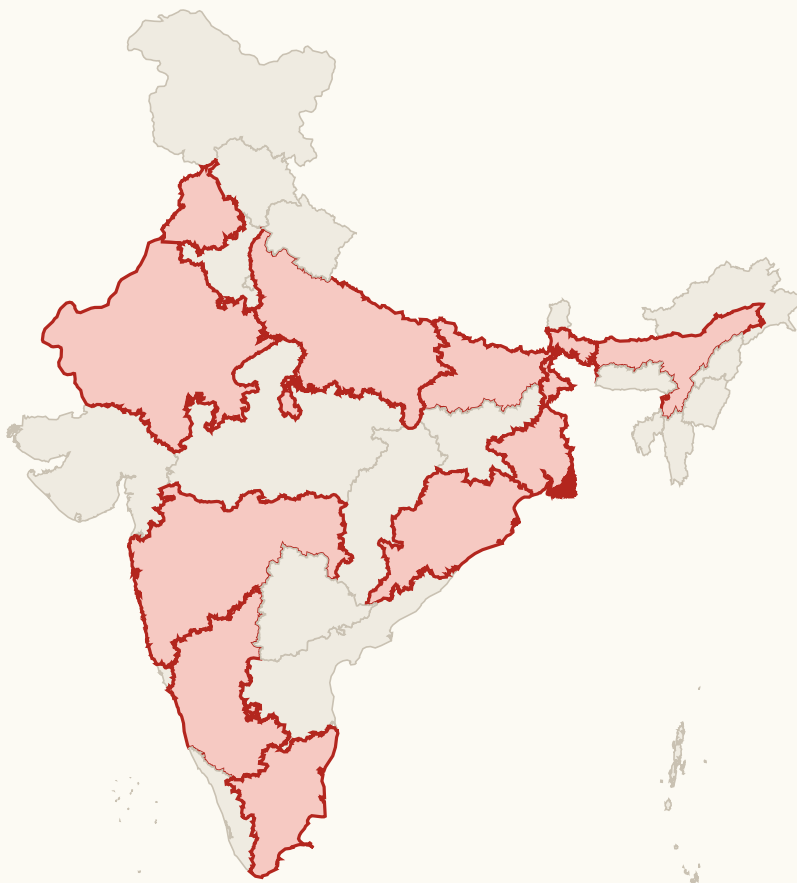
Saint to sect to region - the north, west and east

Saint	Sect / stream	Region
Ramananda	Ramanandi; first to preach bhakti in the vernacular in the north	Varanasi
Kabir	Nirguna; Kabirpanth; verses in the Bijak	Varanasi, died at Maghar
Guru Nanak (b. 1469, Talwandi)	Sikh panth; Adi Granth compiled by Guru Arjan Dev, 1604	Punjab
Raidas (Ravidas)	Nirguna; disciple of Ramananda	Varanasi
Surdas	Pushtimarg; one of the Ashtachhap	Braj
Tulsidas	Rama bhakti; Ramcharitmanas	Awadh

Saint	Sect / stream	Region
Mirabai	Krishna bhakti	Mewar, Rajasthan
Namdev, Dnyaneshwar, Chokhamela, Eknath, Tukaram	Varkari sampradaya - Vitthala of Pandharpur	Maharashtra
Chaitanya Mahaprabhu (b. 1486, Nabadwip)	Gaudiya Vaishnavism; Achintya Bhedabheda; sankirtan	Bengal and Odisha
Basavanna	Lingayat / Virashaiva; Anubhava Mantapa; vachanas	Karnataka
Shankaradeva	Ekasarana dharma; the sattra institution	Assam
Vidyapati	Maithili Vaishnava padavali	Mithila, Bihar

- Ramananda's disciples are asked as a list: Kabir, Raidas, Dhanna, Pipa and Sena - and Dhanna and Pipa are Rajasthan's own, which is why RPSC likes this line.
- The Ashtachhap - eight poets of the Pushtimarg, including Surdas - was constituted not by Vallabhacharya himself but by his son Vitthalnath.
- The Varkari wari, the annual pilgrimage on foot to Pandharpur, culminates on Ashadhi Ekadashi; Chokhamela, a Mahar saint, shows how far the movement cut across caste.
- Basavanna was a minister of the Kalachuri king Bijjala; the Lingayats rejected caste, ritual and image worship.
- Mnemonic for the acharyas - R-M-N-V in that order gives Vishishtadvaita, Dvaita, Dvaitadvaita, Shuddhadvaita: Ramanuja qualified, Madhva pure dualism, Nimbarka both, Vallabha pure.

Where the Bhakti saints worked



From the Tamil Alvars and Nayanars to Mirabai in Mewar and Shankaradeva in Assam

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2018 and again in 2024 - the acharya-to-school match. Ramanuja / Vishishtadvaita, Madhvacharya / Dvaita or Tattvavada, Nimbarka / Dvaitadvaita, Vallabhacharya / Shuddhadvaita. Learn it as a block of four; it is the most reliably repeated item in this chapter.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 as a statement question on the Varkari sampradaya - the devotees worship Vitthala of Pandharpur, the saints include Dnyaneshwar, Namdev and Tukaram, and the wari falls on Ashadhi Ekadashi. All three statements were correct.

Sufism – silsilas, dargahs and the vocabulary

Sufism is Islam's mystical strand. Its goal is fana – the annihilation of the self in God – reached through love, discipline and the guidance of a master. The master is the pir or shaikh, the disciple is the murid, and the chain of masters running back through the generations is the silsila. That word is your whole exam answer: four silsilas, four founders in India, four centres.

Silsila to founder in India to centre

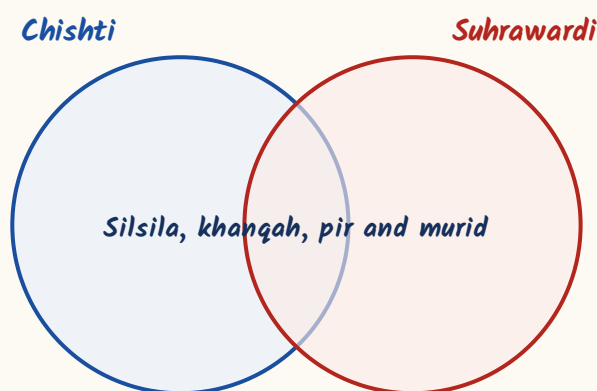
Silsila	Founder / chief figure in India	Centre
Chishti	Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti (Gharib Nawaz)	Ajmer, Rajasthan
Suhrawardi	Shaikh Bahauddin Zakariya	Multan
Qadiri	Miyan Mir (spiritual guide of Dara Shukoh)	Lahore
Naqshbandi	Brought by Khwaja Baqi Billah; its great figure Shaikh Ahmad Sirhindi	Delhi, then Sirhind
Firdausi	Shaikh Sharfuddin Yahya Maneri	Bihar

The Chishti chain – saint to dargah

Saint	Seat / dargah
Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti	Ajmer
Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki	Mehrauli, Delhi
Baba Fariduddin Ganj-i-Shakar	Ajodhan (modern Pakpattan)
Nizamuddin Auliya	Delhi
Nasiruddin Chiragh-i-Dehlavi	Delhi
Gesu Daraz (Bandanawaz)	Gulbarga, Deccan
Shaikh Salim Chishti	Fatehpur Sikri

- Chishtis refused state office, land grants and wealth, lived among the poor, and accepted *futuh* - unasked-for offerings. That is why the order spread widest.
- Suhrawardis did the opposite - they accepted state patronage, offices and property, and stayed close to the sultans.
- *Wahdat-ul-Wujud*, 'unity of being', is Ibn Arabi's doctrine, widely followed in India. Shaikh Ahmad Sirhindi opposed it with *Wahdat-ul-Shuhud*, 'apparentism', and was titled *Mujaddid-i-Alf-i-Sani*, the reviver of the second millennium.
- Vocabulary that appears in options: *khanqah* (hospice), *dargah* (tomb-shrine), *sama* (devotional music assembly), *zikr* (remembrance of God's name), *urs* (death anniversary, celebrated as a union with God), *pir* and *murid*, *futuh*, *wilayat* (spiritual jurisdiction).
- The Chishtis permitted *sama*; the Suhrawardis and the orthodox ulema objected to it - *qawwali* grew out of the Chishti *sama*.
- Amir Khusrau at the Nizamuddin *khanqah* is the bridge between Sufism and Indian music.
- Mnemonic - four *silsilas*, four places, in order C-S-Q-N: Chishti-Ajmer, Suhrawardi-Multan, Qadiri-Lahore, Naqshbandi-Sirhind. A-M-L-S.

Chishti against Suhrawardi



Chishti - no state office, *futuh*, *sama*; Ajmer. Suhrawardi - office and wealth; Multan.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2016 and again in 2023 - Moinuddin Chishti's dargah is at Ajmer, and Bahauddin Zakariya's Suhrawardi centre was at Multan. Both came back verbatim. Being a Rajasthan exam, expect Ajmer to appear from either this chapter or the fairs-and-festivals chapter.

ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2023 set the Chishti saint-to-dargah match - Moinuddin at Ajmer, Baba Farid at Ajodhan, Nizamuddin at Delhi, Gesu Daraz at Gulbarga. And the 'which pair is NOT correctly matched' version has used Miyan Mir, who was Qadiri, labelled as a Chishti.

CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of September 2026): the 814th annual Urs of Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti was observed at the Ajmer dargah in the month of Rajab, over the turn of 2025-26, drawing pilgrims from India and abroad, and a chadar was offered at the shrine on behalf of the Prime Minister. Ajmer is the Chishti centre named in the syllabus, so the Urs is the likeliest current-affairs door into this chapter - and the answer behind it is always Gharib Nawaz, Ajmer, Chishti silsila.

Bhakti against Sufi - the comparison RPSC keeps returning to

The examiner likes this pair because the two movements look alike from a distance and differ in every detail up close. Both are devotional, both attack ritual and orthodoxy, both use music and the vernacular, and both are led by a teacher who gathers disciples. Then everything else diverges. Fix the differences in a table and you will never mix a term from one into the other.

Bhakti vs Sufism

Bhakti	Sufism
Grew inside Hinduism; roots in the Tamil Alvar and Nayanar hymns of the 6th-9th century.	Grew inside Islam; entered India with the Turks from the late 12th century.
Goal: union with a personal God through prem and bhakti.	Goal: fana, the annihilation of the self in God.
Teacher is the guru; the community is the sampradaya or panth.	Teacher is the pir or shaikh; the chain is the silsila; the disciple is the murid.
Institution: the temple, the math, the satsang.	Institution: the khangah in life, the dargah after death.
Music: kirtan, bhajan, abhanga, sankirtan.	Music: sama, and the qawwali of the Chishtis.
Split within: nirguna (formless) vs saguna (with form).	Split within: Wahdat-ul-Wujud (Ibn Arabi) vs Wahdat-ul-Shuhud (Sirhindi).
Target of criticism: caste, ritual and the priestly monopoly.	Target of criticism: the legalism of the ulema and the pull of the court.
Language: Tamil, Marathi, Hindi, Braj, Awadhi, Kannada, Bengali.	Language: Persian for theology; Hindavi and local speech for verse and song.

- Where they meet: Kabir drew on both, and both traditions claim him - Hindus and Muslims are said to have disputed his body at Maghar.
- Both made the vernacular respectable and both drew followers across caste and community lines.
- Both worried the establishment - the ulema attacked the Chishtis for sama, the Brahmanical order attacked Kabir and Ramananda for admitting all castes.
- Dara Shukoh's Majma-ul-Bahrain is the formal literary attempt to fuse the two streams.

TRAP

Terms belong to one side or the other, and the exam tests exactly this. Khanqah, sama, futuh, urs, murid = Sufi. Ashtachhap, sampradaya, abhangas, sankirtan, math = Bhakti. A 2024-style 'which term is NOT associated with Sufism' question had Ashtachhap as its answer - those are the eight Pushtimarg poets.

CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of September 2026): India's medieval heritage keeps entering the UNESCO list. The Moidams of Charaideo - the mound-burial system of the Ahom dynasty of Assam, in use from the 13th to the 19th century - were inscribed in July 2024 at the 46th session of the World Heritage Committee, which India hosted at New Delhi. It was India's 43rd World Heritage Site and the first cultural site from the Northeast. The 47th session in July 2025 added the Maratha Military Landscapes, taking the tally to 44.

REVISION RECAP

1. Quwwat-ul-Islam 1192-98 (Aibak) first mosque; Qutb Minar begun Aibak, completed Iltutmish; Sultan Ghori 1231 first Islamic mausoleum.
2. Alai Darwaza 1311 (Alauddin Khalji) - first true arch and true dome in India. Corbelled arches before it.
3. Tughlaq style = battered walls, grey rubble, austerity: Tughlaqabad, Jahanpanah, Firoz Shah Kotla.
4. Provincial flagships: Adina-Pandua (Bengal), Atala-Jaunpur (Sharqi), Hindola & Jahaz Mahal-Mandu (Malwa), Sidi Saiyyed jali-Ahmedabad (Gujarat).
5. Deccan: Gol Gumbaz (Muhammad Adil Shah, Bijapur, 1656, whispering gallery); Char Minar (Muhammad Quli Qutb Shah, Hyderabad, 1591).
6. Humayun's tomb 1565-72 - first charbagh tomb, commissioned by Bega Begum, architect Mirak Mirza Ghiyas, UNESCO 1993.
7. Itmad-ud-Daulah 1622-28, built by Nur Jahan for her father - first all-marble Mughal building, first large pietra dura.

8. Taj Mahal 1632-53, Ustad Ahmad Lahauri, UNESCO 1983. Agra Fort is Akbar's, not Shah Jahan's.
9. Mughal painting: Humayun brings Mir Sayyid Ali and Abd-us-Samad; Hamzanama under Akbar (about 1,400 cloth paintings); zenith under Jahangir; decline under Aurangzeb.
10. Ustad Mansur = Nadir-ul-Asr (birds and animals); Abul Hasan = Nadir-uz-Zaman. Both Jahangir's.
11. Pahari: Basohli earliest (Kripal Pal, Rasamanjari); Kangra at its height under Sansar Chand (Gita Govinda). Deccani = Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda.
12. Amir Khusrau - Tuti-i-Hind, murid of Nizamuddin Auliya, qawwali and tarana and the sitar. Man Singh Tomar of Gwalior - dhrupad, Man Kautuhal. Tansen came from Rewa.
13. Padmavat by Jayasi in Awadhi; Sirr-i-Akbar and Majma-ul-Bahrain by Dara Shukoh; Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh by Badauni; Padshahnama by Abdul Hamid Lahori; Tabaqat-i-Nasiri by Minhaj-us-Siraj; Tarikh-i-Firozshahi by Barani.
14. Alvars 12 (Vishnu, Nalayira Divya Prabandham, Andal the only woman); Nayanars 63 (Shiva, Tevaram).
15. Ramanuja-Vishishtadvaita, Madhva-Dvaita/Tattvavada (Udupi), Nimbarka-Dvaitadvaita, Vallabha-Shuddhadvaita (Pushtimarg, Nathdwara).
16. Ramananda first preached bhakti in the vernacular in the north; disciples Kabir, Raidas, Dhanna, Pipa, Sena.
17. Kabir's Bijak = Sakhi, Sabad, Ramaini; died at Maghar. Nanak born 1469 at Talwandi; Adi Granth compiled by Guru Arjan Dev in 1604.
18. Varkari = Vitthala of Pandharpur, saints Dnyaneshwar, Namdev, Chokhamela, Eknath, Tukaram; Chaitanya = Gaudiya, Achintya Bhedabheda; Basavanna = Lingayat, Anubhava Mantapa.
19. Silsilas: Chishti-Ajmer, Suhrawardi-Multan, Qadiri-Lahore (Miyan Mir), Naqshbandi-Sirhind (Sirhindi, Mujaddid-i-Alf-i-Sani).
20. Chishtis refused state office and permitted sama; Suhrawardis took state patronage. Wahdat-ul-Wujud (Ibn Arabi) vs Wahdat-ul-Shuhud (Sirhindi). Vocabulary: khanqah, dargah, sama, zikr, urs, pir, murid, futuh - and Ashtachhap is Bhakti, not Sufi.

IH09

British Expansion, Policies, 1857 and Socio-Religious

Reform

Indian History gives about 11 questions a paper on average; modern India usually takes 3-5 of them. Inside this chapter the safest bets are reform-institution-to-founder matching (asked in 2013, 2018 and 2023), the three land revenue systems, and the 1857 centre-to-leader pairs.

This is the chapter where a trading company turns into a government, and where Indian society begins to argue with itself about sati, widows, caste and the Vedas. RPSC does not ask you to interpret any of it. It asks who did what, in which year, and in which province - so the whole chapter reduces to a set of clean tables.

British India, 1757-1900

Conquest

- Plassey 1757 - Clive vs Siraj-ud-Daulah
- Wandiwash 1760
- Buxar 1764 - Hector Munro
- Diwani 1765 - Treaty of Allahabad

Instruments of expansion

- Subsidiary Alliance - Wellesley
- Doctrine of Lapse - Dalhousie
- Awadh 1856 - misgovernance
- Wars: Mysore, Maratha, Sikh, Burmese

Land revenue

- Permanent Settlement 1793
- Cornwallis
- Ryotwari - Munro, Read
- Mahalwari 1822 - Holt Mackenzie
- Drain of wealth - Naoroji

Constitutional ladder

- Regulating Act 1773
- Pitt's India Act 1784
- Charter Acts 1813, 1833, 1853
- GOI Act 1858 - Crown takes over

Education

- Macaulay's Minute 1835
- Wood's Despatch 1854
- Universities 1857
- Hunter Commission 1882

1857

- Barrackpore 29 Mar, Meerut 10 May
- Delhi - Bahadur Shah II, Bakht Khan
- Kanpur, Lucknow, Jhansi, Jagdishpur
- Suppressed 8 July 1858

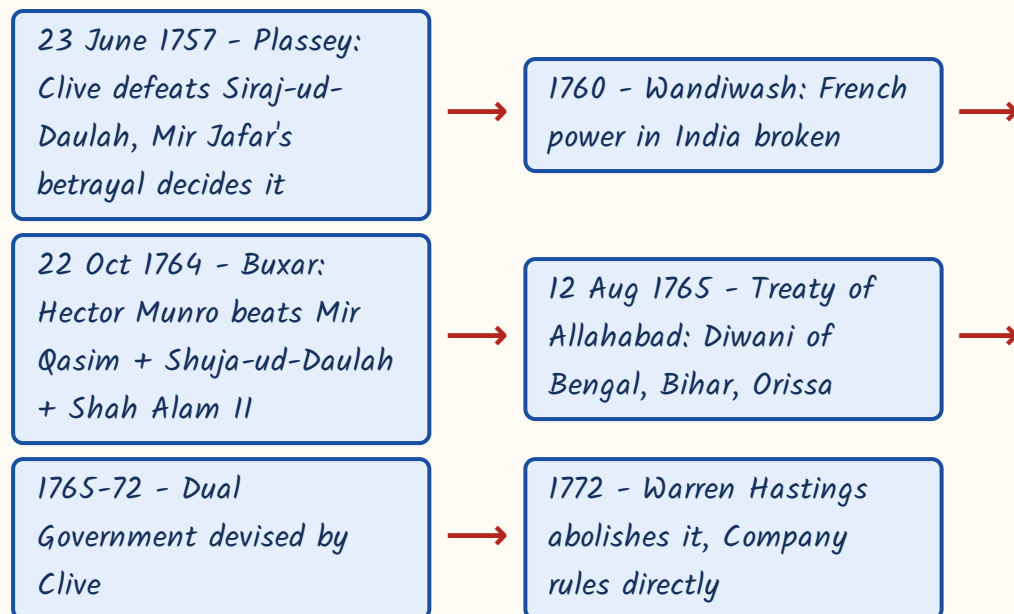
Socio-religious reform

- Brahmo Samaj 1828
- Prarthana 1867, Satyashodhak 1873
- Arya Samaj 1875, Theosophical 1875
- Ramakrishna Mission 1897

From trader to ruler - Plassey, Buxar and the Diwani

Start with one idea. The Company did not conquer Bengal in one battle; it took three steps. Plassey gave it a puppet Nawab. Buxar gave it military supremacy over three powers at once. The Diwani gave it the money. Once you have money and an army, you are the government. That is the whole story of 1757-1765, and RPSC asks it as dates and names.

The eight years that made the Company a state



- Plassey, 23 June 1757 - Clive against Nawab Siraj-ud-Daulah; Mir Jafar was rewarded with the throne of Bengal.
- Buxar, 22 October 1764 - the English commander was Hector Munro; this is the battle that settled British political supremacy in the east.
- Treaty of Allahabad, 1765 - Shah Alam II gave the Diwani against an annual pension of Rs 26 lakh.
- Dual Government - Company held the Diwani (revenue), the Nawab kept the Nizamat (law and order); power without responsibility.
- Warren Hastings ended the dual system in 1772 and became the first Governor-General of Bengal in 1773.

- Sequence to memorise: Plassey 1757, Wandiwash 1760, Buxar 1764, Salbai 1782 - this exact ordering has been asked.
- Mir Jafar is the Plassey man; Mir Qasim is the Buxar man. They are different Nawabs.
- Diwani = right to collect revenue. Nizamat = police, justice, army. Learn the two words.

Two instruments of expansion - Subsidiary Alliance and Doctrine of Lapse

After 1765 the British stopped fighting for every inch. They designed two legal devices instead. Wellesley's Subsidiary Alliance swallowed a state while leaving its ruler on the throne. Dalhousie's Doctrine of Lapse swallowed it when the ruler died without a natural heir. Learn who invented which, and the first case of each - that pair is the standard question.

Subsidiary Alliance vs Doctrine of Lapse

Subsidiary Alliance	Doctrine of Lapse
Lord Wellesley (Governor-General 1798-1805)	Lord Dalhousie (1848-56)
Ruler keeps his throne, loses his foreign policy and army	State is annexed outright and ends
State pays for British troops stationed in it; a British Resident sits at court	Applied when a ruler died without a natural heir; adopted sons not recognised for succession to the state
First accepted by the Nizam of Hyderabad, 1798	First applied to Satara, 1848
Awadh 1801; the Peshwa by the Treaty of Bassein, 1802	Jaitpur and Sambalpur 1849, Udaipur 1852, Jhansi 1853, Nagpur 1854

Annexations under Dalhousie

State	Year	Ground
Satara	1848	Lapse - the first case
Jaitpur and Sambalpur	1849	Lapse
Udaipur	1852	Lapse
Jhansi	1853	Lapse - refusal to recognise Damodar Rao
Nagpur	1854	Lapse
Awadh	1856	Alleged misgovernance - NOT lapse
Punjab	1849	Conquest, after the Second Anglo-Sikh War

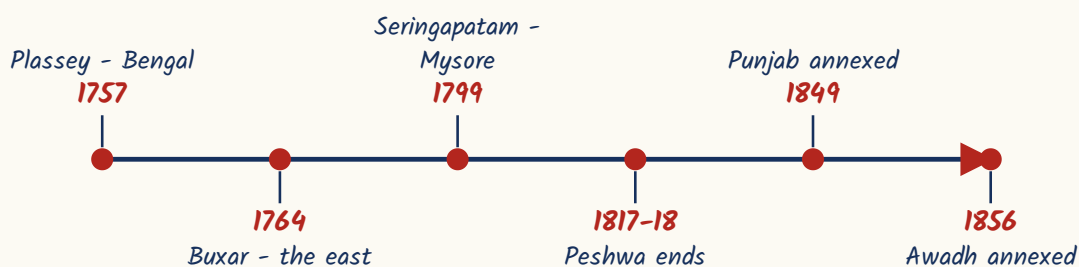
TRAP

Awadh is the standard trick. It was annexed by Dalhousie in 1856, but on the plea of misgovernance, not under the Doctrine of Lapse. Any question asking which state was NOT annexed under Lapse is pointing at Awadh.

The wars - four fronts, and the treaty that closed each

Four sets of wars, fought against four powers, over roughly sixty years. You are almost never asked about the fighting. You are asked which treaty ended which war, and who was ruling when the annexation happened. So read this table as a matching exercise, not as military history.

British expansion - Bengal to Awadh, 1757 to 1856



War to treaty to outcome

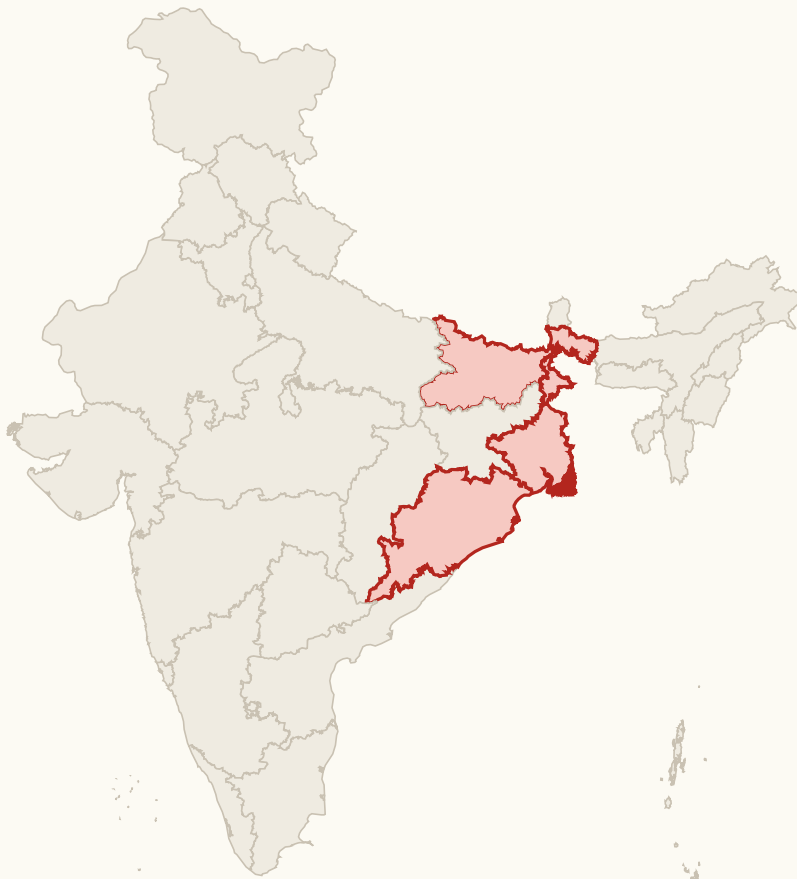
War	Years	Treaty / outcome
First Anglo-Mysore	1767-69	Treaty of Madras
Second Anglo-Mysore	1780-84	Treaty of Mangalore
Third Anglo-Mysore	1790-92	Treaty of Seringapatam
Fourth Anglo-Mysore	1799	Tipu Sultan killed at Seringapatam, 4 May 1799
First Anglo-Maratha	1775-82	Treaty of Salbai
Second Anglo-Maratha	1803-05	Followed the Treaty of Bassein, 1802
Third Anglo-Maratha	1817-18	Peshwaship abolished
First Anglo-Sikh	1845-46	Treaty of Lahore
Second Anglo-Sikh	1848-49	Punjab annexed by Dalhousie, 1849
First Anglo-Burmese	1824-26	Treaty of Yandabo
Third Anglo-Burmese	1885	Burma annexed

- Tipu Sultan died defending his capital Seringapatam on 4 May 1799; Mysore then went back to the Wodeyars under a subsidiary alliance.
- Punjab, 1849 - the boy Maharaja Dalip Singh was pensioned off and the Koh-i-Noor surrendered to the Crown.
- Bassein 1802 is a hinge: it is a subsidiary treaty with the Peshwa, and it triggered the Second Anglo-Maratha War.
- Do not mix Mangalore (Second Mysore) with Seringapatam (Third Mysore). Both are Mysore treaties.

The three land revenue systems - RPSC asks this one directly

This is the highest-value table in the chapter. Three systems, three areas, three officials. The question is almost always a match: system to person, or system to region. The underlying difference is simple - who does the government treat as the owner and who does it collect from. Permanent Settlement picks the zamindar, Ryotwari picks the cultivator, Mahalwari picks the village.

Where the Permanent Settlement applied



Bengal, Bihar and Orissa - Cornwallis, 1793; about 19% of British India

The three settlements - area, official, features

System	Where it applied	Official / year	Key features
Permanent Settlement	Bengal, Bihar, Orissa	Lord Cornwallis with John Shore, 1793	Zamindar recognised as owner; revenue fixed for ever; zamindar kept 1/11th and paid 10/11th; 'Sunset Law' auctioned estates of defaulters

System	Where it applied	Official / year	Key features
Ryotwari	Madras (1820) and Bombay	Thomas Munro and Captain Alexander Read	Settlement made directly with the ryot (cultivator); no intermediary; revenue revised periodically
Mahalwari	North-Western Provinces, Punjab, Central India	Holt Mackenzie, Regulation VII of 1822; revised 1833 under Bentinck by R.M. Bird	Village or mahal is the unit; joint responsibility of the village body; revenue periodically revised

Permanent Settlement vs Ryotwari – the core contrast

Permanent Settlement, 1793	Ryotwari
Revenue payer is the zamindar	Revenue payer is the cultivator himself
Amount fixed permanently – the state gained nothing from later growth	Amount revised at each settlement
Created a landlord class loyal to the British	Left the peasant directly exposed to the collector
Bengal, Bihar, Orissa – about 19 per cent of British India	Madras and Bombay presidencies

- The Permanent Settlement covered roughly 19 per cent of British India – it was never the all-India system.
- Sunset Law: if the fixed revenue was not paid by sunset on the due date, the estate was auctioned.
- Ryotwari is associated with Munro in Madras; Read was his senior in the earliest experiments in the Baramahal.
- Mahalwari has two names attached – Mackenzie for 1822, R.M. Bird for the 1833 revision under Bentinck.

The economic critique came from the early nationalists, and it is a small but repeated block. Dadabhai Naoroji argued that a part of India's wealth was being transported to Britain with no equivalent return - the 'drain of wealth'. He first put it in *England's Debt to India* (1867) and developed it in *Poverty and Un-British Rule in India* (1901). R.C. Dutt wrote the *Economic History of India*; M.G. Ranade wrote on Indian industry. Alongside the drain ran deindustrialisation - Indian handicrafts collapsed under machine-made British imports while tariff policy protected Britain.

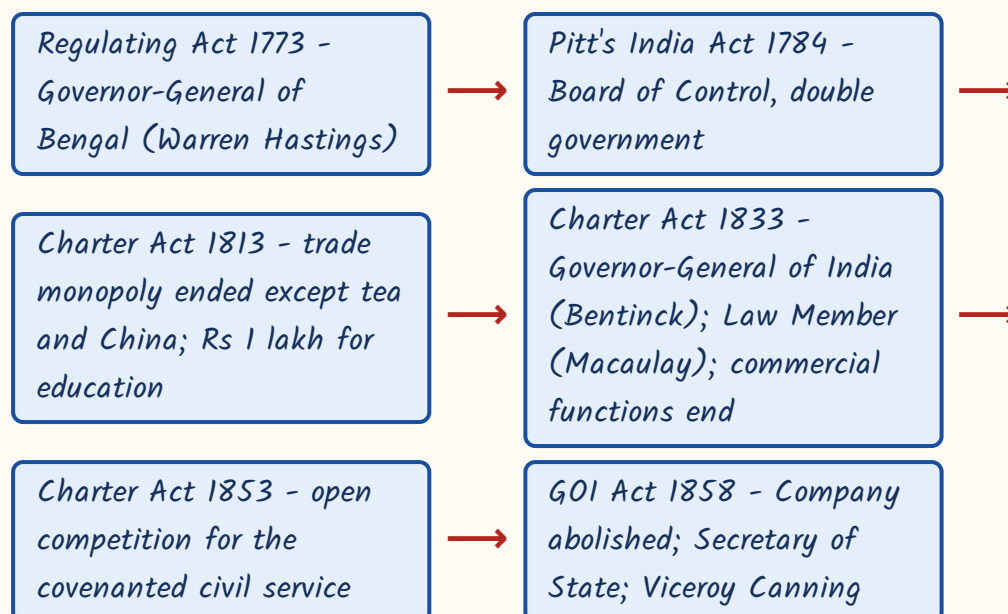
YAAD RAKHO

Trick for the settlements: C-M-M. Cornwallis - Permanent, Munro - Ryotwari, Mackenzie - Mahalwari. Alphabetically C comes first and 1793 comes first too.

Charter Acts and the ladder to Crown rule

Six Acts, each adding one brick. Read them as a ladder: Parliament first supervises the Company (1773), then controls it (1784), then strips its trade (1813, 1833), then opens its services (1853), then abolishes it (1858). If you remember the one distinctive thing each Act did, every question here is answerable.

The constitutional ladder, 1773 to 1858



What each Act is remembered for

Act	Year	Distinctive provision
Regulating Act	1773	Governor of Bengal became Governor-General of Bengal; Supreme Court at Calcutta in 1774
Pitt's India Act	1784	Board of Control created; civil, military and revenue affairs under Crown supervision
Charter Act	1813	Company's trade monopoly ended except tea and the China trade; Rs 1 lakh a year for education
Charter Act	1833	Governor-General of India; Law Member added; Company's commercial functions ended
Charter Act	1853	Open competition for the covenanted civil service; separate legislative machinery
GOI Act	1858	Company abolished; Secretary of State for India with a 15-member Council; Governor-General became Viceroy

TRAP

Two classic wrong pairs. First - the Company's commercial functions ended in 1833, not 1793; 1813 only ended the monopoly (tea and China excepted). Second - dyarchy in the provinces has nothing to do with 1858; it came with the Government of India Act, 1919.

Education policy - Macaulay to Hunter

British education policy in India was settled by an argument: should the state teach in Sanskrit and Persian, or in English? Macaulay closed that argument in 1835 in favour of English, on the theory that a small educated class would pass knowledge downwards - the downward filtration theory. Wood's Despatch of 1854 then built the actual system, from village schools up to universities.

Education landmarks under the British

Landmark	Year	What it did
Macaulay's Minute	2 February 1835	English as the medium of higher education; downward filtration theory
Wood's Despatch	1854	Magna Carta of English education in India; graded system from vernacular schools to universities
First universities	1857	Calcutta, Bombay and Madras
Hunter Commission	1882	W.W. Hunter, under Viceroy Ripon; stressed primary and secondary education, transfer of primary schools to local bodies
Raleigh Commission	1902	Led to the Indian Universities Act, 1904
Sadler Commission	1917-19	Calcutta University Commission
Hartog Committee	1929	Quality rather than expansion of education

- Rammohan Roy was on the English side of this argument - his 1823 letter to Lord Amherst opposed the proposed Sanskrit College.
- Hunter 1882 is a British-era commission. Radhakrishnan 1948, Mudaliar 1952 and Kothari 1964 are post-independence - they belong to IH10.
- Wood's Despatch, not Macaulay's Minute, is the 'Magna Carta'. Both years get swapped in options.

1857 - causes, course, centres, consequences

Treat 1857 in four parts and you will not lose a mark. Causes - political annexations, economic ruin, army grievances, social-religious fear, and the greased cartridge as the spark. Course - a chronology from Barrackpore to Delhi. Centres - a pure matching table of place and leader. Consequences - the end of the Company and the birth of Crown rule. RPSC almost always picks the third and fourth.

- Political - annexations under Lapse, and the annexation of Awadh in 1856, which hit the sepoys' home province.
- Economic - heavy land revenue, ruin of artisans, the drain of wealth.
- Military - poor pay and promotion for Indian sepoys, service overseas, the General Service Enlistment Act.
- Social-religious - fear that reform legislation and missionary activity were aimed at religion.
- Immediate spark - the greased cartridges of the new Enfield rifle, believed to be smeared with cow and pig fat.

Why 1857 happened

Political

Annexations; Awadh taken 1856

Military

Low pay; service overseas

The spark

Greased Enfield cartridges

Economic

Heavy revenue; artisans ruined

Social-religious

Fear for religion and custom

REVOLT OF 1857

The chronology - learn these six dates

29 March 1857 -

Barrackpore, Mangal Pandey

10 May 1857 - Meerut
sepoys revolt

11 May 1857 - Delhi
seized; Bahadur Shah II
proclaimed, Bakht Khan
the commander

June-Sept 1857 - Kanpur,
Lucknow, Jhansi, Bareilly,
Jagdishpur

8 July 1858 - Canning
declares the revolt
suppressed

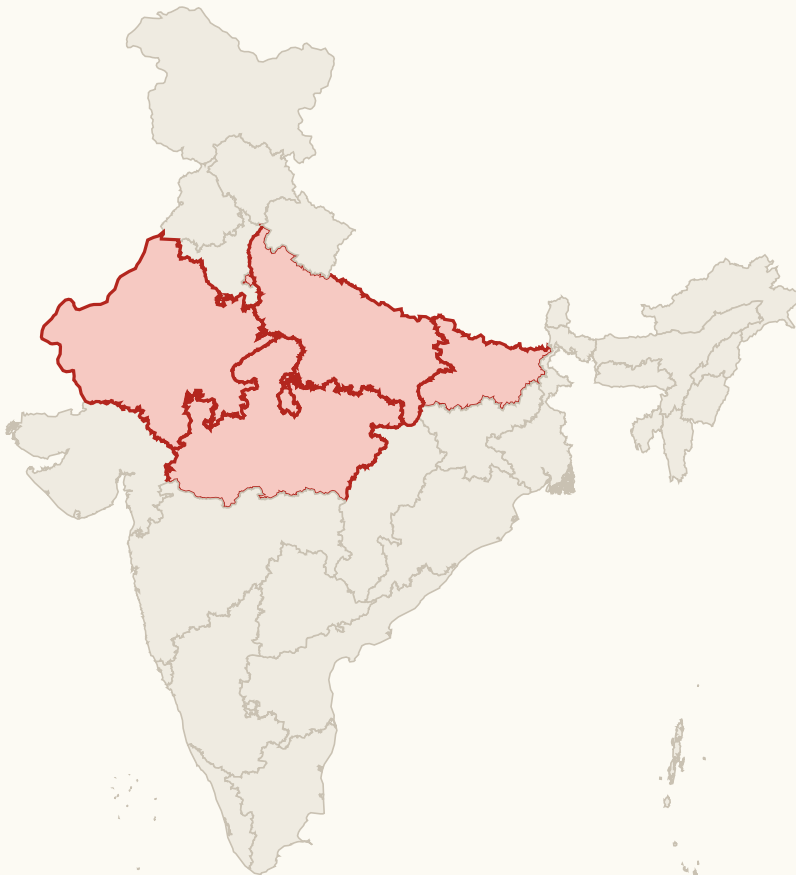
1 November 1858 - Queen
Victoria's Proclamation
read at Allahabad

Centre to leader - the matching question

Centre	Leader
Delhi	Bahadur Shah II, with General Bakht Khan as commander
Kanpur	Nana Saheb, assisted by Tatya Tope
Lucknow	Begum Hazrat Mahal
Jhansi	Rani Lakshmibai
Bareilly	Khan Bahadur Khan
Faizabad	Maulvi Ahmadullah Shah
Jagdishpur (Bihar)	Kunwar Singh

Centre	Leader
Allahabad	Liaquat Ali
Gwalior	Tatya Tope and Rani Lakshmibai, after seizing the fort in June 1858

Where the Revolt of 1857 took hold



Delhi, the Ganga plain and central India - the south stayed quiet

- Consequences - the East India Company was abolished and India passed to the Crown by the Government of India Act, 1858.
- A Secretary of State for India with a 15-member Council took charge; the Governor-General became Viceroy, Canning being the first.
- The army was reorganised - the proportion of European to Indian troops was raised and artillery kept in European hands.
- The Queen's Proclamation promised non-interference in religion and an end to further annexations.
- Bahadur Shah II was tried and exiled to Rangoon; the Mughal dynasty ended.

TRAP

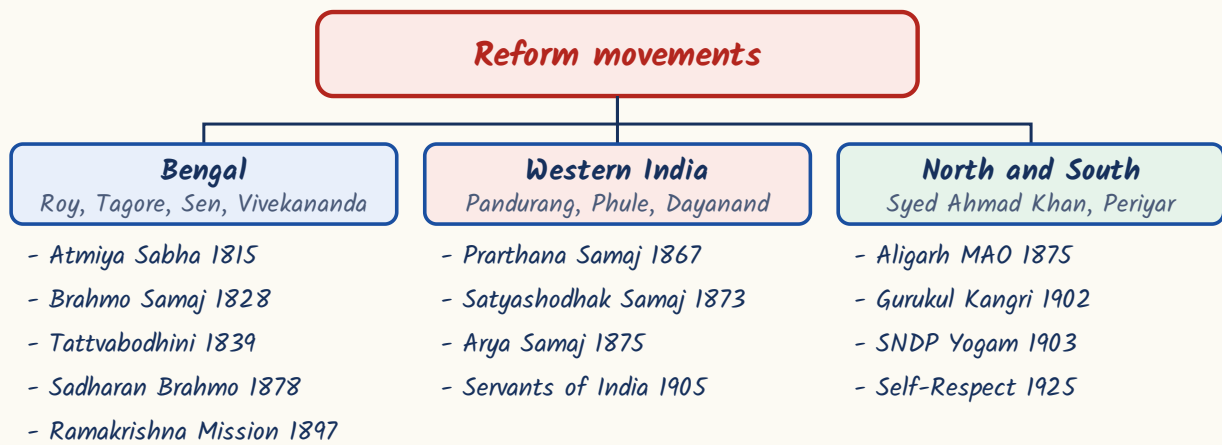
Gwalior-Begum Hazrat Mahal is the planted wrong pair. Hazrat Mahal led at Lucknow. At Gwalior it was Tatya Tope and Rani Lakshmibai in June 1858.

One more angle RPSC likes - what the revolt was called. V.D. Savarkar's 1909 book *The Indian War of Independence, 1857* first presented it as a planned national war. British writers called it a sepoy mutiny. In the centenary year S.N. Sen wrote *Eighteen Fifty-Seven* and R.C. Majumdar took the opposite view. For Rajasthan, remember that the revolt reached the state at Nasirabad on 28 May 1857 - the state-level detail sits in the Rajasthan history chapter, but the date is worth carrying here too.

Socio-religious reform - the founder-organisation-year table

Nineteenth-century reform is really two arguments. One is inside Hinduism - Rammohan Roy and the Brahmos want reason and one God, Dayanand wants a return to the Vedas, Vivekananda wants service. The other is against caste - Phule, Narayana Guru, Periyar and Ambedkar attack the structure itself. For the exam it becomes one thing: founder, organisation, year, place. Learn the table cold; RPSC asks it as a four-pair match nearly every cycle.

Socio-religious reform, region by region



Bengal, the Brahmo line and western India

Founder	Organisation	Year and place
Raja Rammohan Roy	Atmiya Sabha	1815, Calcutta
Raja Rammohan Roy	Brahmo Samaj	1828, Calcutta
Debendranath Tagore	Tattvabodhini Sabha	1839
Keshab Chandra Sen	Brahmo Samaj of India	1866
Split from Keshab's group	Sadharan Brahmo Samaj	1878
Atmaram Pandurang	Prarthana Samaj	1867, Bombay
Jyotiba Phule	Satyashodhak Samaj	1873
Gopal Krishna Gokhale	Servants of India Society	1905, Pune

- Rammohan Roy - published *Sambad Kaumudi* in Bengali and *Mirat-ul-Akhbar* in Persian; the title 'Raja' came from Mughal emperor Akbar II; he died at Bristol in 1833.
- Henry Louis Vivian Derozio taught at Hindu College, Calcutta (1826-31); his students were the Young Bengal or Derozians.
- Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar's campaign produced the Hindu Widows' Remarriage Act, Act XV of 1856.
- Kandukuri Veeresalingam performed the first widow remarriage in the Telugu country at Rajahmundry on 11 December 1881.
- Gokhale's Servants of India Society trained national missionaries; after his death in 1915 Srinivasa Sastri led it.

Arya Samaj, Aligarh and the anti-caste bodies

Founder	Organisation	Year and place
Dayanand Saraswati	Arya Samaj	10 April 1875, Bombay
Blavatsky and Colonel Olcott	Theosophical Society	1875, New York; Indian HQ at Adyar from 1882
Syed Ahmad Khan	Aligarh movement / MAO College	1875, Aligarh
Swami Vivekananda	Ramakrishna Mission	1 May 1897; Belur Math 1899
Swami Shraddhanand	Gurukul Kangri	1902, Haridwar
Narayana Guru	SNDP Yogam	1903, Kerala
E.V. Ramaswamy Naicker (Periyar)	Self-Respect Movement	1925
B.R. Ambedkar	Bahishkrit Hitakarini Sabha	1924

- Arya Samaj - slogan 'Back to the Vedas'; principal text Satyarth Prakash; launched the Shuddhi movement; DAV School, Lahore in 1886.
- Ambedkar's line of work: Mooknayak 1920, Bahishkrit Hitakarini Sabha 1924, Mahad Chavdar tank satyagraha 1927, Bahishkrit Bharat 1927, Kalaram temple entry 1930.
- Phule founded the Satyashodhak Samaj in 1873 to fight Brahminical dominance and to open education to the lower castes and to women.
- Vivekananda's Mission joined spiritual practice to social service - this phrasing appears in options.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2023 - the Ramakrishna Mission was founded in 1897 by Swami Vivekananda. Note the two dates: Mission 1897, Belur Math 1899.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2023 - the Servants of India Society, founded at Pune in 1905 to train national missionaries for the service of India, was set up by Gopal Krishna Gokhale.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2023 as a four-pair match: Satyashodhak Samaj - Jyotiba Phule; Theosophical Society - Blavatsky and Olcott; Aligarh movement - Syed Ahmad Khan; Self-Respect Movement - E.V. Ramaswamy Naicker.

Social legislation - the four Acts that get asked

Law	Year	Detail
Abolition of Sati	1829	Regulation XVII under Lord William Bentinck, after Rammohan Roy's campaign

Law	Year	Detail
Hindu Widows' Remarriage Act	1856	Act XV of 1856; Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar
Age of Consent Act	1891	Associated with Behramji Malabari
Child Marriage Restraint Act (Sarda Act)	1929	Girls 14, boys 18; named after Har Bilas Sarda; in force 1 April 1930

CURRENT LINK

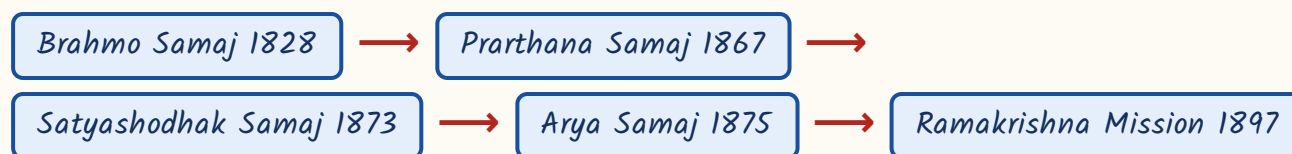
Current link, as of September 2026: 1875 is the anniversary year to keep in mind - the Arya Samaj (10 April 1875), the Theosophical Society (New York, 1875) and MAO College Aligarh (1875) all completed 150 years in 2025, and commemorative coverage of them ran through that year.

Separately, the Union government observed Janjatiya Gaurav Varsh from 15 November 2024 to 15 November 2025 for the 150th birth anniversary of Birsa Munda, whose Ulgulan against colonial land policy in Chotanagpur is the best-known tribal revolt of this period; 15 November is now observed every year as Janjatiya Gaurav Divas.

Exam-room drill - orders, firsts and the pairs they plant**ASKED IN RAS**

Asked in RAS Pre 2018 as a four-pair match: Prarthana Samaj - Atmaram Pandurang; SNDP Yogam - Narayana Guru; Gurukul Kangri - Swami Shraddhanand; Brahmo Samaj of India - Keshab Chandra Sen. Reform-institution-to-founder matching has now come in 2013, 2018 and 2023 - treat it as certain.

Chronological order of the reform bodies - asked as an ordering question



YAAD RAKHO

Five firsts worth one line each: first Governor-General of Bengal - Warren Hastings (1773); first Governor-General of India - Bentinck (1833); first Viceroy - Canning (1858); first state under Lapse - Satara (1848); first state to accept the Subsidiary Alliance - Hyderabad (1798).

- Theosophical Society was founded in New York, not in India; only the headquarters moved to Adyar in 1882.
- Arya Samaj was founded at Bombay, not at Lahore - Lahore is where the DAV School came up in 1886.
- Bahishkrit Bharat is Ambedkar's journal; do not let it be attached to Vivekananda in a NOT-matched question.
- Wandiwash 1760 broke the French, not the Marathas - the Maratha closure is Salbai 1782.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026: anniversary arithmetic is the simplest current-affairs hook in this chapter, and it is the one commemorative coverage follows. 2026 is the 170th year of the Hindu Widows' Remarriage Act, Act XV of 1856, the measure Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar carried; his own birth bicentenary was observed in 2020. It is also 170 years since the annexation of Awadh in 1856, the grievance that carried straight into the sepoy lines - and 2027 will be the 170th year of the Revolt of 1857 itself, so expect 1857 to stay in the paper for two cycles together.

REVISION RECAP

1. Plassey 23 June 1757 (Clive vs Siraj-ud-Daulah, Mir Jafar's betrayal); Buxar 22 Oct 1764 (Hector Munro); Diwani 12 Aug 1765 by the Treaty of Allahabad, pension Rs 26 lakh.
2. Dual Government 1765-72 was Clive's design; Warren Hastings abolished it in 1772.
3. Subsidiary Alliance - Wellesley; first Hyderabad 1798, then Awadh 1801, Peshwa 1802 (Bassein).
4. Doctrine of Lapse - Dalhousie; Satara 1848 first, Jhansi 1853, Nagpur 1854. Awadh 1856 was misgovernance, not lapse.
5. Permanent Settlement 1793 - Cornwallis with John Shore; Bengal-Bihar-Orissa; zamindar keeps 1/11th; Sunset Law; about 19 per cent of British India.
6. Ryotwari - Munro and Alexander Read, Madras 1820 and Bombay, settlement with the cultivator. Mahalwari - Holt Mackenzie 1822, revised 1833 by R.M. Bird under Bentinck, village as unit.
7. Drain of wealth - Dadabhai Naoroji, England's Debt to India 1867 and Poverty and Un-British Rule in India 1901; R.C. Dutt and Ranade complete the critique.
8. Charter Act 1813 ended the monopoly except tea and China; 1833 ended commercial functions and made Bentinck Governor-General of India; 1853 opened the civil service.
9. GOI Act 1858 - Company abolished, Secretary of State with a 15-member Council, Canning the first Viceroy.
10. Macaulay's Minute 2 Feb 1835 - English medium, downward filtration. Wood's Despatch 1854 - Magna Carta of English education; universities of Calcutta, Bombay, Madras in 1857. Hunter Commission 1882 under Ripon.
11. 1857 dates: Barrackpore 29 March, Meerut 10 May, Delhi 11 May; suppressed 8 July 1858; Queen's Proclamation at Allahabad 1 Nov 1858.
12. 1857 pairs: Delhi-Bakht Khan, Kanpur-Nana Saheb and Tatya Tope, Lucknow-Begum Hazrat Mahal, Jhansi-Lakshmibai, Bareilly-Khan Bahadur Khan, Faizabad-Maulvi Ahmadullah Shah, Jagdishpur-Kunwar Singh, Allahabad-Liaquat Ali.
13. Savarkar's 1909 book named 1857 the Indian War of Independence; Bahadur Shah II was exiled to Rangoon.
14. Brahmo line - Atmiya Sabha 1815, Brahmo Samaj 1828, Tattvabodhini 1839, Brahmo Samaj of India 1866, Sadharan Brahmo Samaj 1878.
15. 1875 is a crowded year - Arya Samaj (Bombay, 10 April), Theosophical Society (New York) and MAO College Aligarh.
16. Prarthana Samaj 1867 Atmaram Pandurang; Satyashodhak Samaj 1873 Phule; Ramakrishna Mission 1897 Vivekananda; Gurukul Kangri 1902 Shradhdhanand; SNDP Yogam 1903 Narayana Guru; Servants of India Society 1905 Gokhale; Self-Respect Movement 1925 Periyar.

17. Social laws - Sati banned by Regulation XVII of 1829 (Bentinck); Widow Remarriage Act XV of 1856 (Vidyasagar); Age of Consent Act 1891 (Malabari); Sarda Act 1929, girls 14 and boys 18.
18. Ambedkar - Mooknayak 1920, Bahishkrit Hitakarini Sabha 1924, Mahad satyagraha 1927, Bahishkrit Bharat 1927, Kalaram temple entry 1930.

IH10

Freedom Struggle (1885-1947) and Nation Building to 2000

Expect 3-5 questions a paper from this chapter alone. Documented repeats: Congress session-to-president matching (2023), the Nagpur session of 1920 (2018 and 2023), revolutionary conspiracy cases (2018, 2021), women in the freedom struggle (2021), Bharat Mata (2024) and the Mudaliar Commission (2024).

Sixty-two years of struggle and fifty-three years of nation building in one chapter. It is the largest single block of Indian History in the paper, and it is also the most predictable - Congress sessions and presidents, the three Acts, the four mass movements, the conspiracy cases, the women, and then the post-1947 checklist from integration to Pokhran.

Freedom struggle and after, 1885-2000

Moderates 1885-1905

- INC 28 Dec 1885, Bombay
- A.O. Hume, W.C. Bonnerjee
- Prayer, petition, protest
- Naoroji, Gokhale, Tyabji, Yule

Extremists and Swadeshi

- Partition of Bengal 1905
- Boycott and Swadeshi
- Lal-Bal-Pal, Aurobindo
- Surat split 1907, Muslim League 1906

Gandhi era

- Champaran 1917, Kheda 1918
- Rowlatt and Jallianwala 1919
- Non-Cooperation 1920-22
- Civil Disobedience 1930, Quit India 1942

Constitutional track

- Morley-Minto 1909
- Montagu-Chelmsford 1919
- Simon 1928, Nehru Report 1928
- GOI Act 1935

Revolutionaries

- Alipore 1908, Hardinge bomb 1912
- Ghadar 1913
- Kakori 1925, HSRA 1928
- Chittagong 1930, INA 1942-45

Endgame

- Cripps 1942, Quit India 1942
- Cabinet Mission 1946
- Mountbatten Plan 3 June 1947
- Independence Act 18 July 1947

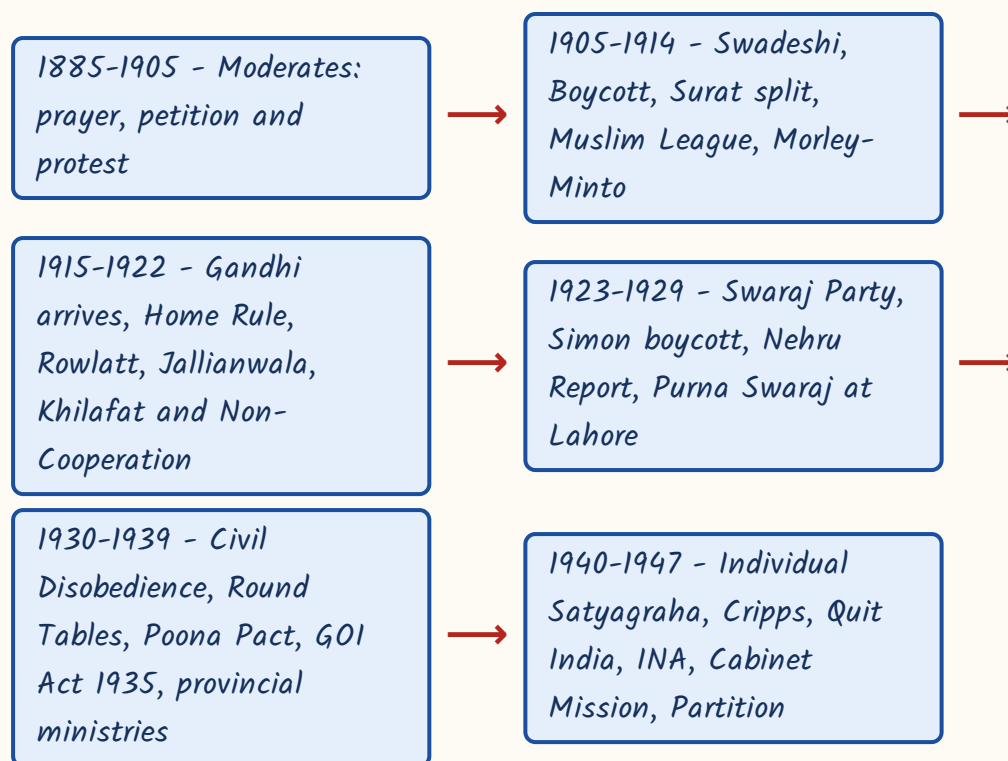
Nation building

- Integration - Patel and V.P. Menon
- SRC 1953-55, States Reorganisation 1956
- Plans, Green Revolution, wars
- Emergency 1975, LPG 1991, Pokhran 1974 & 1998

The spine - fix the decades before anything else

Before you learn a single date, fix the shape of the movement. Twenty years of petitioning, ten years of Swadeshi and split, then Gandhi arrives and the movement becomes a mass movement in three waves - 1920, 1930, 1942 - each separated by roughly a decade. Between the waves sit the constitutional milestones the British offered. If you can place a fact in the right decade, you can usually eliminate two options straight away.

Decade by decade, 1885 to 1947



YAAD RAKHO

Three mass movements, three anchor years - 1920, 1930, 1942. Non-Cooperation, Civil Disobedience, Quit India. Each is exactly twelve years apart from the next, and each ends the decade's argument.

The Congress is born - the Moderate phase, 1885-1905

The Congress began as a body of English-educated professionals who believed British rule could be reformed from within. Their method was prayer, petition and protest - resolutions, memoranda, deputations to London. Do not dismiss them; their economic critique of colonialism is what later leaders used. The examinable part is the session list: year, city, president.

- Founded 28 December 1885 at the Gokuldas Tejpal Sanskrit College, Bombay; 72 delegates; W.C. Bonnerjee president.
- A.O. Hume, a retired Bengal civil servant, was the moving spirit and long-serving General Secretary.
- The session was moved from Poona to Bombay because of a cholera outbreak.
- Moderate demands - more Indians in the legislative councils and the civil service, reduction of military spending, an end to the drain.
- Complete independence was NOT their goal; that came only at Lahore in 1929.

Early sessions - year, place, president

Year and place	President	Why it is remembered
1885, Bombay	W.C. Bonnerjee	First session, 72 delegates
1886, Calcutta	Dadabhai Naoroji	-
1887, Madras	Badrudin Tyabji	First Muslim president
1888, Allahabad	George Yule	First English president
1905, Benares	G.K. Gokhale	-
1906, Calcutta	Dadabhai Naoroji	Swaraj declared the goal of the Congress
1907, Surat	Rash Behari Ghosh	The Surat split
1916, Lucknow	Ambica Charan Mazumdar	Lucknow Pact; Moderates and Extremists reunite
1917, Calcutta	Annie Besant	First woman president of the Congress

Later sessions that matter

Year and place	President	Why it is remembered
1920, Nagpur	C. Vijayaraghavachariar	Non-Cooperation endorsed; new Congress constitution

Year and place	President	Why it is remembered
1924, Belgaum	M.K. Gandhi	The only Congress session Gandhi presided over
1925, Kanpur	Sarojini Naidu	First Indian woman president
1929, Lahore	Jawaharlal Nehru	Purna Swaraj resolution
1931, Karachi	Vallabhbhai Patel	Resolution on Fundamental Rights and the National Economic Programme
1938, Haripura	Subhas Chandra Bose	National Planning Committee set up
1939, Tripuri	Subhas Chandra Bose	Bose resigned soon after; Rajendra Prasad completed the term

ASKED IN RAS

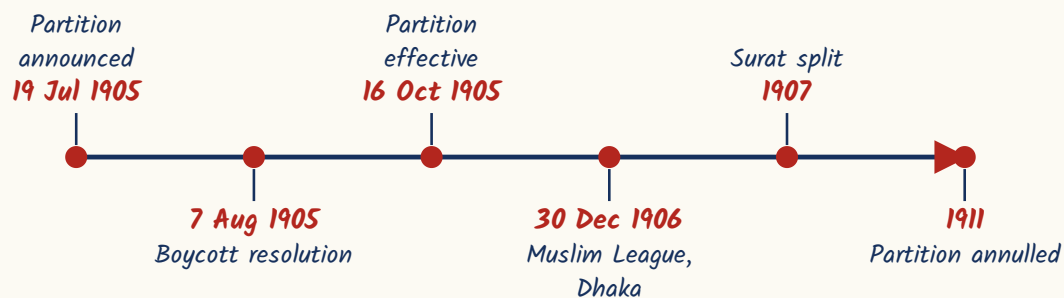
Asked in RAS Pre 2023 as a session-to-president match, and the pool is small: 1920 Nagpur - C. Vijayaraghavachariar; 1925 Kanpur - Sarojini Naidu; 1929 Lahore - Jawaharlal Nehru; 1931 Karachi - Vallabhbhai Patel. Learn these four plus Bonnerjee, Tyabji and Yule and you have covered every session RAS has used.

Swadeshi, the Surat split and the constitutional counter-offer

Curzon's partition of Bengal turned a debating society into a movement.

Announced on 19 July 1905 and effective from 16 October 1905, it was meant to split Bengali politics along religious lines. The answer was Swadeshi and Boycott - buy Indian, burn foreign cloth, build national schools. The British answered with two things: separate electorates in 1909, and a partial retreat in 1911 when the partition was annulled at the Delhi Durbar.

The Swadeshi years, 1905 to 1911



Moderates vs Extremists - the split that came at Surat in 1907

Moderates	Extremists
Dadabhai Naoroji, Gokhale, Pherozeshah Mehta, Surendranath Banerjea	Lal-Bal-Pal (Lajpat Rai, Tilak, Bipin Chandra Pal) and Aurobindo Ghosh
Faith in British sense of justice; reform within the empire	Swaraj as a right, to be taken not begged for
Method: prayer, petition, protest, constitutional agitation	Method: boycott, passive resistance, national education, swadeshi
Dominant 1885-1905	Dominant from 1905; split at Surat 1907; reunion at Lucknow 1916

- Boycott resolution passed at the Calcutta Town Hall on 7 August 1905.
- The Swadeshi programme had four limbs - boycott of foreign goods, swadeshi enterprise, national education and samitis such as Ashwini Kumar Dutt's Swadesh Bandhab Samiti at Barisal.
- All India Muslim League - 30 December 1906 at Dhaka, under Nawab Salimullah.
- Indian Councils Act (Morley-Minto) 1909 introduced separate electorates for Muslims; Minto is called the father of communal electorates.
- Lucknow Pact 1916 - Congress and League together, at the session presided over by Ambica Charan Mazumdar.
- Home Rule Leagues 1916 - Tilak's launched from Belgaum in April, Annie Besant's from Adyar, Madras, in September.

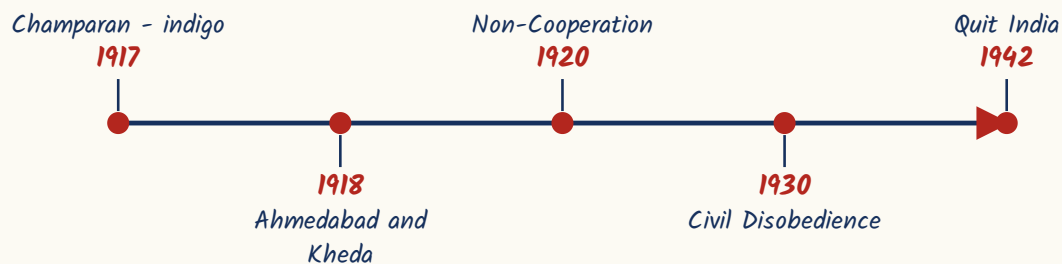
TRAP

Three dates on the partition of Bengal get shuffled: announced 19 July 1905, effective 16 October 1905, annulled at the Delhi Durbar of 1911 - when the capital also shifted from Calcutta to Delhi. And Bipin Chandra Pal is an Extremist; he is the planted answer in NOT-a-Moderate questions.

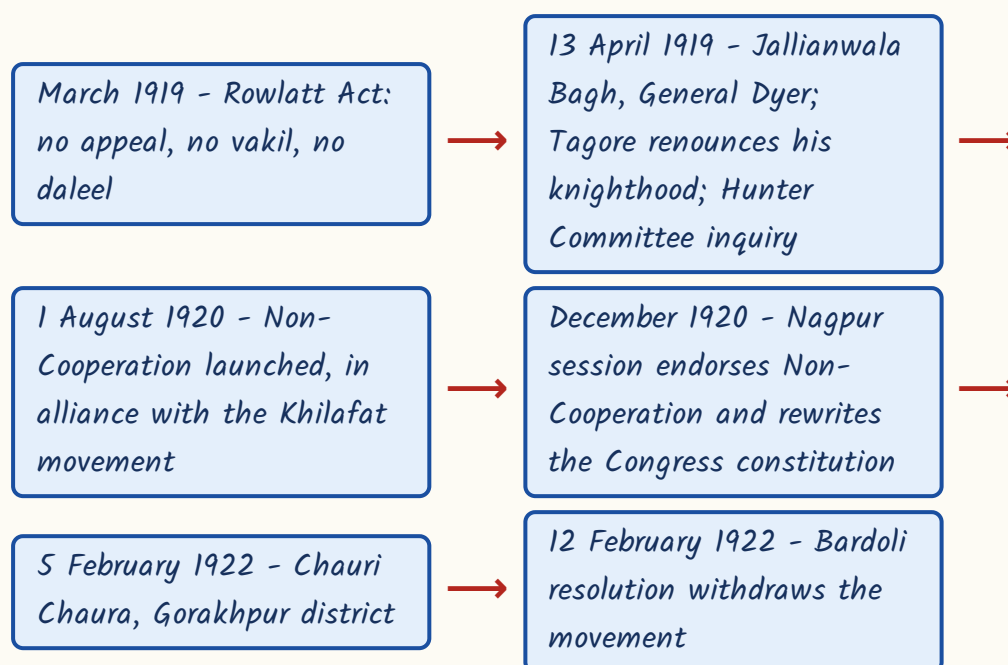
Gandhi takes over - 1917 to 1922

Gandhi tested satyagraha on three local issues first, and only then took the Congress. Champaran in 1917 was about the tinkathia system forced on indigo growers; Ahmedabad in 1918 was a mill workers' strike; Kheda in 1918 was a revenue remission for failed crops. Then came the Rowlatt Act, Jallianwala Bagh, and the alliance with the Khilafat leaders - and the Congress became a mass organisation.

Gandhi's satyagrahas, 1917 to 1942



From Rowlatt to Chauri Chaura



- Non-Cooperation programme - surrender of titles, boycott of courts, schools, councils and foreign cloth; national schools and panchayats instead.
- Nagpur, December 1920 - president C. Vijayaraghavachariar; a 15-member Working Committee created; provincial committees reorganised on a linguistic basis; membership fee cut to four annas.
- The four-anna fee is the detail that made the Congress a mass body - it is asked directly.
- After the withdrawal, C.R. Das (president) and Motilal Nehru (secretary) founded the Swaraj Party in 1923 to enter the councils and wreck them from within.
- Bardoli 1928 is a different event - Sardar Patel's no-tax satyagraha, which won him the title Sardar.

ASKED IN RAS

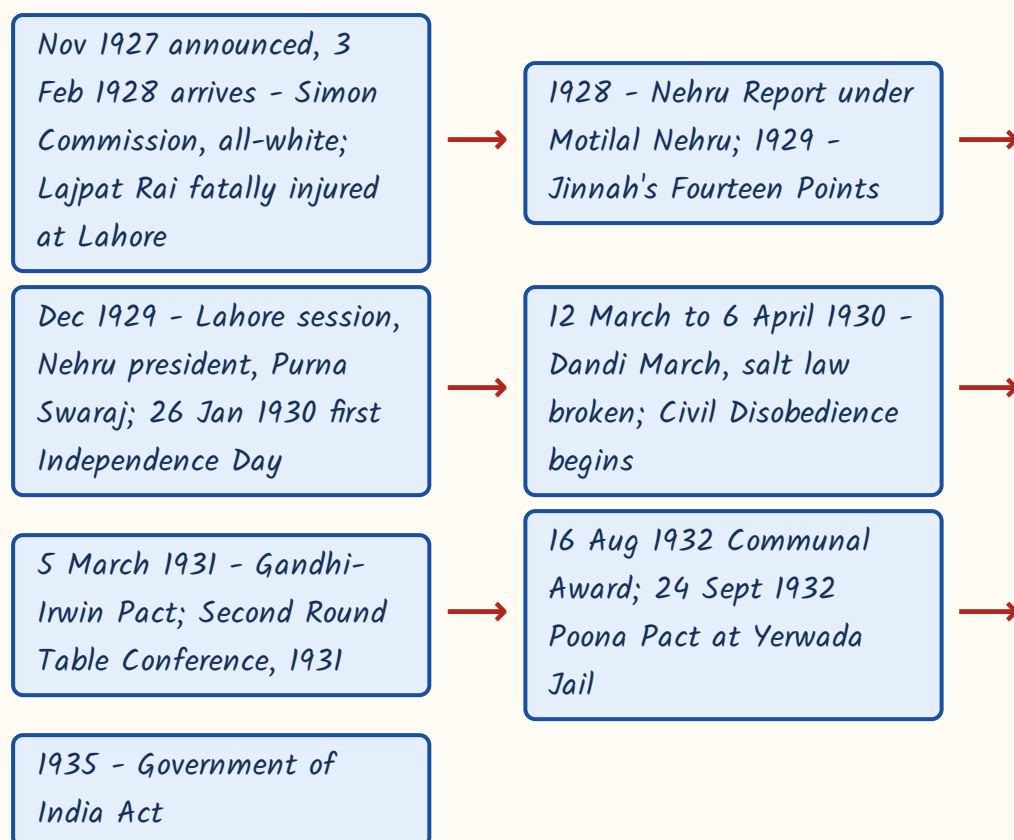
Asked in RAS Pre 2018 and again in 2023 - the Nagpur session of December 1920. All three of these statements are correct: it was presided over by C. Vijayaraghavachariar, it endorsed Non-Cooperation, and it gave the Congress a new constitution with a 15-member Working Committee and linguistic provincial committees.

One warning on names. Chauri Chaura, Bardoli resolution and Bardoli satyagraha are three different things and options mix them deliberately. Chauri Chaura, 5 February 1922 in Gorakhpur district, is the violence. The Bardoli resolution of 12 February 1922 is the withdrawal. The Bardoli satyagraha of 1928 is Sardar Patel's no-tax movement, six years later and unconnected.

Simon to the Act of 1935 - the constitutional decade

The 1919 Act had promised a review after ten years. The review came early, in the shape of an all-white Simon Commission, and the insult united everyone. From there the sequence is tight: Indians write their own constitution (Nehru Report), the Congress declares Purna Swaraj at Lahore, Gandhi picks salt as the symbol, and the British reply with three Round Table Conferences, a Communal Award, and finally the Act of 1935.

1927 to 1935 - the sequence RPSC asks in order



- Dandi - 12 March to 6 April 1930, from Sabarmati Ashram, 78 volunteers, about 385 km.
- Gandhi attended only the Second Round Table Conference, in 1931.
- Communal Award of Ramsay MacDonald gave the Depressed Classes separate electorates with 71 seats.
- Poona Pact replaced separate electorates with joint electorates and raised reserved seats in the provincial legislatures from 71 to 148.
- Karachi session 1931, president Vallabhbhai Patel - the resolution on Fundamental Rights and the National Economic Programme.

The three Acts - year to provision

Act	Year	Core provisions
Indian Councils Act (Morley-Minto)	1909	Separate electorates for Muslims; enlarged legislative councils; the beginning of communal representation
Government of India Act (Montagu-Chelmsford)	1919	Dyarchy in the provinces - subjects split into transferred and reserved; bicameral central legislature; a statutory commission after ten years
Government of India Act	1935	All-India Federation that never came into being; provincial autonomy replacing provincial dyarchy; dyarchy at the Centre; Federal Court in 1937; separation of Burma in 1937

TRAP

Dyarchy moves. In 1919 it is in the provinces; the 1935 Act abolishes it there, gives the provinces autonomy, and shifts dyarchy to the Centre. So provincial autonomy is 1935, never 1919 - that exact pair has been used as a NOT-a-provision question.

The revolutionaries - conspiracy cases are a documented repeat

Running under the Congress the whole time is a second, armed movement. For the exam it is a list of cases: an event, a year, and two or three names. RAS has asked this block in 2018 and again in 2021, usually as event-to-year matching, and it likes the Rajasthan connection wherever one exists.

Conspiracy cases and armed actions

Event	Year	Names to remember
Chapekar brothers, Poona	1897	Killing of Rand
Alipore Bomb Case	1908	Khudiram Bose and Prafulla Chaki, after the Muzaffarpur attempt
Delhi Conspiracy - Hardinge bomb	23 December 1912	Bomb thrown at Chandni Chowk by Basanta Kumar Biswas; planned by Rash Behari Bose
Ghadar Party, San Francisco	1913	Sohan Singh Bhakna, Lala Hardayal; the weekly Ghadar
Kakori Conspiracy	9 August 1925	Ram Prasad Bismil, Ashfaqullah Khan, Rajendra Lahiri, Roshan Singh - all hanged
HSRA formed	1928	Bhagat Singh, Chandrashekhar Azad and others
Central Assembly bomb	8 April 1929	Bhagat Singh and B.K. Dutt
Chittagong Armoury Raid	18 April 1930	Surya Sen
Bhagat Singh, Sukhdev, Rajguru hanged	23 March 1931	-

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2021 as an event-to-year match: Alipore Bomb Case 1908, Delhi Conspiracy (Hardinge bomb) 1912, Kakori Conspiracy 1925, Chittagong Armoury Raid 1930. Four events, four years - learn them as a block.

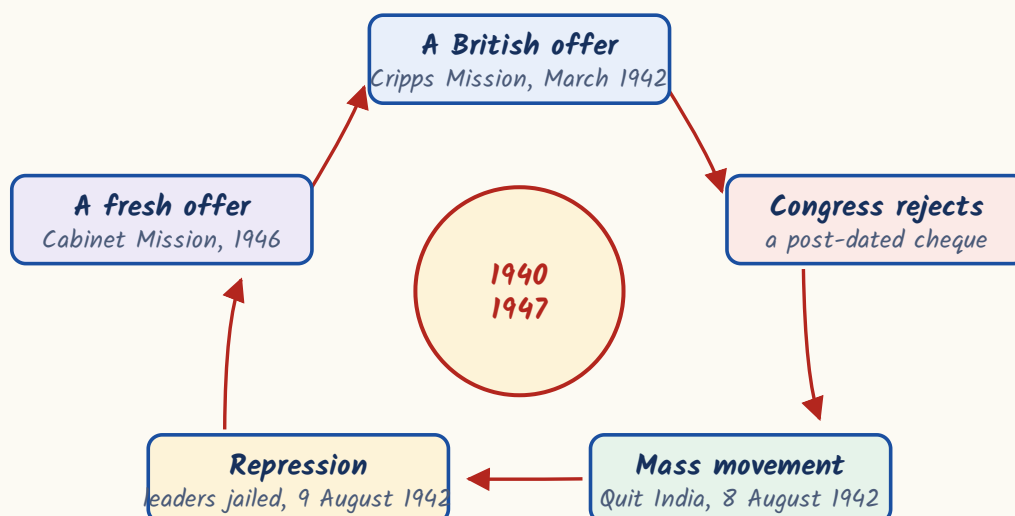
ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2021 - the Rajasthan angle. Kesari Singh Barhath of Shahpura was convicted in the Mahant Pyarelal murder case and jailed at Hazaribagh; his brother Jorawar Singh was linked to the Hardinge bomb plot of 23 December 1912, in which Basanta Kumar Biswas threw the bomb.

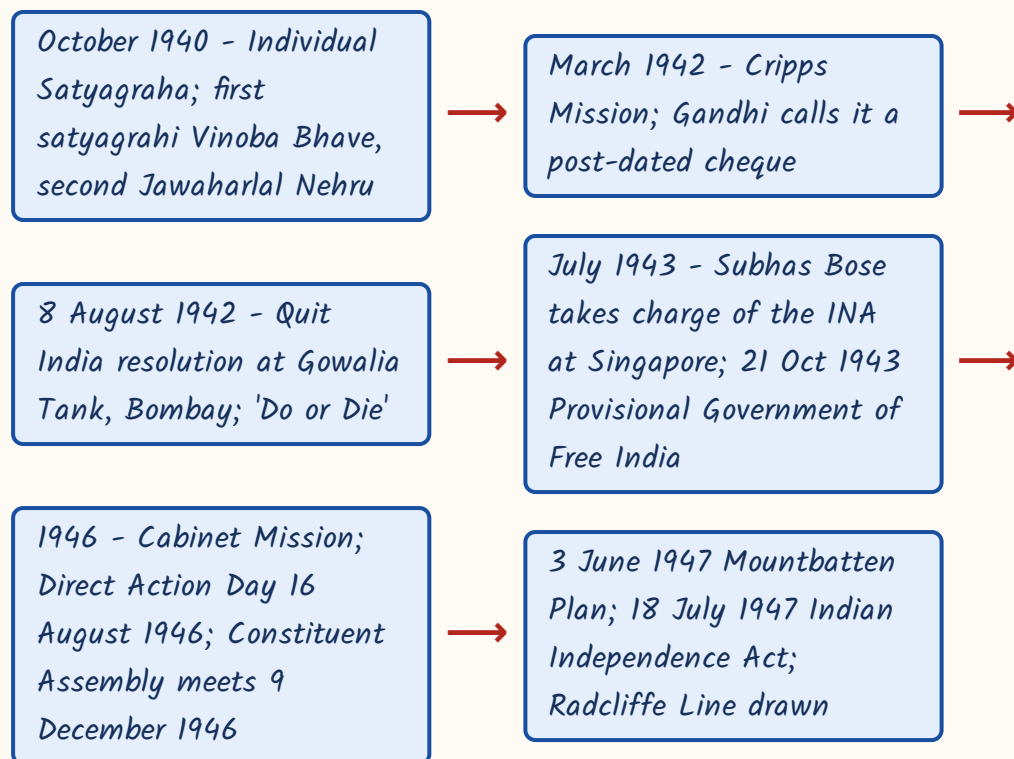
The endgame - 1939 to 1947

The war changed the arithmetic. Britain needed India, so the Congress could bargain; but Britain also jailed the entire leadership the moment it asked Britain to leave. Between 1940 and 1947 the pattern is offer, rejection, movement, offer again - Individual Satyagraha, Cripps, Quit India, the INA trials, Cabinet Mission, and finally partition on a timetable Mountbatten advanced by ten months.

The pattern of the war years



From Individual Satyagraha to Independence



- Quit India - the leadership was arrested on 9 August 1942; Aruna Asaf Ali hoisted the flag at Gowalia Tank.
- Parallel governments came up at Ballia, at Tamluk in Bengal and at Satara.
- INA - first raised in 1942 under Captain Mohan Singh; the Rani Jhansi Regiment was led by Lakshmi Sahgal.
- Cabinet Mission 1946 - Pethick-Lawrence, Stafford Cripps and A.V. Alexander; it rejected Pakistan and proposed a grouping of provinces.
- The Radcliffe Line demarcated the boundary with Pakistan; the Constituent Assembly first met on 9 December 1946.

TRAP

Lord Wavell was the Viceroy who hosted the Cabinet Mission - he was not a member of it. The three members are Pethick-Lawrence (head), Cripps and Alexander. This is a favourite NOT-a-member question.

Women in the freedom struggle, and the culture of nationalism

RAS has asked this as a dedicated four-pair match, so give it its own table rather than scattering the names. The pattern is that each woman is tied to one place and one event - Gowalia Tank, Gohpur, Tamluk, Odisha. Learn the pairing, not the biography.

Woman to event - the 2021 match

Name	Associated with	Detail
Sarojini Naidu	First Indian woman president of the Congress	Kanpur session, 1925
Aruna Asaf Ali	Hoisted the Congress flag at Gowalia Tank, 1942	Quit India
Kanaklata Barua	Shot dead at Gohpur, Assam, 20 September 1942	Aged 17, leading the Mrityu Bahini; honoured as Birangana
Matangini Hazra	Killed at Tamluk, Bengal, 1942	Quit India
Rama Devi	Salt Satyagraha in Odisha	Called 'Maa'; later joined the Bhoodan movement
Annie Besant	Home Rule League and Congress president 1917	First woman to preside over the Congress
Lakshmi Sahgal	Rani Jhansi Regiment of the INA	-

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2021 - Kanaklata Barua, shot while leading a procession to hoist the flag at the Gohpur police station in 1942, belonged to Assam. The same paper carried the woman-to-event four-pair match. Women in the freedom struggle is now a standing item.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 - the painting *Bharat Mata*, the defining image of the Swadeshi movement, was made in 1905 by Abanindranath Tagore. It was first titled *Banga Mata*, and the figure holds a book, sheaves of paddy, a piece of white cloth and a rudraksha mala - the four objects are themselves examinable.

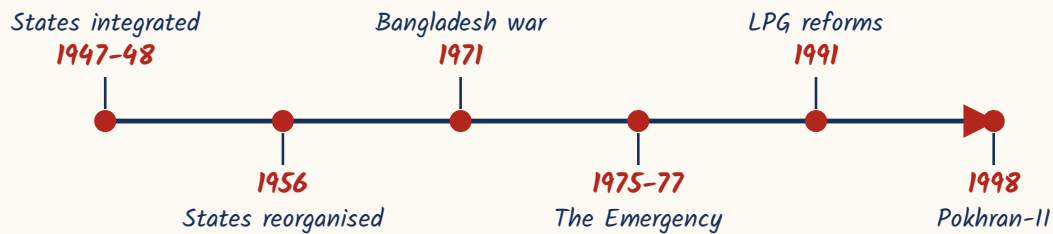
CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026: the Union government launched a year-long nationwide commemoration of 150 years of the national song *Vande Mataram* on 7 November 2025, which runs into November 2026 - directly into this exam cycle. Anchor facts: Bankim Chandra Chatterjee wrote it in 1875, it appeared in his novel *Anandamath* in 1882, and it was first sung at the Calcutta session of the Congress in 1896.

Nation building, 1947 to 2000 - the post-independence checklist

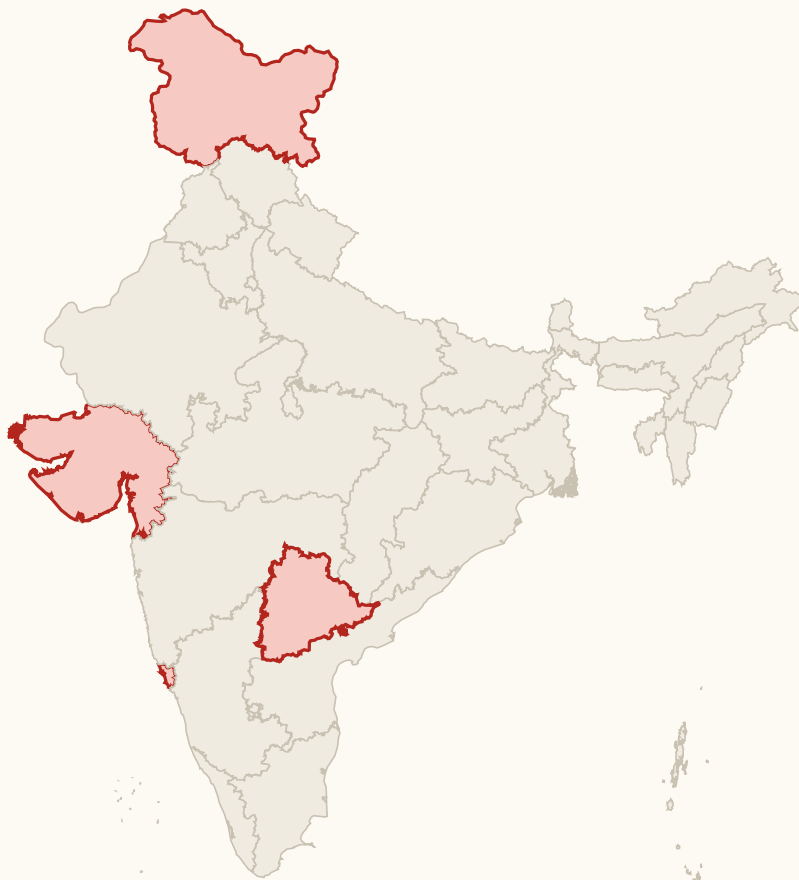
The syllabus does not stop in 1947, and candidates routinely do. Treat the next fifty years as six small blocks - integration, reorganisation, planning, wars, the political shocks of 1975 to 1991, and the education commissions. Each block is a short table. That is all that is ever asked.

Nation building, 1947 to 2000



- The States Department was created in July 1947 under Sardar Patel, with V.P. Menon as Secretary.
- Of roughly 562 princely states, all but three acceded before 15 August 1947 through the Instrument of Accession.
- Junagadh - settled by a plebiscite in February 1948.
- Hyderabad - the police action Operation Polo, 13-18 September 1948.
- Jammu and Kashmir - Maharaja Hari Singh signed the Instrument of Accession on 26 October 1947, after the tribal invasion.
- Goa - liberated from Portuguese rule by Operation Vijay in December 1961.

The states that did not accede easily



Junagadh in Gujarat, Hyderabad around Telangana, Kashmir 1947, Goa 1961

- Potti Sriramulu's fast to death produced Andhra State on 1 October 1953 - the first state formed on a linguistic basis.
- Fazl Ali Commission (States Reorganisation Commission) appointed December 1953, members H.N. Kunzru and K.M. Panikkar, reported 30 September 1955.
- The States Reorganisation Act, 1956 created 14 states and 6 union territories - Rajasthan took its present shape on 1 November 1956.
- Learn the trio: Sriramulu 1953, Fazl Ali 1953-55, Act 1956.

Five Year Plans - the ones that get asked

Plan	Years	Model or theme
First	1951-56	Harrod-Domar model; agriculture and irrigation
Second	1956-61	Mahalanobis model; heavy industry

Plan	Years	Model or theme
Third	1961-66	Self-reliant economy; wrecked by war and drought
Plan Holiday	1966-69	Three annual plans after the Third Plan failed, the 1965 war and successive droughts; rupee devalued in June 1966
Fourth	1969-74	Growth with stability
Fifth	1974-79	Garibi Hatao; ended a year early
Rolling Plan	1978-80	Janata government
Sixth to Eighth	1980-85, 1985-90, 1992-97	Eighth Plan is the LPG plan

- Green Revolution - IADP launched in 1960-61 in seven districts, including Pali in Rajasthan, with Ford Foundation support.
- High Yielding Varieties Programme 1966-67; Norman Borlaug's dwarf wheat; M.S. Swaminathan is called the father of the Green Revolution in India.
- The gains stayed with wheat and with irrigated regions, which widened regional disparity - this critique is asked as a statement.
- Verghese Kurien belongs to the White Revolution, not the Green - a standard swap in options.

Wars and the accords that closed them

Conflict	Year	Outcome
Sino-Indian War	October-November 1962	-
Indo-Pak War	1965	Tashkent Declaration, 10 January 1966; Shastri died in Tashkent that night
Bangladesh Liberation War	1971	Shimla Agreement, 2 July 1972
Kargil conflict	1999	Operation Vijay

- Emergency - proclaimed 25 June 1975 under Article 352 on the ground of internal disturbance; it ran to 21 March 1977.
- The trigger was the Allahabad High Court verdict of 12 June 1975 in the Raj Narain case.
- 42nd Amendment 1976 during the Emergency; Shah Commission 1977 inquired into it.
- 44th Amendment 1978 replaced internal disturbance with armed rebellion as a ground.
- Mandal Commission - appointed 1979 under B.P. Mandal, reported December 1980.
- It identified 3,743 backward castes and recommended 27 per cent reservation.
- Implemented by V.P. Singh in 1990 and upheld in Indra Sawhney (1992).
- 1991 reforms - P.V. Narasimha Rao as PM, Manmohan Singh as Finance Minister.
- Rupee devalued in two steps in July 1991; Narasimham Committee on banking reform.
- New Industrial Policy, 24 July 1991 - licensing abolished for most industries; reserved public-sector industries cut from 17 to 8.
- Pokhran-I, 18 May 1974, code-named Smiling Buddha - officially a peaceful nuclear explosion.
- Pokhran-II, Operation Shakti - five devices on 11 and 13 May 1998.

Education and reorganisation commissions - a 2024 match

Commission	Years	Chairman and key recommendation
University Education Commission	1948-49	S. Radhakrishnan
Secondary Education Commission	appointed 23 September 1952	A. Lakshmanaswami Mudaliar, Vice-Chancellor of Madras University; multipurpose schools, diversified courses, three-year degree

Commission	Years	Chairman and key recommendation
Education Commission	1964-66	D.S. Kothari, secretary J.P. Naik; 10+2+3 pattern and 6 per cent of GDP on education; report titled <i>Education and National Development</i>
States Reorganisation Commission	1953-55	Fazl Ali
National Policy on Education	1968 and 1986	Followed the Kothari report

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024, twice over - once directly (the commission headed by Dr A. Lakshmanaswami Mudaliar, appointed in September 1952, was the Secondary Education Commission) and once as a four-pair match of commission to chairman. Radhakrishnan-Mudaliar-Kothari-Fazl Ali is the set. Memorise it as a chant.

TRAP

Operation Vijay is used twice in this chapter - the liberation of Goa in December 1961 and the Kargil conflict of 1999. Hyderabad's action is Operation Polo, September 1948. And Pokhran-II is 1998, not 1996 - that wrong year has already appeared as an option.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026: three round anniversaries sit inside this exam cycle. The States Reorganisation Act, 1956 completes seventy years in 2026, and so does Rajasthan in its present shape, dated 1 November 1956 - which makes 1 November 2026 a state-level commemoration RPSC can hang a question on. The Emergency completed fifty years on 25 June 2025; since 2024 the Union government has observed 25 June as Samvidhaan Hatya Diwas. And the 1991 reforms complete thirty-five years in July 2026 - P.V. Narasimha Rao as Prime Minister, Manmohan Singh as Finance Minister, and the New Industrial Policy of 24 July 1991.

REVISION RECAP

1. INC founded 28 Dec 1885, Gokuldas Tejpal Sanskrit College, Bombay; 72 delegates; W.C. Bonnerjee president; A.O. Hume the moving spirit.
2. Presidential firsts - Badruddin Tyabji 1887 (first Muslim), George Yule 1888 (first Englishman), Annie Besant 1917 (first woman), Sarojini Naidu 1925 Kanpur (first Indian woman).
3. Partition of Bengal announced 19 July 1905, effective 16 Oct 1905, annulled 1911; Boycott resolution at Calcutta Town Hall 7 Aug 1905; Swaraj declared the goal at Calcutta 1906; Surat split 1907.
4. Muslim League 30 Dec 1906 at Dhaka under Nawab Salimullah; separate electorates by the Act of 1909; Lucknow Pact 1916.
5. Home Rule 1916 - Tilak from Belgaum in April, Besant from Adyar in September.
6. Gandhi's first satyagrahas - Champaran 1917 (tinkathia), Ahmedabad and Kheda 1918; Bardoli no-tax satyagraha 1928 under Patel.
7. Rowlatt Act March 1919, Jallianwala Bagh 13 April 1919 (Dyer, Hunter Committee, Tagore's knighthood); Non-Cooperation from 1 Aug 1920; Chauri Chaura 5 Feb 1922; withdrawn by the Bardoli resolution 12 Feb 1922.
8. Nagpur 1920 - C. Vijayaraghavachariar; 15-member Working Committee, linguistic provincial committees, four-anna membership. Swaraj Party 1923 - C.R. Das and Motilal Nehru.
9. Simon announced Nov 1927, arrived 3 Feb 1928; Nehru Report 1928; Lahore Dec 1929 Purna Swaraj; 26 Jan 1930 first Independence Day.
10. Dandi 12 March to 6 April 1930, 78 volunteers, about 385 km; Gandhi-Irwin Pact 5 March 1931; Gandhi attended only the Second Round Table Conference.

11. Communal Award 16 Aug 1932; Poona Pact 24 Sept 1932 at Yerwada - reserved seats raised from 71 to 148 with joint electorates.
12. Acts - 1909 separate electorates; 1919 dyarchy in provinces; 1935 provincial autonomy, dyarchy at the Centre, Federal Court 1937, Burma separated 1937.
13. Conspiracy cases - Alipore 1908, Hardinge bomb 23 Dec 1912 (Basanta Kumar Biswas, planned by Rash Behari Bose), Ghadar 1913 San Francisco, Kakori 9 Aug 1925, HSRA 1928, Chittagong 18 April 1930.
14. Quit India 8 Aug 1942 at Gowalia Tank, 'Do or Die', Aruna Asaf Ali hoisted the flag; parallel governments at Ballia, Tamluk and Satara.
15. INA 1942 under Mohan Singh; Bose at Singapore July 1943 and the Provisional Government 21 Oct 1943; Rani Jhansi Regiment under Lakshmi Sahgal.
16. Cabinet Mission 1946 - Pethick-Lawrence, Cripps, Alexander (Wavell was Viceroy, not a member); Mountbatten Plan 3 June 1947; Independence Act 18 July 1947.
17. Integration - States Department July 1947 under Patel with V.P. Menon; Junagadh plebiscite Feb 1948, Hyderabad Operation Polo Sept 1948, J&K accession 26 Oct 1947, Goa Operation Vijay Dec 1961.
18. Andhra 1 Oct 1953 first linguistic state; Fazl Ali Commission 1953-55; States Reorganisation Act 1956 - 14 states, 6 union territories.
19. Emergency 25 June 1975 to 21 March 1977 under Article 352; Mandal 1979-80, implemented 1990; reforms of July 1991 under Rao and Manmohan Singh; Pokhran-I 18 May 1974 (Smiling Buddha), Pokhran-II 11 and 13 May 1998 (Operation Shakti).
20. Commissions - Radhakrishnan 1948-49, Mudaliar 1952-53, Kothari 1964-66 (10+2+3, 6 per cent of GDP), Fazl Ali for states.